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Business as Usual

By EP UNNY

**19 months after Manmohan Singh's death, he gets clean chit in coal case**

Ex-PM Manmohan Singh was summoned to face trial in 2015.

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 29

MORE THAN a decade after a trial court summoned former Prime Minister Manmohan Singh in the coal block allocation case, the Supreme Court on Wednesday set aside the order and accepted the Central Bureau of Investigation's (CBI) closure report which cleared him in the matter.

Saying that the trial court had no justification for rejecting the CBI's closure report, a three-judge bench led by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant closed the proceedings.

While Singh died in December 2024, Senior Advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for the former PM, said though the matter had become infructuous after his death, the trial court's remarks against him ought to be expunged. Senior Advocate AM Singhvi, also representing Singh, urged the court to do away with the remarks.

The bench, which included

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

STRINGENT PROVISIONS IN AMENDED LEGISLATION

Tough exam leak Bill clears LS, Rahul raises police crackdown

Govt hails passage, says open to learn from experience; LoP: Shah must quit over July 20 action

Asad Rehman, Anonna Dutt & Jatin Anand
New Delhi, July 29

WRAPPING UP a two-day debate punctuated by acrimonious exchanges as the Opposition slammed the government over the police crackdown on student protesters in Delhi, Lok Sabha Wednesday passed the stringent Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026 by a voice vote amid sloganeering.

Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi's remarks against Union Home Minister Amit Shah over the July 20 police action led to stormy scenes with



Union Minister Kiren Rijiju and LoP Rahul Gandhi in Lok Sabha. PTI

**POLITICS PAGE 6****RAJYA SABHA PASSES BILL MAKING INSULT TO VANDE MATARAM A CRIMINAL OFFENCE**

strong protests from the treasury benches — one of the words he used was expunged from House records.

Later, the government

hailed the passage of the Bill. Union Minister Jitendra Singh, who replied to the debate, said it reflected the government's "openness to incorporate constructive inputs, learn from experience and further strengthen the law" to deal with exam paper leaks.

Shah, in a post on X, congratulated "every student in India" on the passage of the Bill, saying it "shields the dreams

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

CHARGESHEET FILED IN FAST-TRACK COURT

Leaked NEET papers took two routes out of Maharashtra: CBI probe

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, July 29

PROBING THE NEET-UG 2026 paper leak case, the CBI has uncovered two messaging app trails — a Maharashtra-Rajasthan-Haryana route and a Maharashtra-Rajasthan-Kerala pathway — through which the question papers travelled.

Investigators are calling it a "countrywide conspiracy" involving subject experts, coaching institute operators and intermediaries, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

In a chargesheet filed Tuesday in a Delhi fast-track court, the CBI has named 13 accused

including NTA biology expert Manisha Mandhare, NTA chemistry expert Pralhad Vithalrao Kulkarni, NTA physics expert Manisha Sanjay Havaldar.

The others named are Shivrak Raghunath Moteogankar, owner of Renukai Career Centre Coaching Institute in Latur; Tejas Harshadkumar Shah, COO at APMA Coaching Institute in Pune, and eight alleged intermediaries: Manisha Sanjay Waghmare, Dhananjay Nivrutti Lokhande, Shubham Madhukar Khairnar, Yash Yadav, Mangilal Biwal, Vikash Biwal, Dinesh Biwal and

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

INSIDE PAGES 5.8**AMID FARMERS' PROTEST, SHIVRAJ VS MP GOVT OVER PROCUREMENT****BENGAL GOVT TO GIVE EGGS WITH MID-DAY MEALS FROM ISKCON**

28-year-old Gulveer Singh during the men's 10,000 m final at Commonwealth Games in Glasgow. AP

From Sirsa mud ground to India's first CWG men's 10,000m silver

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, July 29

PELTING RAIN, chilly conditions and a field of runners from Africa with a podium-finishing history spanning over 50 years — India's Gulveer Singh was up against the weather, sporting history and a quality field at the

Commonwealth Games.

Yet, the 28-year-old from Sirsa in UP's Aligarh held his nerve, stuck to his race strategy and produced an impressive final burst to win silver, marking India's first-ever Commonwealth Games medal in the men's 10,000m with a time of 27 minutes and 49.80 seconds.

Gulveer had, in fact, fallen behind during the race but fought back to snap at the heels of the leading pack before surging forward. Ky Robinson of Australia won gold in 27:48.93, while David Mullarkey of the Isle of Man took bronze in 27:50.28.

The result also ended

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

3 lured to Thailand with holiday trip, held for ransom; 5 Indians arrested

Divya A
New Delhi, July 29

THREE YOUTHS, all in their early 20s, were allegedly lured to Pattaya in Thailand through what was advertised as a low-cost seven-day holiday package, held captive and tortured for five days while ransom calls were made to their families in India — before they were rescued by police on Monday.

Their alleged kidnappers,

also Indians, were arrested from Bangkok the next day while they were preparing to flee the country, according to local media reports.

The five suspects — identified as Avtar Singh (38), Jagjit Singh (38), Rambalak Kumar (24), Sukhbir Singh (37) and Kulra Singh (27) — were arrested from a hotel in Khlong Tan area of Bangkok on Tuesday while they were waiting to board an outbound flight, the

Bangkok Post reported, citing the police.

While the suspects have reportedly admitted to the charges, they have claimed that a Pakistani national, who they were in contact with via a chat app over the past month, ordered them to kidnap the three Indians. The alleged mastermind is reportedly based in Dubai and had planned to receive ransom payment in

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

● **CASE AGAINST KAPIL SANGWAN RELATES TO HIS ALLEGED ROLE IN RUNNING AN EXTORTION SYNDICATE**

In a first, trial in absentia begins today in Delhi against absconding gangster

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, July 29

IN A first, a Delhi court will start hearing arguments Thursday against Kapil Sangwan, a gangster accused in two cases under the Maharashtra Control of Organisations Crime Act (MCOCA), in absentia — or, in his absence. Sangwan has been declared absconding and is believed to be in London.

In an order issued on July 9, Special Judge Vishal Gogne of Rouse Avenue Court permitted the trial to proceed in "absen-

ROAD TO TRIAL

KAPIL SANGWAN, an accused in two cases under MCOCA, has been absconding since 2019. He is believed to be in London.

SANGWAN WAS declared a proclaimed offender in May 2025.

TWO NON-bailable warrants were issued against him by Rouse Avenue court against him but they



Rouse Avenue Court in Delhi.

could not be executed since his house was found to be "locked".

ON JULY 9, Special Judge Vishal Gogne of Rouse Avenue Court permitted the trial to proceed in absentia under BNSS Section 356 (inquiry, trial or judgment in absentia of a proclaimed offender)

tia" under Section 356 (Inquiry, trial or judgment in absentia of proclaimed offender) of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS).

The trial pertains to one of the two MCOCA cases against Sangwan, related to his alleged role in running an extortion syndicate.

According to new norms, a person accused of a crime can be tried and convicted in his absence, as if he was present in court and has waived his right to a fair trial. Earlier, the Code

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Har Pal Aapke Saath

Karnataka HC slams Civil Judge involved in road rage incident, halts probe against 2

Express News Service
Bengaluru, July 29

THE KARNATAKA High Court on Wednesday came down heavily on a Principal Civil Judge who indulged in a squabble with two persons riding a two-wheeler and got the police to take criminal action against them. The High Court also stayed further investigation in the case.

Justice M Nagaprasanna saw the CCTV camera footage, showing Principal Civil Judge and JMFC, Gayatri, getting into a verbal spat with petitioners Vinya K M and V Kavita. “The video would clearly indicate that the judicial officer has behaved in a manner totally unbecoming of the office that she holds,” the court said.

The bench said: “Judicial office is a continuation of public trust, it is not only inside the courtroom, but it is behaviour outside the courtroom that would erode the confidence of the public or sustain the confidence. Every act of judicial officer is discharge of official duties and is not confined to the four walls of the court hall but travels beyond the court hall when the interaction happens with the public.”

The petitioners approached the court seeking to quash the case against them, contending that they overtook the private vehicle of the complainant (Civil Judge) who was travelling with her husband. The petitioners alleged that the complainant chased down their two-wheeler, stopped them and got into a squabble. The judicial officer then informed

the police and lodged a complaint against the petitioners under sections 126(2), 132, 3(5), 351(2), 352, 74 of the Bharatiya Nyay Samhitha. The offences alleged were wrongful restraint, criminal intimidation and others.

The bench in its order said: “It is surprising as to how, for the offences so laid against the petitioners, they were taken into custody. Merely because the complainant was a judicial officer, it would not mean that citizens are treated at the dictate of the judicial officer.”

Remarking about the incident, the court said, “If this has enraged or hurt the ego of the judicial officer, nothing more can become a classic illustration of abuse of the office of the judicial officer; therefore there shall be an interim order of stay of further investigation against the petitioners.”

The bench in its order also directed the Registrar to place the interim order passed before the Chief Justice of the High Court for further action against Gayatri. On the other hand, Bengaluru Advocates’ Association (ABB) has demanded action against the Civil Judge over allegations that she abused her official position and got a youth assaulted following a road rage incident.

In a letter to Karnataka High Court Justice S R Krishnakumar, the ABB has sought suspension of the judicial officer. The letter came after she allegedly summoned police to the spot and to detain a student following a road rage incident. The video of the incident went viral.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Tough exam leak Bill clears LS

and aspirations of our youth by laying down iron-clad provisions imposing the harshest punishment on those who dare to breach the sanctity of public examinations”. The Modi government, he said, “will spare no one who attempts to imperil the future of our students and will leave no stone unturned to ensure that they face the full wrath of the law”.

Speaking to the press after the day’s proceedings, Gandhi demanded Shah’s resignation and a Supreme Court-monitored probe into the “brutalities” against the students. He said he was not allowed to speak in Lok Sabha, that every time he tried to speak in the House, he was “silenced”.

BJP national spokesperson Sambit Patra accused Gandhi of trying to “mislead the country with his lies”, of creating a ruckus in the House and using unparliamentary words. “He alleged he was not given a chance to speak... When 45 people were given a chance to speak, why would Rahul Gandhi not be given a chance to speak?” he said.

“Rahul Gandhi has divided the country’s students into three categories, and this is an insult to the students. We clearly state that all students of this country are desh bhakts (patriots); no student of this country is an idiot or an andhbhakt (blind follower),” Patra said.

Earlier, while participating in the debate, Gandhi accused Shah of “ordering police action” against students during the July 20 protests in Delhi.

Objecting to the remarks, Union Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju demanded that Gandhi substantiate Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBdOf>

ate his allegations and apologise to the House.

“You are the Leader of the Opposition. Speak with seriousness. On what basis did you make this statement? How can he say that someone ordered firing? It is a breach of his own position and privilege,” Rijiju said.

Speaker Om Birla also intervened, urging Gandhi to make statements based on facts and maintain the dignity of the House. He also said that some of Gandhi’s remarks will be expunged from House records.

When the treasury benches demanded that Gandhi apologise, Opposition members rallied behind him, saying “Rahul ji ko bolne do (let Rahul speak)”, leading to noisy scenes.

Gandhi said the protesting students had shown courage. “The students of the country are saying we will not become andhbhakts (blind followers). This is a beautiful expression. Their parents perhaps did not have the courage to face the BJP and the RSS. Yet these children, brave, imaginative and powerful, stood there and faced whatever you threw at them,” he said.

Targeting Dharmendra Pradhan who resigned as Education Minister last week, Gandhi said, “Rainath Singhji said we are not the UPA and our ministers never resign. He is right. The resignation of Pradhan is superficial because he never ran the education system. The Education Ministry is run by the RSS. The man who runs it is the OSD sitting in the minister’s office.”

Speaking to reporters outside the House, Gandhi said there can be just “two options” — one that the Home Minister “gave the orders” (for action against students), and second that the “Home Minister didn’t

know that firing will happen”. He also asked why Shah had not been coming to the House.

Jitendra Singh, while replying to the debate on the Bill, also spoke of the “unparliamentary language” used by Gandhi. “I am surprised that the LoP doesn’t know the basic parliamentary norms,” he said.

Singh said the LoP did not seem to know that any order to fire a gun is given by a magistrate. “It has been clarified that shots were never fired, tear gas was used. When the gun was not fired, the question of who gave the order does not arise,” he said.

He said the amendments would further strengthen the legal framework to prevent unfair means in public examinations and safeguard the interests of students and youth. The government, he said, remained committed to ensuring the integrity, transparency and credibility of the public examination system.

Highlighting the key provisions of the Bill, Singh said the punishment for persons resorting to unfair means has been enhanced from imprisonment of three to five years to five to ten years, while the maximum fine has been increased from Rs 10 lakh to Rs 50 lakh.

For service providers involved in such offences, the maximum fine has been enhanced from Rs 1 crore to Rs 5 crore and the period of debarment from conducting public examinations has been increased from four years to eight years. The Bill further enhances punishment for organised crime from five to ten years’ imprisonment to seven to ten years and increases the maximum fine from Rs 1 crore to Rs 10 crore.

Retrospective green nod

Justice Ujjal Bhuyan, in Vana-shakti vs Union of India, struck down a 2017 notification enabling retrospective environmental clearance and the subsequent 2021 office memorandum which laid down the Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) for such clearances.

However, on November 18, 2025, the Supreme Court, citing public interest and legal flaws, recalled the May 16 ruling. It was a 2-1 verdict. The then Chief Justice of India B R Gavai and Justice K Vinod Chandran backed the recall while Justice Bhuyan dissented saying the majority decision “overlooks the very fundamentals of environmental jurisprudence” and “is a step in retrogression”.

Ruling on review petitions, the three-judge bench led by Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2rVd_RGf9mljMz6l

sible in law,” the bench said.

“Even otherwise, being a perpetual amnesty scheme applicable to all permissible projects, it fails to lay down an intelligible differential for the selection of projects for the grant of post-facto environmental clearance having a rational nexus to supervening public interest, and is thereby ultra vires the object of the 1986 Act, namely the preservation of the environment through a balanced approach between the precautionary principle and sustainable development,” it said.

“Given these circumstances, the 2021 office memorandum does not satisfy the test of proportionality and reasonableness and is violative of Articles 14 and 21 of the Constitution,” the bench said.

First trial in absentia begins today

of Criminal Procedure (CrPC) provided for recording evidence in the absence of the accused but did not permit a trial in absentia. The BNSS, which replaced CrPC, brought the provision for the first time.

“In simple terms, this means that an accused who deliberately remains absconding and evades the judicial process cannot indefinitely hold up the trial merely by staying away,” said advocate Samridhi Dobhal, who is associated with the office of the Special Public Prosecutor.

In his order of July 9, Judge Gogne had said: “The court finds that the safeguards provided under section 356 (2) for trial of an absconding accused in absentia have been suitably addressed by the State...there is no impediment to the furtherance of the proceedings by way of considering charge.”

The order stated: “Since all accused except one are in custody, the court deems it appropriate that submissions on charge are heard on a day to day basis from 27.07.2026 till 07.08.2026. For the present, it is directed that the prosecution shall conclude its arguments on 27.07.2026 and 28.07.2026.”

However, Judge Gogne was on leave on July 27 and 28. On Wednesday, the Judge agreed to a request from lawyers representing Delhi Police that they would commence arguments from Thursday because Special Public Prosecutor Akhand Pratap Singh was occupied with another matter.

Sangwan was granted interim bail in another MCOCA case registered in 2019. Following bail, he failed to surrender and has been absconding ever since.

In the extortion racket case to be heard Thursday, the trial in absentia comes after the Delhi Police Crime Branch and the court tried to get Sangwan to appear or join the investigation multiple times. Two NBWs (non-bailable warrants) were issued against him in June and July 2026.

In the July 9 order, Judge Gogne had said: “It is seen that the NBWs could not be executed and his house (in Najafgarh) was found to be locked. It is also reported that the said accused has not been seen at the premises in question for a long time.”

The Crime Branch also published a notice in a national newspaper regarding Sangwan’s absence. They also reached out to a relative and gave an affidavit regarding the commencement of the proceedings.

“The significance of this order is that an absconding accused cannot be allowed to frustrate the criminal justice system simply by remaining beyond the reach of the law. To allow the application of trial in absentia, there is a minimum requirement of two NBWs against an accused and there should be a gap of one month between both NBWs,” advocate Dobhal said.

“Of course, this is not an automatic process. The law provides several safeguards and requires the court to first satisfy itself that all the prescribed steps have been complied with. Once those requirements are fulfilled, the court can proceed with the trial even in the physical absence of the accused,” she said.

Sangwan, meanwhile, faces over two dozen other cases related to extortion, land grab-

bing, and murder in Delhi and Haryana.

He was arrested in 2016 and remained in jail until 2019, when he was granted parole for a month. During that period, his associates organised a grand party at a farmhouse, built on encroached government land, in Najafgarh. Although the Crime Branch raided the event and arrested 22 people, Sangwan could not be found. A Red Corner Notice was issued against him in June 2021.

Sangwan was also allegedly involved in the murder of Haryana INLD leader Nafe Singh Rathie in February 2024. The killing is believed to be linked to his gang rivalry with jailed gangster Manjeet Mahal.

On July 9, Special Judge Gogne directed that a legal aid counsel be assigned by the Delhi Legal Services Authority (DLA) to represent the gangster in the MCOCA case. As of today, Sangwan does not have a lawyer.

Advocate Hritwik Maurya, who is also associated with the office of the Special Public Prosecutor, said: “If he’s convicted and judgement is passed by the trial court sentencing him under the provisions of MCOCA, and as such a situation arises where he is apprehended at a later stage, he will be directly sent to imprisonment to satisfy the sentencing judgement passed by the trial court since trial in his absence has already been concluded.”

Former MLA and AAP leader Naresh Balyan was also booked under MCOCA in this case for his alleged links with Sangwan. Balyan, a two-time MLA from Uttam Nagar (2015 and 2020), was arrested in December 2024 and is in custody.

Leaked NEET papers took two routes out of Maharashtra: CBI

Dr Manoj Bhagwanrao Shirure. Investigators have focused on Motegoankar whose coaching institute has branches in Pune, Nashik, Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar, Nanded, Solapur, Kolhapur, Akola and other parts of Maharashtra.

“Investigators have alleged that Motegoankar was an active member of the organised network that procured and circulated NEET-UG 2026 question papers. He allegedly arranged procurement of chemistry questions by paying Rs 5 lakh, routed through co-accused Dr Manoj Bhagwanrao Shirure, reportedly for the benefit of his son and students enrolled at RCC,” sources said.

A phone found during a search at Motegoankar’s house allegedly led to recovery of leaked questions, and notes of chemistry questions in his handwriting.

“At least 36 images, including five duplicates, containing 132 handwritten chemistry questions were recovered from his mobile phone. The meta-data allegedly showed that the images were captured on a Samsung Fold7 on April 23 this year, around 10 days before the examination. Prima facie, investigators found that approximately 111 of these questions matched questions from the NTA master sets for NEET-UG 2026,” sources said.

The CBI chargesheet, it is learnt, also details the alleged

role of Dr Shirure, a medical practitioner running a private hospital in Latur. Investigators have said Shirure facilitated the procurement and onward dissemination of leaked chemistry questions at the instance of Kulkarni, also an accused.

“Shirure’s hospital premises were allegedly used as the venue where Motegoankar’s son accessed the chemistry question paper in the third week of April, before the NEET examination. Shirure also referred two other doctors whose children procured the question paper from Kulkarni, each allegedly paying Rs 3 lakh,” sources said.

Kulkarni was said to have also disclosed that he first came in contact with co-accused Dhananjay Lokhande in 2021 and conspired with Manisha Waghmare in procuring and circulating the leaked papers. “The paper reached the beneficiaries through Kulkarni’s network. A payment of Rs 5 lakh made for the leaked paper was traced to Motegoankar’s wife and was allegedly recovered from the residence of a Shirure family member,” sources said.

The CBI has found that the first formal indication of the alleged NEET paper leak came not from an investigating agency, but from a May 7 email sent by a chemistry teacher, Shashikant Suthar, in Rajasthan’s Sikar, to the NTA, detailing how solved questions were

allegedly circulating hours before the examination.

Suthar wrote that on the evening of May 3, shortly after the NEET examination ended at 6 pm, his landlord approached him with two PDF files containing question papers and asked him to compare them with the actual NEET paper.

Suthar found that the questions in the PDFs matched the actual paper. He then got the match independently verified by colleagues before alerting the NTA.

Questioned about the source of the PDFs, the landlord reportedly said they had been sent to him on WhatsApp by his son, a first-year MBBS student studying in Kerala.

“He (the student) told him that he had received the files on May 2 from a student who shared a room with him. The chain, as described in Suthar’s email, led to a man who had initially demanded Rs 40,000 for the leaked paper but later agreed to Rs 30,000, which was paid through PhonePe,” sources said.

The email alleged that the man who had been paid sent 450 solved questions and answers at 11 pm on May 2, just hours before the NEET examination was scheduled to be held. “The account suggests that the alleged leak had reached students and intermediaries at least a day before the exam,” sources said.

India’s 1st CWG men’s 10,000m silver

decades of African dominance. For the first time since 1970, no athlete from the continent finished on the podium, though eight of them were in the 15-man final, including two formidable Kenyans: 2023 World Championship medallist Daniel Ebenyo and 2024 Paris Olympics podium-finisher (5000m) Edwin Kugrat.

But Gulveer was unfazed by reputation. His performance in the rain-soaked conditions, alongside Avinash Sable’s second-place finish in the 3000m steep-chase four years ago in Birmingham — another event once dominated by Kenyans — will be remembered among the finest races by an Indian distance runner.

“The silver means a lot because it is the result of a lot of hard work over the last few years,” Gulveer told *The Indian Express* from Glasgow.

This wasn’t a flash-in-the-pan performance. Gulveer holds national records in the 10,000m (27:00.22), 3,000m, 5,000m and the 25-km road race, and became the first Indian to run a sub-60-minute half marathon, in New York, this year.

In Glasgow, the downpour made things harder. “We had to

be a little careful on the bends because the track was wet. Otherwise, my focus was only on following my race plan and staying relaxed,” Gulveer said.

He started with a moderate average speed of 21.5 km/h, holding that pace for the first 4,000 metres and staying among the top three runners. “In a championship race, position is very important. I didn’t want to lead too early because that would have meant doing extra work, but I also didn’t want to lose contact with the front group,” said Gulveer, a JSW Sports-backed athlete.

After the 4,000-metre mark, as the other runners began making their moves, he slipped back in the pack, dropping to ninth at the 5,600-metre mark. But the moment he lost sight of the leading pack, he sped up to 24.7 km/h. “Whenever I felt the pace changing or the gap opening, I made sure I moved up again. The idea was to stay in a good position and be ready when the race really started in the last few laps,” he said.

With 2,000m to go, Gulveer was in seventh position and getting boxed in on the inside lane. But as an opening appeared with 1.2 km left, he moved up to fourth.

The worry was that he might fade at the business end of the race. In 2025, he had finished ninth in the 5,000-m heats at the World Championships after being in fourth position with a little over two laps to go.

This time, it was clear he had learnt from that mistake, producing a finishing kick with 200 metres remaining. “By the last 200 metres, I knew it was time to give everything I had left. At that stage, you don’t really think too much. You react. I had saved enough for the finish, and I tried to maintain my form and kept pushing until the line,” Gulveer said.

“When you are racing for a medal, you don’t feel the pain at that moment. You only think about finishing as strongly as possible,” he said.

Hailing from a farming family, Gulveer had wanted to join the Army for a stable job -- in Sirsa, nearly 700 men serve in the forces. He started out running on a mud ground near his home, training to pass the Army’s 1.6-km Physical Efficiency Test. Just eight years later, the Naib Subedar and Army Sports Institute runner had etched his name into the annals of India’s distance running history.

3 held for ransom in Thailand

cryptocurrency, according to media reports.

According to a report in *The Pattaya News*, the alleged ring-leader provided the victims’ flight and passport details to the suspects. The victims were then intercepted and taken to the house where they were confined.

The police told the media that the suspects were promised valuables, cash and airline tickets to leave Thailand after carrying out the operation.

The investigation began after the Indian Embassy in Thailand alerted Chonburi Immigration Police and Pattaya City Police on July 21, following complaints from the victims’

families, *The Nation* newspaper reported.

The families had reportedly shared video call recordings showing the victims with their hands and feet tied, and with assault marks. The abductors demanded a ransom of Rs 40 lakh from the family of each victim, the report said.

On Monday, the police raided a two-storey townhouse in Pattaya and rescued the three victims — identified as Mohit (23), Ashish (24) and Himanshu (20). According to a report, the victims told investigators that another Indian national had been held captive at the same property, and was allegedly released after his relatives paid

about Rs 30 lakh in ransom.

Citing local reports, *PTT* said the victims were found confined separately on the second floor of the house with their hands and feet tied and their mouths taped. They also bore signs of assault. Investigators recovered adhesive tape, a wooden object allegedly used in the assaults, and red spray paint, which they believe was used to stage photographs and videos of the victims that were sent to their families to pressure them into paying the ransom, it said.

There was no official comment from the Indian Embassy in Thailand or the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) on the matter.

Manmohan clean chit in coal case

Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, was hearing a batch of petitions in connection with the coal block allocation cases.

The CBI, which filed its closure reports before the trial court in August and October 2014, had found no case against Singh. However, the Special Judge had rejected the reports, taken cognizance of the case and, in March 2015, summoned Singh to face trial. The Supreme Court had stayed the summons on April 1, 2015.

“Vide the impugned order, the learned Special Judge took cognizance under the Preven-

tion of Corruption Act against six persons, including the appellant, Dr Manmohan Singh. CBI, after investigation, filed closure reports, thereby giving the appellant a clean chit. Nevertheless, the learned Judge turned down the closure reports and took cognizance,” the CJI-led bench said on Wednesday.

“Due to the unfortunate demise of the appellant, this appeal could be disposed of as infructuous. But with a view to considering the aspect of the learned Special Judge taking cognizance and summoning

the appellant, we have gone through both closure reports filed by CBI,” it said.

“Having regard to the relevant parameters consistently laid down by this court on acceptance of reports of the investigating agency, we are satisfied that there was no reason for the learned Judge to turn down the closure reports of the CBI and take cognizance,” it said.

The case is related to the allocation of Talabira-II coal block in Odisha in 2005, when Singh, who was then the Prime Minister, also held the coal portfolio.

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FIR registered over ‘defamatory’ posts against PM, police seek details from X

Alok Singh
New Delhi, July 29

THE DELHI Police has registered an FIR in connection with “objectionable and defamatory” content posted on social media against Prime Minister Narendra Modi and other constitutional heads.

It has also written to X and other platforms to remove the content and provide details of users who posted them, The Indian Express has learnt.

According to sources, the content was mostly posted during the Cockroach Janta Party’s protest at Jantar Mantar.

A case under charges of criminal intimidation, public mischief, and defamation has been lodged at the Special Cell IFSO (Intelligence Fusion and Strategic Operations) unit in connection with the matter.

On Sunday, *The Indian Express* reported that the Delhi Police has started asking social media platforms to take down such content.

According to sources, in one of the notices sent to a social media platform, the Delhi Police said the circulation of such “objectionable and defamatory content has caused serious harm to the PM’s reputation, dignity and public image”.

“The continued availability of such content has the potential to disturb public order, create unnecessary political controversy and erode public trust. Such acts also facilitate misuse of social media platforms for defamation and objectionable content and cyber-enabled offences.

“Therefore... you are hereby directed to remove or disable access to the aforesaid accounts as well as URLs immediately, within three hours of receipt of this intimation, while ensuring that the relevant data, logs and subscriber information are preserved for evidence purposes,” the notice said.

Police have also identified around 500 social media accounts that allegedly shared deepfake and AI-generated content related to the protests. A police officer said these accounts have been recommended for blocking through the respective social media platforms.

On July 20, clashes broke out between Delhi Police personnel and CJP protesters, including students, leaving several injured. Police later registered 15 FIRs in connection with the violence, but subsequently decided to withdraw them.



A worker welds the barricades at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on Wednesday. TASHI TOBGYAL

Delhi Police welds barricades at Jantar Mantar

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 29

FOLLOWING THE Cockroach Janta Party (CJP)’s warning that it would resume its protest if all FIRs lodged against the protestors are not immediately withdrawn, the Delhi Police has beefed up security by deploying additional personnel and welding barricades at Jantar Mantar.



When contacted, Delhi Police sources said the security arrangements had been made in anticipation of a gathering at Jantar Mantar.

On Tuesday, the CJP threatened to resume its agitation, accusing the Centre of backtracking on its promise to not take legal action against protesters.

CJP spokesperson Ashutosh Ranka alleged a “complete breach” of the July 25 understanding with the Centre, claiming that hundreds of students had been arrested in BJP-ruled states.

Class 5 student sexually assaulted in school van, driver & helper arrested

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 29

A 11-YEAR-OLD girl, a Class 5 student of a public school in North Delhi, was allegedly sexually assaulted by her school van driver and his helper, police said on Wednesday.

The accused were arrested on Friday, said police. They have been booked under Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act. As per the police, the incident came to light on Friday, when the girl came to her class teacher and narrated her ordeal.

“She told her teacher that the driver would drop her near her

house after dropping all other students travelling in the van... After dropping everyone, he would allegedly sexually assault her along with his friend,” said a source in the police. “This kept on happening for months. Every time she would resist, the accused would threaten to make her videos viral,” the source added.

Police said the teacher informed the girl’s parents, who filed a police complaint against the accused.

“The girl has been counselled and we are trying to find out whether the accused have been involved in similar incidents,” the source said.

HC refuses to stay Centre’s HPV vaccination drive

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, July 29

THE DELHI High Court Wednesday refused to stay the HPV vaccination drive after it was informed by the Centre that out of around 55.9 lakh doses administered since February, only 120 cases reported adverse events following immunisation (AEFI) as on July 25.

The court, which was hearing a PIL that flagged concerns over safety of administering Merck’s HPV vaccine Gardasil, noted there was “no instant harm”. Of the 120 AEFI cases, 42 were classified as “serious/severe”, but no deaths were reported, the Centre mentioned.

It added that none of the AEFI cases required hospitalisation beyond two days.

• Skywatch

Forecast: July 30, 2026
Generally cloudy sky.
Spell of very light to light rain
MAX: 32-34
0.9°C below normal
MIN: 24-26
3.3°C below normal
• Sunrise: 5:42 AM (July 31)
• Sunset: 7:14 PM (July 30)
• Moonrise: 7:51 PM (July 30)
• Moonset: 7:02 AM (July 31)

• AQI Tracker

Alipur
Moderate
AQI: 131

Anand Vihar
Moderate
AQI: 146

Najafgarh
Satisfactory
AQI: 66

JNU
Good
AQI: 47

● Good (0-50)

● Satisfactory (51-100)

● Moderate (101-200)

● Poor (201-300)

● Very Poor (301-400)

● Severe (401-500)

To stop untreated sewage entering Yamuna, Delhi to get 15 new decentralised treatment plants

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 29

SEEKING TO tackle the single largest source of pollution entering Yamuna river, the Delhi Jal Board (DJB) on Wednesday approved sewerage and wastewater treatment projects worth around Rs 4,500 crore, including setting up of 15 decentralised sewage treatment plants (DSTPs), covering 1,000 km of sewer lines and upgrading existing treatment infrastructure. “These projects are expected to benefit around 20 lakh residents,” said Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, adding that the work is set to be completed within 21 months.

In a statement, the government said the new plants will cater largely to areas where sewer infrastructure remains inadequate. While the city has steadily expanded its sewage treatment capacity over the years, large volumes of wastewater still enter drains – either because many colonies remain unconnected to the sewer network or sewage has to travel a long distance before reaching treatment plants.

Delhi currently has 22 drains discharging wastewater into Yamuna, with Najafgarh and Shahdara drains alone contributing around 80% of the total pollution load observed in the Capital.

Singh said that while 13 DSTPs had been approved earlier, the DJB has now awarded 15 additional DSTPs with a combined treatment capacity of 103.5 MGD at an investment of nearly Rs 2,000 crore.

Officials said the together, the DSTPs will add 227 million gallons per day (MGD) of treatment capacity, taking Delhi’s overall sewage treatment ca-

capacity from 814 MGD to 1,041 MGD – exceeding the current sewage load of around 1,000 MGD generated by the city.

Unlike large centralised STPs that require wastewater to travel over long distances through trunk sewers, decentralised sewage treatment plants are located closer to where sewage is generated and can help in tapping of drains directly at the source. Officials said this reduces dependence on extensive sewer networks, lowers pumping requirements and allows wastewater from unsewered or rapidly urbanising areas to be intercepted and treated before it enters nearby drains flowing into the Yamuna.

As per the Environment department records, there has been a marginal increase in Delhi’s utilisation of installed sewage treatment capacity over the last three years – rising from 74.2% in 2022 to 79.16% in 2024, and reaching 80.9% in 2025. Despite this, a substantial volume of sewage remains untreated due to a daily deficit of around 174 MGD.

“It was a long-term requirement foreseeing that the city will need to expand its sewage treatment capacity, considering population growth, urban expansion and redevelopment of residential and commercial areas,” a senior DJB official said. Alongside the plants, the DJB also approved laying of 989 km of new sewer pipelines and providing household sewer connections across 244 colonies and 57 villages. It further approved upgrades to existing treatment plants, a new 35 MGD STP, sludge management facilities at 10 existing STPs and in-situ treatment of the Delhi Gate drain.

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UTISWATANTRA
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New Delhi

Man stabbed to death after he confronts youths passing lewd remarks at friend

Pragnesh
New Delhi, July 29

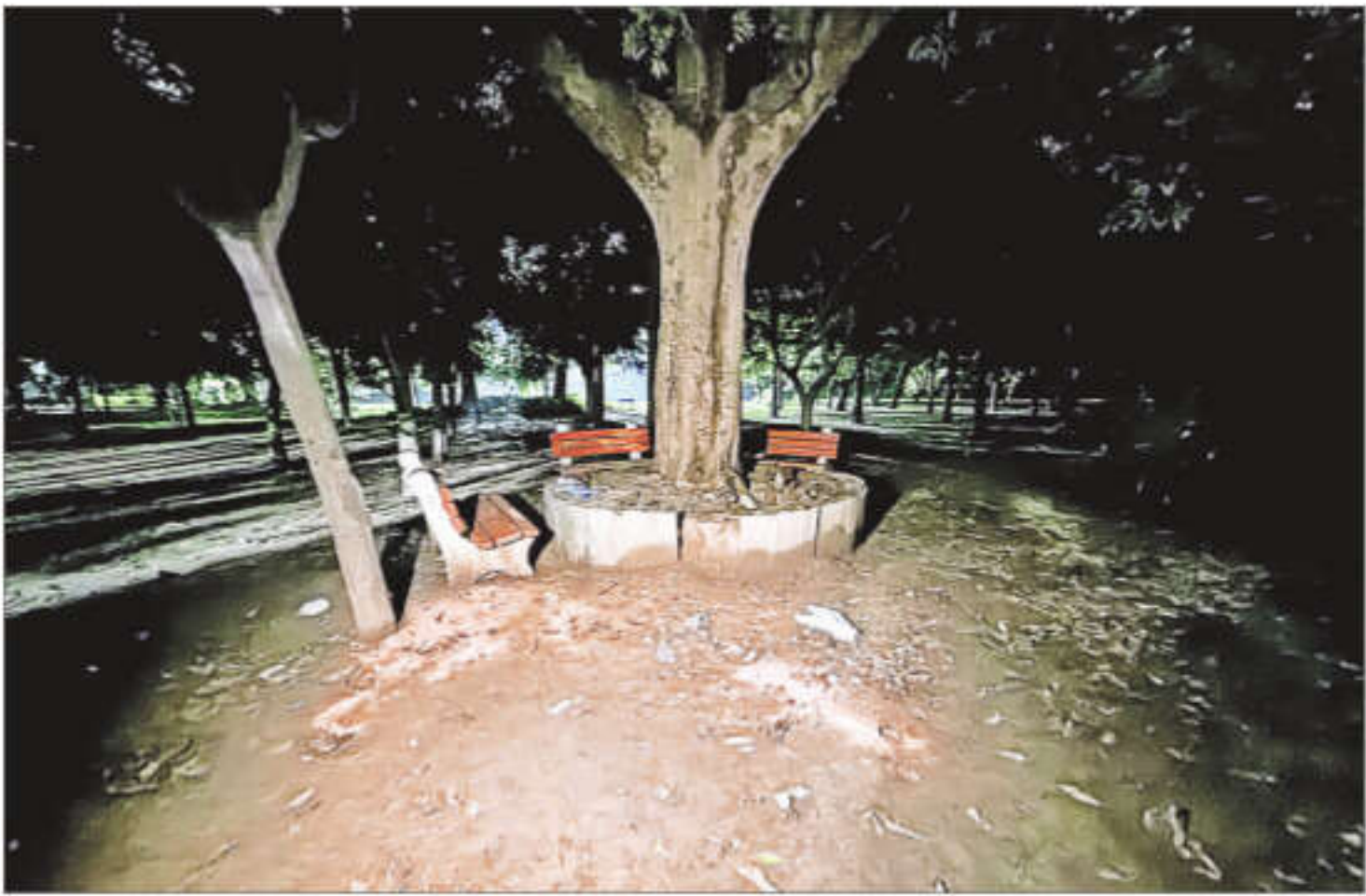
A 30-YEAR-OLD man was stabbed to death inside a Delhi Development Authority (DDA) park in Northwest Delhi's Bharat Nagar on Tuesday afternoon after he allegedly confronted a group of four youths for passing lewd remarks at his woman friend, who was also critically injured in the attack. While police have apprehended a juvenile, the remaining accused are absconding.

A case of murder has been registered, officers said.

Police identified the deceased as Sunil, a resident of Mainpuri in Uttar Pradesh. He was visiting the city when the incident took place.

His friend, Devki (26), a resident of Jahangirpuri, has been admitted to the hospital.

According to police, Sunil and Devki had been sitting on a bench at Baba Chaudhary Khimman Singh Park in Ashok Vihar since around 2.30 pm. About an hour later, four youths allegedly approached them and passed lewd comments at Devki.



ments at Devki.

"Enraged, Sunil snapped back with abuses, which led to a scuffle. That was when one of the accused took out a knife and stabbed Sunil and Devika," a senior officer said.

A guard at the park, hearing Devika scream, rushed to

the spot.

"He found Devki lying in a pool of blood. She was asking for help, while the man was lying unconscious, with stab injuries all over his body. Three to four boys had fled the spot," the officer added.

Police said a PCR call re-

garding the incident was received at Bharat Nagar police station at 3.33 pm. "A police team immediately reached Khimman Singh Park in Ashok Vihar," said DCP Akanksha Yadav.

Both victims were taken to the hospital, where Sunil was



The incident happened inside a DDA park in Northwest Delhi's Bharat Nagar. PRAVEEN KHANNA

declared dead. Sunil had suffered four stab wounds, including injuries to his face and chest, police said.

Police said that in her preliminary statement, Devki has said that three to four men had approached them in the park before an argument broke out. "As one of the assailants pulled

out a knife, Sunil came in front of Devki and was stabbed. The accused then stabbed Devki, before fleeing," said an officer.

Two teams led by Inspector Robin Tyagi have been formed to identify and arrest the remaining suspects, police said.

Police said Sunil and Devki had known each other for years. "Sunil worked at an iron bending shop and kept visiting Delhi for business. Devki, who worked as a caretaker, was Sunil's friend and they had met multiple times earlier," said an officer.

"Her condition is very critical so we couldn't speak to her much... While Sunil's family is on their way from UP, Devki's family has been informed about the incident," the officer added.

Spread over more than 10 acres in Ashok Vihar Phase III, Baba Chaudhary Khimman Singh Park is frequented by joggers, families and children, and is about a 20-minute walk from the Shalimar Bagh Metro station. It witnesses a steady flow of people both in the morning and evening.

'THEY WANT TO EXCLUDE MOST WOMEN' AAP attacks govt over Laxmi Yojana eligibility criteria

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 29

THE AAP on Wednesday criticised the BJP-led Delhi government's monthly financial assistance scheme for women, alleging that the eligibility criteria have been laid out in a way that would exclude most women in the Capital.

Hitting out at the government which announced that women with three children are not eligible, AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal said it was confusing for the Hindus as RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat has asked them to have many children.

"Mohan Bhagwat is saying that every Hindu should have as many children as possible and Rekha Gupta is saying that if you have more than three children, you will not get the benefit under the Delhi Lakshmi Yojna," read a post by Kejriwal on X.

"The helpless Hindus are confused. Rekha ji and Bhagwat ji should tell the Hindus what exactly they should do," he said. Bhagwat, at an event in February, had expressed concern over "a declining Hindu population", suggesting that Hindu families should consider having at least three children.

AAP's Delhi unit president Saurabh Bharadwaj, meanwhile, told *The Indian Express*: "The government is just trying to exclude as many people as possible who can benefit from the scheme."

"They have excluded women who have more than three children... women will have to show proof that they have lived here for more than 10 years, which will exclude mi-

grant labourers. They are trying to exclude everyone who needs the money the most," he said.

The Delhi Cabinet on Tuesday cleared the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana which will provide a monthly assistance of Rs 2,500 to women from the Economically Weaker Section (EWS). However, unlike similar schemes rolled out by several states, a detailed set of eligibility criteria for beneficiaries were also announced.

Women already receiving benefits under any other financial assistance scheme or pension, government employees, women with more than three living children, women from families with annual electricity consumption exceeding 2,400 units, those from families with a member employed by the government, women who own a four-wheeler, those who pay income tax or GST, and ones with a criminal record are ineligible.

"This government's image is bad... which is why they had to implement this policy, but they are just doing it to check the box, like a formality," Bharadwaj claimed.

"Before the Delhi elections, all of them — the Prime Minister, the BJP national president, the party spokespersons and leaders — claimed that every woman in Delhi would get Rs 2,500 per month. But what is the BJP doing now?" he said.

"They said women aged 21 to 60 are eligible and the money will be given to only one woman per family. You ask for votes from everyone. But when it comes to giving money, you will give to only one," he said.

Yamuna rises after release from Hathnikund, level of river likely to keep going up for two days

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, July 29

VARYING AMOUNTS of water released from the Hathnikund Barrage over the last two days have led to a staggered rise in the level of Yamuna river, with the Central Water Commission's (CWC) monitoring stations recording different levels of water between the barrage and Delhi. The CWC has forecast a gradual rise in the river water in the Capital over the next two days.

According to CWC data, water released from Hathnikund Barrage rose from 2,149 cusecs at 6 am on Tuesday (July 28) to 23,235 cusecs by 4 pm, touching 24,576 cusecs at 6 pm before falling later in the night. Another spike to 24,478 cusecs was recorded at 2 am on Wednesday, after which the discharge fell to 8,119 cusecs by 11 am.

Bhim Singh Rawat, a member of the South Asia Network on Dams, Rivers and People (SANDRP) said the fluctuations were due to the rainfall received in the upper Yamuna catchment, upstream of the Hathnikund Barrage, in the last few days. "The impact of these releases would be reflected in Delhi typically after 48 hours," he added.

The rainfall comes against the backdrop of a largely subdued monsoon witnessed by much of Haryana. According to India Meteorological Department's (IMD) data, Yamunanagar, where the barrage is located, has received 274.2 mm of rain against the usual 303.1 mm.

Panchkula, Ambala and Karnal have also recorded deficit rain, while Chandigarh has received above-normal rainfall, showing uneven rainfall across



The CWC has forecast a gradual rise in Yamuna over two days. FILE

the upper Yamuna basin.

Between Hathnikund and Delhi, the first cluster of CWC monitoring stations comprises Western Yamuna Canal, Fatehgarh, Panchkuan, Ghodopipli and Kala Naur. Of these, Panchkuan and Ghodopipli are flowing above their warning levels.

Downstream, while Karnal, Mawi Palla and Delhi Railway Bridge continue to flow normally, the CWC has forecast a gradual rise in the water levels over the next two days.

The CWC has forecast the Yamuna at the Delhi Railway Bridge to rise gradually from 202.2 m on Wednesday to 202.4 m by July 31. This is well below the warning level of 204.5 m, the danger mark of 205.33 m and the highest flood level of 208.66 m recorded during the 2023 floods.

The current water discharges from Hathnikund are also much lower than those during the 2023 floods when heavy rainfall across the upper Yamuna basin had resulted in unprecedented inflows into Delhi.

"After Hathnikund, there is a gap in data. We don't have discharge data for the river down-

stream of the barrage, making it difficult to track how the flow changes before reaching Delhi," Rawat said.

As per CWC data, Hindon river, meanwhile, has remained marginally above the warning level (195 m) but is still below the danger mark of 196 m, with the forecast indicating that levels are likely to remain elevated over the next two days.

Earlier this month, a rising Hindon had inundated low-lying settlements in parts of Ghaziabad and Gautam Budhha Nagar, prompting the Uttar Pradesh Irrigation department to step up monitoring while maintaining that the river remained below the danger level.

Unlike the Yamuna, whose flows into Delhi are influenced by releases from the Hathnikund Barrage, the Hindon is a separate, primarily rain-fed tributary with its own catchment.

Originating in the lower Shivalik ranges in Saharanpur district of UP, it flows through western UP before joining the Yamuna downstream of Delhi near Greater Noida.

Cash to digital: Payment for Metro rides changes track

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, July 29

NEARLY THREE-FOURTH of the revenue of Delhi Metro — India's largest Metro network — now comes from cashless transactions. This marks a reversal in trends eight years ago when income in cash accounted for almost three-fourth of its revenue, according to the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation's (DMRC) internal data, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

This year, so far, digital transactions have accounted for 73.56% of earnings against 26.44% in cash — largely representative of the trends in the two categories. In 2018, this split was almost the opposite with 77.93% cash transactions and 22.07% cashless earnings. Notwithstanding the shift, Smart Cards are preferred by around half of Metro commuters, the data shows. Habit, faster entry and exit at gates, and fare discounts are said to be some factors behind the preference.

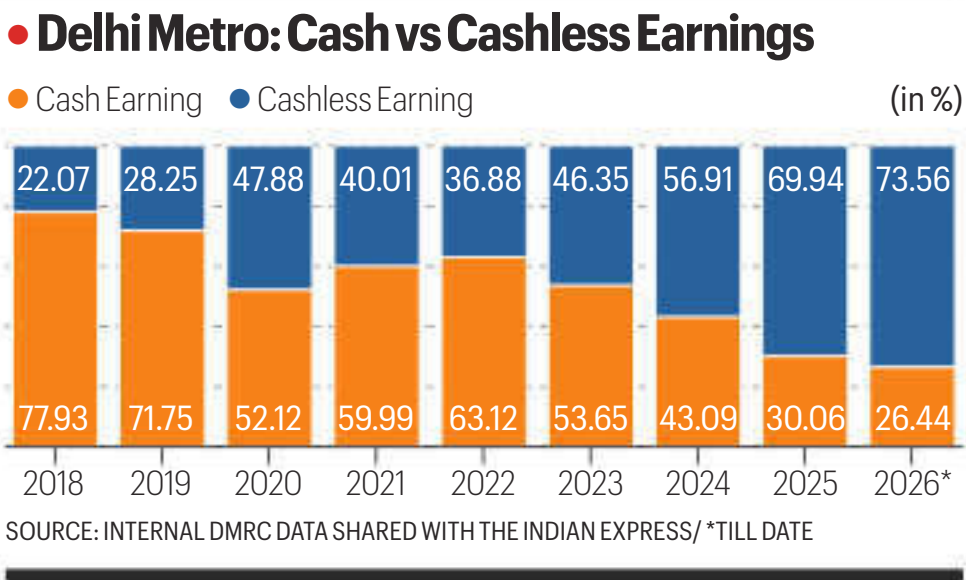
■ As per the data, a little over 3% passengers use the Virtual Smart Card, available on Delhi Metro Sarthi App.

■ QR-based paper tickets, bought at counters, or ticket vending machines, account for about 18% of the transactions.

■ Digital QR tickets booked through mobile apps and messaging platforms (including the Delhi Metro Sarthi app, Paytm, PhonePe, WhatsApp and ONDC-linked platforms such as Rapido and Uber) make up around 9% of rides.

■ Bank-issued National Common Mobility Cards (NCMC), including those issued via Airtel Payments Bank under the 'One Nation, One Card' scheme, account for close to

EXPRESS special



20% of trips.

Officials have attributed the digitisation push to a need to cut queues at counters and token vending machines, reduce cash handling, and enable interoperable travel through NCMC across Metro networks. "Over time, there has been a gradual shift towards contactless options like UPI, QR-code based tickets, and upgraded NCMC," an official said. According to officials, a series of tie-ups with different companies has led to increased usage of cards.

DMRC first launched an online Smart Card recharge facility over a decade ago in 2014. UPI app Paytm followed with Smart Card recharge in March 2016, and PhonePe in October 2018. In 2021, Amazon Pay launched a feature to recharge smart cards in 2021 and WhatsApp launched it in 2024.

The Virtual Smart Card, a dynamic QR code on a phone that functions like a physical smart card, was introduced in September 2024 — much later compared to other digital options.

QR-based tickets took even longer to reach the network. QR ticketing through the RIDLR app, a public transport ticketing and commuting app, was intro-

duced only on the Airport Express Line in September 2018, followed by Paytm QR ticketing on the same line in August 2019. It took nearly five more years for the launch of the Airport Line's WhatsApp-based ticketing facility in May 2023. This was followed by an extension of QR ticketing to the entire DMRC network in October 2023.

Since then, the options have expanded quickly: WhatsApp QR ticketing and PhonePe QR ticketing, both rolled out in 2024, Amazon Pay followed in August that year, and a soft launch of ticketing through apps linked to Open Network for Digital Commerce (ONDC), which allows commuters to buy digital QR tickets directly through everyday consumer apps such as Rapido and Uber, arrived in November 2024.

NCMC has had the most staggered rollout of all. It was first introduced on the Airport Express Line in December 2020, but did not start working across the rest of the DMRC network until June 2023. Airtel Payments Bank was roped in from January 2023 to let commuters top up NCMC cards through its Thanks app, ahead of the card's network-wide activation.

Delhi Medical Council gets 4 members a year after its dissolution

Tabshir Shams
New Delhi, July 29

THE DELHI Chief Minister's Office (CMO) on Wednesday, in a post on X, announced the appointment of four members to the Delhi Medical Council (DMC), more than a year after the body was dissolved amid allegations of administrative and financial irregularities.

"The Government of Delhi has appointed Dr. Ajay Kumar, Dr. Hansraj Baveja, Dr. S. K. Tandon, and Dr. Vinod Kumar Monga as members of the Delhi Medical Council," read the CMO's post.

"The Delhi Medical Council plays an important role in maintaining quality, transparency, and medical ethics in healthcare services. These appointments will make significant contributions to strengthening Delhi's health system by making the Council's functions even more effective," it also said.

The DMC was dissolved by then Lieutenant Governor (LG) VK Saxena on June 17 last year. "The council had not been re-constituted since — a gap that

has also caused significant delays in registration of doctors.

While ordering the dissolution, the former LG had allowed two ex-officio members to continue temporarily, assigned the role of registrar to the Directorate General of Health Services for the interim period, and had directed the Health department to re-constitute the council in two months, under the Delhi Medical Council Act, 1997.

In December 2025, as reported by *The Indian Express*, a special audit was ordered to investigate allegations that the DMC had collected roughly Rs 28 crore in recent years without proper audit or fund segregation. The committee has also been examining if such recovery can be made from the personal accounts of Dr. Girish Tyagi, who previously served as the acting registrar and has held the positions of both the president and vice-president of the council.

Dr Tyagi has since filed a case in the Delhi High Court seeking to quash a government order directing him to vacate his post.

● THE BROTHERS, CONVICTED IN A 1996 MURDER CASE, JUMPED BAIL AND VANISHED FOR DECADES

A trader's murder in Delhi, a Mumbai killing and long trail of two fugitive brothers

Pragnesh
New Delhi, July 29

ON MAY 14, 2006, as a vendor arrived at Mumbai's Bhindi Bazaar mutton market to open his stall, he saw a plastic bag lying on his handcart. Curious, he opened it to find a human torso, the head and limbs severed.

He alerted the police but the case eventually went cold.

More than a decade later, a tip-off led Mumbai Police to two brothers — Firasat Ali and Arshad Ali — who investigators alleged were behind the killing. They were soon arrested by the Mumbai Police.

While Arshad remained in jail, Firasat disappeared in January 2021, when he was granted bail by the Bombay High Court.

Soon, investigators found that he is absconding in another

murder case too — this time in Delhi — for 26 years.

Firasat and his other brother, Shah Nawaz, had been sentenced to life imprisonment for killing a trader in 1996 but had disappeared after securing bail in 2000. Earlier this month, nearly 30 years after the trader's murder, Delhi Police finally arrested Firasat and Shah Nawaz.

The headless torso

In the Bhindi Bazaar case, investigators grappled with one question: who was the victim and was it a gang hit.

The area had long been associated with Mumbai's underworld. Once linked to Dawood Ibrahim's D-Company, Bhindi Bazaar was by 2006 witnessing a changing crime landscape.

Gulabra More, then an assistant sub-inspector at Nag-

pada police station, joined the investigation at the JJ Marg police station in South Mumbai.

But identifying the victim proved impossible. DNA samples led nowhere and no missing person's complaint matched the remains.

Over a decade later, More — an inspector with MRA Marg police station by then — received a call from an informer claiming that he knew the identity of the victim and the killer.

"The deceased was Kishan Kharva, who would have been 57 years old at that time. The caller said that the killer was someone named Firasat and his brother," More told *The Indian Express*.

Within days, Mumbai Police arrested the brothers. They refused to divulge anything about the crime, prompting investiga-



Shah Nawaz and (right) Firasat Ali. EXPRESS

tors to trace Kharva's family.

They found that Kharva lived in Kamathipura with his wife, Bansiben, and their four children. Police said Bansiben sold utensils door to door, often accepting old clothes in exchange. Once she had collected enough, she sold them to wholesale traders, including Firasat.

During questioning, Bansiben admitted to have allegedly



hired the two men to kill her husband. "Kharva was addicted to alcohol and used to physically assault and abuse his wife besides frequently accusing her of infidelity. Bansiben gave a contract to kill her husband, paying Rs 2 lakh to Firasat and Arshad. Firasat murdered Kharva, dismembered the body, and disposed of the body parts at different locations," said DCP

(Crime Branch) Sanjeev Yadav in Delhi. As investigators dug deeper into Firasat's past, they uncovered the second murder.

The 1996 killing

On September 27, 1996, Ish-tiaq Ahmad (27), a wholesale clothes trader from Moradabad, had spent the day buying second-hand clothes in West Delhi's Raghunagar Nagar. "He and his brothers were at the market along with their neighbour from Moradabad, Shah Nawaz, also a clothes trader," said an officer.

An argument broke out between Ish-tiaq's brother Sharafat Ali and Shah Nawaz over a saree they wanted to buy. "Shah Nawaz threatened us with dire consequences for taking that saree from him. He said he would be back," Sharafat told

the police in his complaint.

Hours later, Shah Nawaz arrived at Ish-tiaq's their rented room in Raghunagar Nagar with three men, including Firasat. "Armed with knives, they launched a deadly attack," said the officer.

According to police reports, the attack resembled a gang hit. Police said Firasat and Shah Nawaz went for Ish-tiaq while the others attacked his brothers. "Based on Sharafat's statement, an FIR was registered. Murder charges were added after Ish-tiaq's death," said DCP Yadav.

A trial court later sentenced Shah Nawaz and Firasat to life imprisonment. But in 2000, while their appeal against the sentence was pending, the brothers secured bail and disappeared. Sixteen years later, the

Delhi High Court upheld their conviction.

The catch

After his arrest in Mumbai, Firasat remained in jail until January 2021, when he was granted bail by the Bombay High Court. He then disappeared. There was no trace of Shah Nawaz either.

Nearly five years later, Delhi Police Crime Branch's Anti-Robbery and Snatching Cell (ARSC) received fresh intelligence — Firasat had returned to his hometown of Moradabad, while Shah Nawaz was living in Godda, Jharkhand.

"On July 4, two teams simultaneously conducted raids at Moradabad and Godda. Both were apprehended," said the DCP. Both are now lodged in Tihar Jail.

APPEAL AGAINST DETENTION AFTER SIR DELETION

Voter ID, Aadhaar, PAN not conclusive proof of Indian citizenship: Calcutta HC

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, July 29

THE CALCUTTA High Court has held that voter identity card, Aadhaar number, PAN and bank account passbook are not conclusive proof of Indian citizenship.

The observation came on Tuesday when a division bench comprising Justices Debangsu Basak and Ajay Kumar Gupta was hearing a habeas corpus petition filed by one Suman Molla, who claimed that his nephew, Nasir, had been placed in a detention camp after his name was deleted from the electoral rolls during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise in West Bengal. Molla stated that Nasir was sent to a detention camp even though an appeal against the deletion was pending and he filed a police complaint in this regard on June 18.

The petitioner relied on Nasir's voter identity card, Aadhaar card, PAN card issued by the Income Tax Department and a bank account passbook to Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGfOKH6oBd0F>

“Writ petitioner and the detainee are unable to discharge the burden of proof as mandated by the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025”
CALCUTTA HIGH COURT

contend that he was an Indian citizen and not a foreign national. Observing that a voter identity card only establishes that a person was enrolled in the electoral rolls, the bench noted that Nasir's name had been deleted during the 2026 SIR process. The court also held that opening a bank account, by itself, is not proof of Indian citizenship.

“Writ petitioner and the detainee are unable to discharge the burden of proof as mandated by the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025,” the court observed. Holding that neither

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1 the petitioner nor the detainee had established Nasir's Indian citizenship, the court said it was not inclined to interfere with the decision of the authorities and dismissed the habeas corpus petition.

The advocate appearing for the petitioner submitted that in the SIR, Nasir was initially classified as 'under adjudication' and then his name was deleted without giving him an opportunity of hearing by the Tribunal.

The counsel also referred to the CS Record of Rights documents annexed with the writ petition showing that the great-grandfather of the detainee owned an immovable property.

The counsel appearing for the State submitted a report that identified the detainee as a foreign national. The counsel also placed a video recording of the detainee himself admitting that he was a foreign national.

The petition also stated that following the death of Nasir's father in 1980, Molla had brought up the detainee. The court, however, noted that the

petitioner is aged 38 while the detainee is 46. The bench rejected the petitioner's claim that he had brought up Nasir as his uncle. The court also drew an adverse inference against the detainee about his parents being Indian citizens after he and the writ petitioner refused to identify the burial site for the DNA test.

The court also observed that the writ petition does not disclose the birth certificate of the detainee. “Adequate material to establish place of birth or date of birth is absent in the writ petition and the supplementary affidavit. Citizenship by birth is not established. So far as citizenship by descent is concerned, there are cavemous disconnections. Name of the father of the detainee varies from document to document... Indian citizenship of the persons through whom the detainee seeks to connect as descent is also not established. Citizenship of the detainee by descent is not established,” the court observed.

MID-DAY MEAL SCHEME

Amid row, Suvendu says West Bengal govt will provide eggs with ISKCON-cooked veg food

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, July 29

WEST BENGAL Chief minister Suvendu Adhikari on Wednesday said that the government will provide eggs in mid-day meals along with the proposed ISKCON-cooked vegetarian meals in schools across Kolkata from August 1. This comes amid a controversy after the BJP government announced an overhaul of the mid-day meal scheme with its proposal to partner with ISKCON to provide cooked meals under a pilot project that would drop eggs from the menu.

Speaking to the media during a programme of the school education department at Nabanna, Adhiakri said, “From August 1, as a pilot project, ISKCON, will provide mid day meals in various schools in Kolkata. They will serve highly nutritious food to the students. Along with them, the state government, through SHG (Self Help Groups), will provide eggs to the students for protein. Odisha follows this model. ISKCON serves mid-day



West Bengal CM Suvendu Adhikari visits Belur Math in Howrah district on the occasion of Guru Purnima on Wednesday. PTI

meals in 22 cities in the country.”

While presenting the BJP government's first budget in the Assembly, Finance Minister Swapan Dasgupta had announced the overhaul, significantly raising the material allocation per student and partnering with the International Society for Krishna Consciousness (ISKCON) to serve purely vegetarian meals in Kolkata schools as a pilot project. This led to a controversy, with

the Opposition alleging that the government was promoting vegetarian food and depriving the students of protein.

Adhikari had said, “We are giving the responsibility of cooking mid-day meals to ISKCON. ISKCON will cook food. If you have an objection, do not say 'Hare Krishna'; no one will force you to do that. You will get good food to eat. You will get to eat pure food, nothing to worry about.” Recently, the chief min-

ister highlighted that allotment for each student even in the primary section for mid day meals has been increased to Rs 10 and that monthly wages for workers engaged with mid day meals in schools has been hiked from Rs 2,000 to Rs 3,000.

Meanwhile, Adhikari also announced a composite grant to schools in Bengal, after three years. “The previous government deprived the schools of this valuable grant for the last three years. In this scheme, the Centre gives 60% of the funds and the state government gives 40%. Today, we gave Rs 296.64 crore to over 80,000 schools in the state. This will be helpful to the students. Since we have implemented the 2020 National Education Policy (NEP) we will benefit from central schemes,” Adhikari said.

The CM also stated that digital learning will be promoted in over 1200 schools. “In higher secondary schools we are including basic learning of Artificial Intelligence. We are also trying to go for audio visual learning in the schools,” he added.



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The legal education system in India is undergoing a massive transition. As businesses expand, technology reshapes industries and regulatory frameworks become increasingly complex, the demand for legal professionals has outgrown traditional courtrooms.

Presently, law graduates are contributing to corporate strategy, digital governance, intellectual property, public policy and emerging technology regulation, making legal education one of the most versatile academic pathways. With greater emphasis on practical learning, interdisciplinary knowledge and specialised expertise, law schools are preparing students for careers that are as diverse and impactful.

Law is generally suited for students who enjoy analytical thinking, problem-solving and engaging with complex issues. Curiosity, logical reasoning, effective communication and the ability to understand multiple perspectives are among the most valuable qualities for aspiring lawyers. Moreover, equal importance is given to perseverance, ethical judgement and a willingness to continuously learn, as laws and regulations evolve with society and technological progress.

Students should be keen towards practical learning rather than gaining textbook knowledge. Modern legal education places significant emphasis on internships, legal aid clinics, research projects, drafting exercises and moot



court competitions that simulate real courtroom proceedings. These experiences help students build advocacy skills, develop professional confidence and understand how legal principles are applied in real-world situations. Collaborative projects, client interaction and participation in seminars further prepare students for the demands of professional practice.

The expansion of the legal ecosystem has branched out into a wide range of specialisations. Corporate law continues to remain one of the top choices, driven by India's growing business environment and increasing regulatory

requirements. Intellectual Property Rights has also gained prominence as innovation, start-ups, and creative industries flourish. Cyber law has become another sought-after option in a digital economy where issues related to piracy, cybersecurity, and online transactions demand specialised legal expertise.

Besides, emerging fields such as artificial intelligence and technology law are creating exciting opportunities as governments and businesses work to establish ethical and regulatory frameworks for new technologies. Environmental law, arbitration, competition law, international trade law, taxation and healthcare law are also witnessing growing demand.

For a law student, career opportunities today are quite diverse. Though litigation remains a respected career path, graduates are increasingly finding roles in corporate legal departments, multinational companies, consulting

firms, regulatory bodies, public sector organisations and financial institutions.

The rise of legal technology has further created opportunities in contract management, compliance, legal analytics, digital governance and tech-driven legal services, enabling professionals to combine legal expertise with innovation.

The future of the legal profession seems both promising and transformative. Technology is automating routine legal tasks, streamlining research and improving access to legal services, but it is also increasing the demand for professionals who can interpret complex regulations, advise organisations and apply human judgement to reshape industries. For students willing to embrace continuous learning and practical experience, legal education offers much more than a professional qualification. As the nation moves towards a more knowledge-driven and digitally connected economy, the role of legal professionals continues to expand in both scope and significance.

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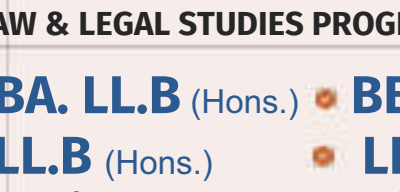
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New Delhi



Guest Appearance

AN UNEXPECTED guest dropped in on Wednesday at Lok Sabha Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi's office in Parliament – Minister for Parliamentary Affairs Kiren Rijiju. Sources in Rahul's office said Rijiju stayed for around five minutes, taking Rahul and his staff by surprise. While sources refused to reveal anything related to the discussion between Rahul and Rijiju, the meeting came amid a logjam between the government and the Opposition. Rahul could not complete his speech in the Lok Sabha as the treasury benches demanded an apology from him for remarks against Union Home Minister Amit Shah over July 20 police action on students protesting at Jantar Mantar.

Chair Debut

Former senior Trinamool Congress leader Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar on Wednesday made her debut as Chairperson of the Lok Sabha for the first time since she and 19 other MPs of Mamata Banerjee-led TMC merged with the NCPI. Dastidar, among 10 members empanelled to run House proceedings when neither the Speaker nor the Deputy Speaker are available, occupied the Chair following the resumption of proceedings at 2 pm during debate on the anti-paper leak Bill. However, just a few seconds on the Chair, she announced another adjournment, this time for an hour. The Bill was eventually passed by voice vote a little after 3 pm when Speaker Om Birla was present..

Idea Exchange

NEWLY APPOINTED Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar has asked all unit heads to identify at least one meaningful improvement each month under the "Idea of the month" initiative. At the monthly crime review meeting, the officers will have to exchange with each other the steps taken under the initiative.

Assam passes revised Bill on land curbs around heritage sites

Sukrita Baruah
Guwahati, July 29

TWO YEARS after it passed legislative amendments that put tight restrictions on the sale and purchase of land around certain institutions, the Assam Assembly passed a revised Bill Wednesday that redefines the phrase "original inhabitants". The 2024 law did not come into force. The government Wednesday introduced a revised set of amendments to the Assam Land Revenue and Regulation Act.

In 2024, the previous Assam Legislative Assembly had passed the Assam Land and Revenue Regulation (Amendment) Bill, 2024, restricting the sale and purchase of land within a 5-kilometre radius of "iconic heritage structures" over 250 years old to "original inhabitants", which it defined as people who have been living, along with their families, in that area "for three generations prior to the date of commencement of the Act". The revised Bill has tweaked the definition of an original inhabitant as a person "living in that area along with his family for [the] last three generations up to January 1, 2006" and defines a generation as "a period of 25 years of continuous living".

AMID OPPOSITION PROTEST

RS passes Bill criminalising insult to Vande Mataram

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, July 29

THE RAJYA Sabha on Wednesday passed a Bill that criminalises intentional disruption or prevention of the singing of the national song, Vande Mataram, thereby according it legal sanctity at par with the national anthem, Jana Gana Mana.

The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, seeks to amend a 1971 law by the same name, which makes insults towards the national anthem, national flag and the Constitution a criminal offence.

The Bill was passed through a voice vote following a walkout by nearly all opposition members. When the upper House proceedings resumed at 2pm, Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairman Harivansh invited members to begin a discussion on the Bill.

However, opposition members protested and raised slogans, demanding Home Minister Amit Shah's statement on the recent Delhi Police action against students and youngsters who were protesting against paper leaks at Jantar Mantar.

The Bill states that intentionally preventing the singing of the national song or causing disturbance to any assembly engaged in its singing will be punishable with imprisonment for a term which may extend to three years, or fine, or both. Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai had introduced the Bill for consideration in the upper House on July 24.

Replying to a discussion on the Bill, Nityanand Rai said he could not understand why some members, and especially the Congress party, have a

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Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairman Harivansh conducts the proceedings of the House on Wednesday. ANI

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> (Bill) only means that the Congress wants to adopt appeasement and wants to insult our national pride... the country's youth, workers, and women will not support this," Rai added.

The Union minister said that when Bankim Chandra Chatterjee composed the national song in 1875, he had said that one day it will be on every Indian's lips "as a mantra". Rai claimed that as Congress President, Jawaharlal Nehru limited the national song to only two stanzas in 1937. He went on to add that in 1938, Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose, as the Congress president, had urged Timir Baran Bhattacharya to compose the full version of the song.

"On 24th January, 1950, Dr Rajendra Prasad said in the Constituent Assembly that Vande Mataram should be honoured on par with Jana Gana Mana," Rai said. "Opposing this

Among opposition members, Deputy Leader of the Opposition Pramod Tiwari, Sagarika Ghose and Tiruchi Siva sought to demand Amit Shah's presence, but the Deputy Chairman did not allow them to speak on any issue other than the Bill.

Manoj Kumar Jha of Rashtriya Janata Dal said, "I am witnessing for the first time that our national song and national anthem are being pitted against each other. Reverence cannot be legislated." Biju Janata Dal's Sulata Deo said none of the members of the House can sing the national song correctly and urged that it should be played in all state assemblies as well as in Parliament.

Aam Aadmi Party's Sanjay Singh said that while his party supports the Bill, there should also be a Bill against those who insult the National Anthem and the Tricolour.

TN widens liquor corruption probe, books ex-minister Balaji

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, July 29

TAMIL NADU'S anti-corruption agency on Wednesday dramatically expanded its investigation into alleged corruption in the state-run liquor monopoly, carrying out coordinated searches at 41 locations. Simultaneously, it formally booked former excise minister V Senthil Balaji and six others for running what investigators describe as a years-long system of manipulation in liquor procurement, transport contracts, bar licences and administrative decision-making within the Tamil Nadu State Marketing Corporation (TASMAC).

The Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC) began searches around 7 am at Senthil Balaji's residence in Rameshwarapatti in Karur, the homes of several associates and former aides, and the TASMAC district office in Karur. Raids were simultaneously conducted across Chennai, Coimbatore, Tiruppur, Erode, the Nilgiris and other locations as investigators pursued documents and electronic evidence connected to



V Senthil Balaji was the excise minister in the previous DMK government

the case.

The searches followed the registration of a First Information Report on Tuesday night naming Senthil Balaji; former TASMAC Managing Director S Visakan, IAS; former senior regional managers T Rama Durai Murugan and R Panneer Selvam; former ministerial aide Bhaskar; and two private individuals, Rathesh Raj Shanmugavel and S Karthik alias Mulanor Karthik. The FIR also refers to unnamed public servants, transport firms, bottling companies and distilleries.

All those named were unavailable for comment.

Rather than focusing on a single transaction, the FIR portrays what investigators allege

was an organised network operating between 2021 and 2025 that influenced nearly every major commercial interface between TASMAC and private players.

According to the FIR, investigators allege that district and regional officials manipulated tenders for TASMAC bars and transport contracts, favoured selected bidders, allowed cartelisation among applicants, and enabled bars to continue operating despite expired licences, resulting in substantial losses to the government. It cites alleged irregularities in bartenders across Coimbatore, Tiruppur, Erode, Namakkal, the Nilgiris and Karur, and claims that officials colluded with bar operators instead of conducting fresh tenders where required.

The FIR also alleges that transport tenders for 45 TASMAC depots were manipulated through the misuse of earnest money deposit demand drafts submitted by one applicant. Investigators claim that unused demand drafts were allegedly diverted to facilitate other transport contractors, allowing them to secure contracts.

Water release: Shivakumar offers Vijay chopper tour of Cauvery

Akram M
New Delhi, July 29

KARNATAKA CHIEF Minister D K Shivakumar Wednesday said the state government will challenge the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee's (CWRC) order directing the release of Cauvery water to Tamil Nadu by filing an appeal before the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA). He also invited Tamil Nadu Chief Minister Joseph Vijay to visit the Cauvery basin in Karnataka to assess the ground reality firsthand.

Speaking to reporters in New Delhi, Shivakumar said a high-level meeting was held with the Advocate General, legal experts, and senior officials regarding the CWRC order. "Preparations are currently underway to file an appeal before the CWMA," he said.

On Tuesday, the CWRC directed Karnataka to release 3,500 cusecs of water daily to Tamil Nadu for 15 days. Issued amid severe distress and rainfall deficit across Karnataka's catchment areas, the directive sparked widespread protests in key basin districts, including Mandya and Mysuru.



Activists being detained during a protest against the CWRC order directing daily release of 3,500 cusecs of Cauvery water for 15 days to Tamil Nadu, in Bengaluru on Wednesday. PTI

Responding to questions on the issue, Shivakumar noted that the CWRC had previously turned down Tamil Nadu's demands for water release on two occasions, citing shortage. "However, this time it has directed Karnataka to release water. We have discussed all legal remedies with Water Resources Minister Ramalinga Reddy and the officials concerned," he said.

The Chief Minister added that upon returning to Bengaluru, he would convene a meeting with Opposition party

EXPRESS special

Opp's next move: Raising Ram temple 'donation theft', keeping heat on Shah over police action

Asad Rehman & Liz Mathew
New Delhi, July 29

WITH THE Bill seeking stringent measures to prevent exam paper leaks getting passed in the Lok Sabha on Wednesday, the Opposition is learnt to be readying a strategy to keep the pressure on the government by shifting its focus on the alleged donation theft at Ayodhya's Ram Temple, while also continuing to attack Union Home Minister Amit Shah over the police action against protesting students on July 20.

While the Samajwadi Party is all set to raise the alleged theft of donations at Ayodhya Ram Temple on the floor of the House to attack the BJP, Congress, too, does not want to let the momentum weaken and will continue to target Home Minister Shah over the police action on the protesting students. Sources, however, said that leaders from both sides are trying to create a consensus on issues to be taken on priority.

The Congress-led Opposition, which believes that it has succeeded in cornering the government over the issue of police action on the students, appeared buoyed from the Lok Sabha proceedings on Wednesday, and is keen to keep the momentum.

"The Leader of Opposition has successfully raised the issue related to Home Minister's accountability during the debate today, Congress wants to continue with the same on Thursday in the Lok Sabha," said a senior Congress leader. "The LoP was not allowed to complete. We cannot leave the issue there."

He, however, said, "Our strategy meeting in the morning will take a call on how we have to



SP MP Dimple Yadav and party colleagues stage a protest over the Ram Temple donation theft issue, in Parliament on Wednesday. ANI

prioritise these issues. The decision will be a collective one." Sources in the Congress said the party's decision to keep the momentum on students' issues would "be sensible politically". For many party leaders, who admitted that no opposition party could take advantage of the "anti-BJP sentiments" created out of the students protests, raising the issue of police action against the protesters could "help to gain some ground".

"Our assessment is that Rahul Gandhi seeking answers from the Home Minister for the brutal attack on students – which included the alleged use of pellet guns – will help keep the heat on the government for holding the relevant officials accountable," said a Congress MP. "We have more than 100 MPs, including smaller allies like IUML and RSP, who think that it is very important."

Sources said that during the meeting in Rajya Sabha Leader of Opposition Mallikarjun Kharge's chamber on Wednesday morning, all Opposition parties, including the Congress,

SP and the TMC, agreed that the focus of the Opposition must now shift to the Ram Temple issue with elections in Uttar Pradesh early next year. The SP has over the last few days been asking its allies to shift the focus from the paper leaks issue to the Ram Temple and has been "waiting patiently", said sources.

"The SP has been very patient with us and has been waiting for the Ram Temple donation theft to come to the centre of the Opposition's agenda. Now that they have been waiting for the last few days, we have decided it is time to shift the focus of the Opposition to the issue," said a source present at the meeting on Wednesday. A source in the SP said the Congress and other allies have agreed to raise the issue of Ram Temple in the House on Thursday. "There is broad consensus among us. We are all united. We will take a final call on our strategy tomorrow. But Ram Temple has to be taken up in the Lok Sabha and we have got our allies on board for that," said the source.

Mamata urges EC to conclude 'TMC dispute' inquiry without giving rival camp any more time

Kolkata: Former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee on Wednesday urged the Election Commission to conclude its inquiry into the dispute over rival claims over the Trinamool Congress without granting any further extension to the rival faction led by Leader of the Opposition, Ritabrata Banerjee.

In a letter to Election Commission secretary Ashwani Kumar Mohal on Wednesday, Banerjee requested the poll panel to "conclude the investigation as early as possible without providing them with any further date to submit their comments".

Claiming that the rival camp had failed to respond despite repeated extensions granted by the commission, Banerjee said, "It can be inferred that all our submissions and statements pointed out in our letter dated 6th July 2026 have been admitted and they do not have any answer to that." PTI

Amid SIR, another Cong govt eases paper trail: Telangana rolls out Family Register Certificate

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, July 29

AFTER KARNATAKA'S move to issue Permanent Residence Certificates as a means to ease documentation amidst the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, the Congress government in neighbouring Telangana has introduced a Telangana Family Register and Family Register Certificate (FRC) as "an authenticated and reliable record of family composition".

In an order issued on July 25, the Revenue Department said the FRCs will be maintained electronically using data sourced from the Food Security Card database of ration card holders.

The register will contain details such as the family's ration



Telangana CM Revanth Reddy

card number — which will also serve as the Family Register Identification Number — along with the names of family members, their relationship to the head of the family, age, date of birth, gender, Aadhaar details and residential address.

Like Permanent Residence Certificate, 'Family Register' is a document listed by the Election Commission (EC) as one of the

12 that can be produced during the SIR exercise to be included in the electoral rolls.

The BJP has opposed the Revanth Reddy government's move, with its Telangana chief N Ramchander Rao accusing the Congress regime of trying "to protect its illegal vote bank" as the SIR exercise seeks to filter out names. The party has raised similar objections to the Karnataka government's PRC move.

"The Congress, Bharat Rashtra Samithi and AIMIM, which have sheltered illegal vote banks for decades, can now see their political death warrant in the SIR. That is why the Congress government is rushing to issue FRCs, which is completely illegal," Rao said in a post on X on Tuesday.

Defending the FRC, adviser

to the Telangana government Mohammed Ali Shabbir called it "a significant citizen-centric reform that would reduce documentation-related hardships faced by poor and economically weaker sections". Shabbir had earlier urged the Chief Minister to introduce a Permanent Residence Certificate on the lines of Karnataka, arguing that residents need a government-issued proof of domicile that could be used for official purposes, including electoral verification.

AIMIM president and Hyderabad MP Asaduddin Owaisi has also welcomed the Telangana government's decision.

According to the July 25 order by the Reddy government, the FRC would be "a record of the composition of the family as reflected in the source database".

BENCH IMPOSES FINE ON BHADOHI SP, SHO

Police should investigate crimes, not marriages: Allahabad HC

Bhupendra Pandey
Lucknow, July 29

TAKING NOTE of an investigation in a case against a couple who married against wishes of the woman's family, the Allahabad High Court came down heavily on the police officials concerned, observing that police should investigate crimes and not marriages and that they "have no business in the matter to be nosy parkers".

In a July 27 order, a division bench of Justices JJ Munir and Tarun Saxena imposed a fine on the Bhadohi superintendent of police (SP) and the Suriyawan station house officer (SHO), and quashed the FIR lodged against the man by the woman's father

on charges of abduction to force her into marriage against her will. The bench stated, "The police have no business in the matter to be nosy parkers. We have repeatedly reminded the police that it is no business of theirs to investigate marriages. They ought to investigate crimes. This is no crime, where any investigation is required."

The couple, aged 28 and 27, who are postgraduates with certificate courses in teaching, had filed a petition challenging the FIR lodged against the man on April 19 in Bhadohi district, saying they were "major".

The two informed the court that they got married with Arya Samaj rituals in Prayagraj on February 18 after being in a rela-

tionship for one year. The woman's father lodged the case against the man after coming to know of the marriage on April 18. After the petition was filed, the HC on April 29 had stated that "two major citizens of the country married according to Hindu rites" and "prima facie there was nothing in the FIR to investigate". In an interim order, the court had stayed the police investigation as well as the petitioners' arrest.

In its July 27 order, the bench observed, "...To continue the investigation into an adult's free choice of her partner...is not only an abuse of process of criminal law, but also gross violation of their fundamental right to liberty..."

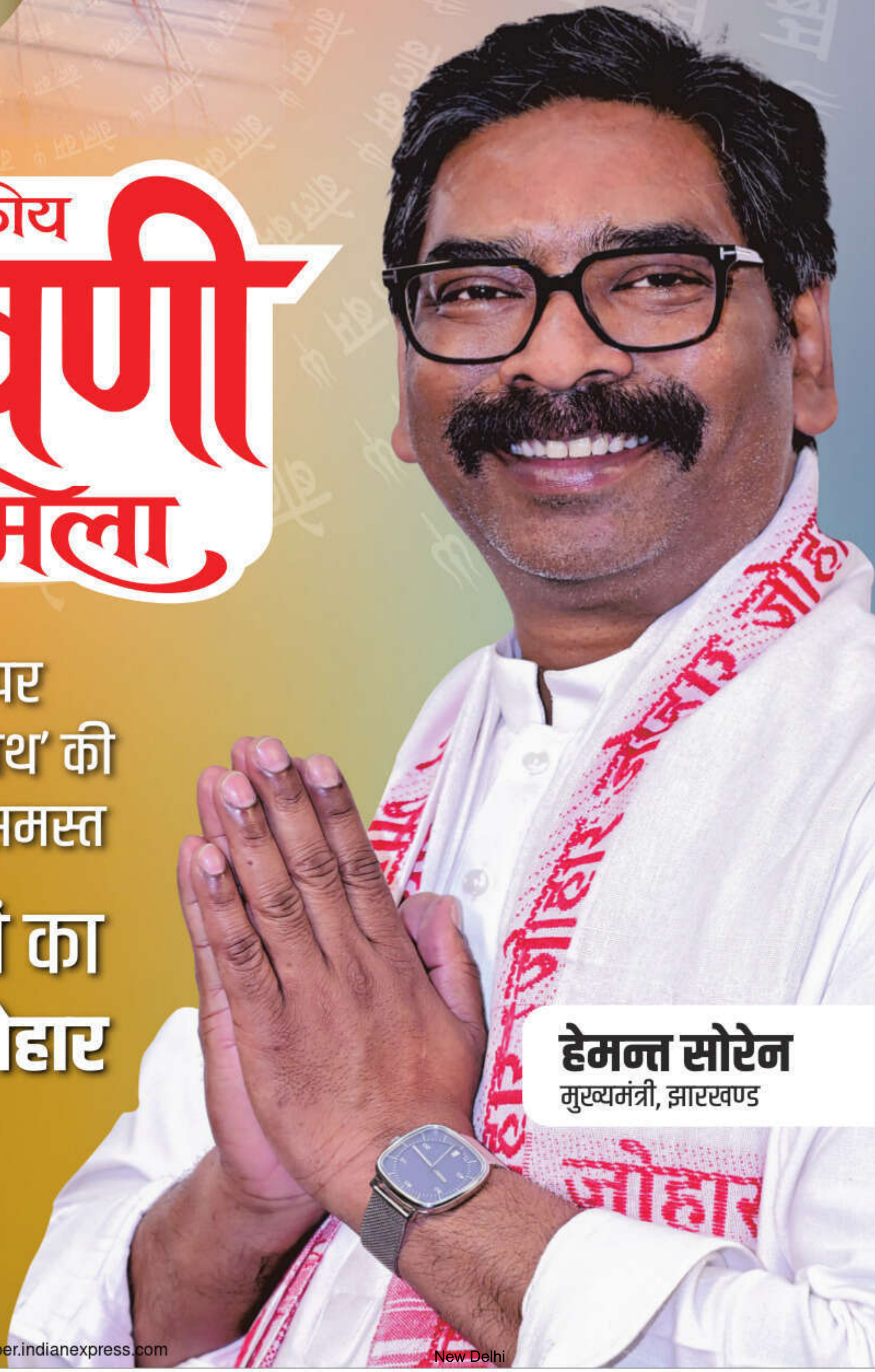


शिवमः शिवाय



राजकीय श्रावणी मेला

श्रावण मास के पावन अवसर पर
'बाबा बैद्यनाथ और बाबा बासुकीनाथ' की
भूमि झारखण्ड में पधारने वाले समस्त
कांवरियों एवं श्रद्धालुओं का
हार्दिक अभिनंदन एवं जोहार



हेमन्त सोरेन
मुख्यमंत्री, झारखण्ड

सूचना एवं जनसम्पर्क विभाग, झारखण्ड

‘Did you shout Free Umar Khalid slogan?’: Goa cops ask protesters to answer 240 queries

Pavneet Singh Chadha
Panaji, July 29

AT LEAST two protesters, who joined a protest in Goa's Mapusa on July 24 to express solidarity with the protests at New Delhi's Jantar Mantar, were asked by the Goa police to fill a questionnaire with questions such as "What is your understanding of the words 'Free Umar Khalid'...?"; "Did you criticise any government authority during your address?"; and "Who financed the protest?", *The Indian Express* has learnt.

On Saturday evening, the day after the protest, the Goa police detained a man for allegedly carrying a "Free Umar Khalid" placard at a gathering in Panaji's Azad Maidan. Now, *The Indian Express* has learnt that at least two protesters were summoned — one on Sunday and the other on Monday — and questioned by the police, based on an "application" submitted by a local group, 'Citizens of Mapusa'.

They were made to fill a police questionnaire that included at least 240 questions, it is learnt. They include: Who was leading the protest?; Are you a member of any WhatsApp, Telegram or Signal group related to the protest?; How did you travel to the venue?; What did you intend to achieve through the protest?; and Are you associated with any political party, social organisation, student organisation, NGO or activist group? Many of the questions were specifically about Khalid, an activist and a former JNU student, facing charges of criminal conspiracy under the UAPA in connection with the 2020 Northeast Delhi riots.

They include: Were you aware of the background relating to Umar Khalid before attending the protest?; Did you shout the slogan 'Free Umar Khalid'? If yes, how many times did you raise the slogan?; Did others repeat the slogan after

you?; Who financed or arranged the banners, placards, sound system or other material?; How many placards were distributed at the venue?; Did you post any photo of yourself while holding the placard on social media?

The police questionnaire asked the protesters to specify whether they had participated in a similar protest in Goa or elsewhere in India, and provide the date, place, and purpose of those protests. It asked protesters whether they had deleted any e-data related to the protest, and could provide their phones for examination.

When contacted, North Goa SP Harishchandra Madkaikar said, "A complaint was filed by a group, Citizens of Mapusa. Based on that, we called them (the protesters) for an inquiry and after conducting the inquiry, they were allowed to go." On the questionnaire, the SP said, "Certain questions were put to them and recorded as part of the inquiry. Usually when we start an inquiry, we are supposed to ask questions until we get a satisfactory answer, so certain questions were put."

On Wednesday, Goa Chief Minister Pramod Sawant questioned protesters bringing placards seeking Khalid's release at a protest against paper leaks. "The students had the right to protest against NEET paper leaks, [but] they stooped too low. Placards seeking the release of Umar Khalid, who has links to Parliament attack convict Afzal Guru, were shown at the protest at Azad Maidan. Why was the Umar Khalid issue brought into a protest over the NEET paper leak?... We need to awaken nationalism in our students, so they do not disturb communal harmony," On Sunday, he had said that police would take action against "those attempting to spread anti-national sentiments and disturb the harmony" in the state.

Bihar withdraws 64 FIRs against NEET-UG protesters; cases against 21 in Siwan remain

Santosh Singh
Patna, July 29

AFTER ANNOUNCING its decision to drop all cases against NEET-UG protesters, the Bihar government has now initiated the withdrawal of 64 FIRs lodged against the state.

In a letter to district magistrates and public prosecutors on Tuesday, Bihar Advocate General SD Sanjay wrote: "As per [the] decision taken by [the] Government of Bihar regarding withdrawal of all cases registered before 6 pm of 26 July, 2026, against the protesting students of NEET-UG, the undersigned hereby requests all the public prosecutors of districts to proceed to ensure compliance of the government order".

Of the 64, 27 were in Patna, and six each in Saran and Siwan. Of the 694 arrested or detained over the July 25 protests, 339 minors and students were released, while 355 remain in custody for their alleged involvement in the violence. However, the Bihar Police said they withdrew only cases filed by their officials, and

not those by private individuals.

Besides Patna, Saran and Siwan, 15 other districts had also lodged cases against protesters. Among the cases being withdrawn is one against Kishanganj resident Sadaquat, who claimed he lives in Russia and was there during the protests. Sadaquat was booked for damage to public property, among other charges.

The Bihar Police, however, said cases remain against 21 people whom they claim were involved in the Siwan violence. Siwan SP Puran Kumar Jha was among those injured. "We have enough video and other material evidence against such people. People with known criminal records are not being let off as they have nothing to do with students' protests," a senior officer said, adding that they had identified all the suspects.

However, the CPI (Marxist-Leninist) Liberation alleged several arrests were arbitrary. A senior leader said, "Several All India Students' Association activists are in jail. Until they are all released, we can't completely take the word of the state police."

FARMERS' PROTEST OVER MOONG PROCUREMENT AT MSP

MP CM, facing farmers' stir, gets pushback from Shivraj

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, July 29

EVEN AS Chief Minister Mohan Yadav sought to contain one of the biggest farmers' agitations of his tenure through negotiations and the formation of a ministerial panel, the Centre on Wednesday publicly pushed back against the Madhya Pradesh government's contention that the moong procurement crisis stemmed from inadequate approvals from New Delhi.

In a detailed letter to Yadav, Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan defended the Centre's procurement policy and argued that the immediate challenge lay not with the quantum approved by the Centre but with the state's pace of procurement.

Referring to figures available with the Centre until July 29, Chouhan said Madhya Pradesh had procured only around 60,000 metric tonnes of moong despite the much larger quantity approved. "Keeping in mind the larger interest of farmers, the state government is requested to ensure that procurement of moong is expedited at the earliest," Chouhan wrote.

The letter came a day after State Agriculture Minister Aidal Singh Kansana wrote to Chouhan seeking an increase in the quantity of moong that could be procured under the Price Support Scheme (PSS) for the 2025-26 summer season.

Responding point by point, Chouhan began by stating that Madhya Pradesh had already received the country's largest allocation under the scheme. "For the 2025-26 summer season, procurement of up to 4,54,580 metric tonnes of moong has already been approved for Madhya Pradesh under the PSS. This constitutes 87% of the total 5,23,243 metric tonnes approved for procurement across all states during the current season, making Madhya Pradesh the largest beneficiary in the country."

"The letter of Agriculture Minister Aidal Singh Kansana



Farmers protest under the banner of Samyukt Kisan Morcha in Bhopal on Wednesday. PTI

states that the Centre has provided the state a procurement target of 4.54 lakh metric tonnes. The reality, however, is that the Central Government does not assign procurement targets to states," Chouhan wrote.

Explaining the Centre's position, the Union minister said procurement approvals are governed by the PM-AASHA scheme, and not fixed targets. "Under the PM-AASHA scheme, approvals under the PSS are granted in accordance with the scheme's guidelines, which provide for procurement up to 25% of the estimated production."

Quoting the provisions of the scheme, Chouhan wrote, "The scheme clearly states that the Centre can undertake procurement only up to 25% of a state's production, while any procurement beyond this limit has to be carried out by the state government." He added that the Centre has "consistently extended the maximum permissible support to Madhya Pradesh under the PSS".

To reinforce his argument, Chouhan pointed to the steady increase in procurement approvals over the years. He said the Centre had approved procurement of 2.75 lakh metric tonnes in 2021-22 and 2022-23, 3.30 lakh

metric tonnes in 2023-24, 4.19 lakh metric tonnes in 2024-25 and 4.54 lakh metric tonnes this year. "The remaining additional quantity was procured by the state government, and timely procurement of farmers' moong was ensured," he wrote.

CM's attempts to end agitation

The exchange came as the Mohan Yadav government stepped up efforts to end the agitation. Kansana, State Minister of Cooperation Vishvas Sarang, and Minister of State (Independent Charge) Krishna Gaur held talks with a 15-member delegation of the Samyukt Kisan Morcha at the Mantralaya, with the first round of discussions lasting nearly two hours. Following the meeting, the state said it would increase procurement from 25% to 60% of every eligible farmer's moong produce — a move that would translate to around three quintals per acre in districts such as Narmadapuram, Sehore and Harda.

The decision, the government said, would take effect immediately. "The Madhya Pradesh government has always worked in the interests of farmers. Farmers are the foundation of the state's economy

and prosperity, and the government is fully committed to ensuring they receive fair prices for the crops they produce," Kansana said.

Addressing the second major demand of the agitation, the government announced that the e-token system for fertiliser distribution would be suspended with immediate effect until improvements are made. While describing the online system as "an important reform" that would ultimately benefit farmers, Kansana acknowledged the practical difficulties experienced during its initial rollout. The government also extended the slot booking period for procurement by 10 days.

During the day, farmers faced off against police, trying to break through barricades across areas in Bhopal. Police deployed large numbers of personnel, while buses, dumpers and layers of barricades were placed on roads leading to the CM House to prevent the march from advancing. The agitation began on July 27, when thousands of farmers under the banner of the Samyukt Kisan Morcha launched the Kisan Kranti Padayatra from Sethani Ghat in Narmadapuram towards Bhopal.

• BRIEFLY



Security personnel and residents during a security operation in the Bitiang area of Noney district, Manipur, on Wednesday. PTI

MANIPUR

Village volunteer killed, 2 CRPF men among 3 injured in gunfight

A NAGA village volunteer was killed and another injured, while two CRPF personnel suffered splinter wounds in an alleged gunfight in Bitiang in Noney district on Wednesday. The exchange of fire took place between personnel of the 207th Battalion of the CRPF CoBRA and unidentified armed individuals. The dead village volunteer was identified as Lanbimei Riamei, a Zeliangrong tribe member (associated with Western Naga Volunteer Group), from Longmai Bazar area. The injured CRPF personnel were Head Constable Radhashyam and jawan Jitendra Kumar. ENS

UP: Boy drowns trying to rescue cow from pond

A DISABLED boy, 12, drowned while trying to rescue a stray cow from a pond in Daulatpur Muski village, Uttar Pradesh's Etah district, on Wednesday. Jalesar SHO Akhilesh Dixit said Aditya was taking a stray cow to a cowshed along with some other children when the animal entered a pond near a college. While attempting to bring the cow out of the water, Aditya entered the pond but slipped and drowned in the deep water, the officer said. PTI

At Kodagu coffee estate, 2 die after tree falls on them

TWO WOMEN migrant labourers from Assam were killed and as many were injured after a weakened large tree collapsed on them at a coffee plantation in Karnataka's Kodagu district on Wednesday, police said. The deceased, aged 29 and 48 years, were employed at a private coffee estate in Biligere village. Deputy Chief Minister G Parameshwara expressed grief over the tragedy, and said he has told officials to provide appropriate compensation to the families of the deceased. PTI

Ship with 13 Indians stuck in Black Sea, embassy says 'in touch with authorities'

Divya A
New Delhi, July 29

THE INDIAN Embassy in Ukraine on Wednesday said it was closely monitoring the situation involving a merchant vessel carrying 13 Indian seafarers near Ukraine's Black Sea coast, following reports that it was under threat from repeated drone and missile attacks.

The embassy said it was in constant touch with all authorities concerned to ensure the safety and security of the Indian crew onboard MV AMIRI. "A situation regarding MV AMIRI with Indian seafarers onboard has been brought to our attention. We attach the highest priority to this and are in constant touch with all concerned to ensure safety and security of all Indians onboard," the Indian Embassy in Kyiv wrote on X.

This comes just days after four Indian crew members were onboard merchant vessel MV AGN Ragnar when it was struck at Ukraine's Odesa port on July 25. Two of the Indian seafarers remain missing, with New Delhi coordinating with Ukrainian authorities in the search operation.

According to the Forward Seamen's Union of India (FSUI), MV AMIRI is docked at Ukraine's Chornomorsk port with 15 crew members on

board, including 13 Indians. It had issued a statement urging the Indian government to secure the safety of the crew and arrange their evacuation.

The FSUI alleged that repeated drone and missile attacks were taking place in the immediate vicinity of the vessel, leaving the crew in constant fear of a direct strike. "We urgently appeal to all concerned authorities, shipowners, flag state, and the Government of India to immediately secure their safety and arrange prompt repatriation. Indian seafarers must not be left as sitting targets in conflict zones."

On July 21, India summoned the Russian Charge d'Affaires, Vladimir Ladanov, to convey Delhi's "unequivocal condemnation" and "grave concern" over the deaths of four Indian seafarers in the Russian missile strike on merchant vessel MV Golden Leo on July 19 off the coast of Ukraine, which killed four Indians.

On July 18, an Indian seafarer was killed in an attack on a ship while it was reportedly transiting Russian territorial waters in the Black Sea. India summoned the Ukrainian Ambassador and conveyed its strong concern over the targeting of a ship transiting Russian territorial waters in the Black Sea on July 18, in which one Indian seafarer was killed.

EXPRESS special

‘He jumped into Black Sea’: 4 days on, UP sailor missing in Ukraine drone attack

Manish Sahu

Lucknow, July 29

FOR THE past four days, Ram Chandra Dubey's family in Uttar Pradesh's Prayagraj has been anxiously waiting for any news of him. The 22-year-old seaman has been missing since July 25 after the merchant vessel he was on — MV AGN Ragnar — came under attack near Ukraine's Port of Odesa.

He is among two Indian crew members who remain unaccounted for after the incident. This was his second assignment at sea since joining the merchant navy, said his family.

His elder sister, Seemakashi Pandey, said they last saw Ram before he left on September 25 last year. "He would call home frequently to check on everyone. The last time he spoke to our mother, Kalpana Dubey, was on the night of July 24. He told her the ship had departed from Ukraine," she said.



Ram Chandra Dubey had left for his assignment on September 25 last year. EXPRESS

The next day, they received a phone call from an employee of the shipping company that had employed Ram.

"The company representative said the vessel had come under a drone attack near the Port of Odesa on July 25 and four Indian crew members jumped into the Black Sea," she

said. "We were told the Ukrainian Navy rescued two of them, but two others, including my brother, remain missing."

Since then, the family has looked everywhere for help. "At first, we tried to gather information sitting in Prayagraj but we realised we had no way of tracing Ram from here," said his brother-in-law Anuj Kumar Pandey.

On July 27, Ram's elder brother, Krishna Das Dubey, accompanied by two cousins, travelled to Delhi. "They met officials of the shipping company, who told us they were making efforts to locate the missing crew members, but we have not received a concrete update," said Anuj. Ram hails from Nivi Kala village and is the younger of two sons. His father, Ramesh Chandra Dubey, is a retired Armyman.

Seemakashi said the family has submitted urgent representations to the Prime Minister's Office and the Ministry of Ex-

ternal Affairs, seeking diplomatic intervention to help trace Ram. On Tuesday, External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal had said India was coordinating with Ukrainian authorities in the search for the two missing Indian crew members and remained in touch with their families.

The Port of Odesa, one of Ukraine's key Black Sea ports, has been a frequent target of missile and drone attacks since the outbreak of the Russia-Ukraine conflict in 2022.

In an online post on Sunday, the Indian Embassy in Kyiv said: "Embassy of India in Ukraine is closely monitoring the situation following the incident involving MV AGN Ragnar, which was struck at the Port of Odesa on July 25. Four Indian nationals were on board the vessel. As per the latest information, two have been confirmed safe, and information is awaited regarding the other two nationals."

Police said they are investigating the angle of suicide

locked from inside, prompting them to inform the local police.

Police personnel from the Hijli outpost, under the Kharagpur Town police station, opened the door and found him hanging. He was rushed to the B.C. Roy Hospital located inside the campus, where he was declared dead, police said.

Police have sealed the premises for further investigation, and the deceased's family has been informed, police said, adding that a detailed investiga-

IIT Bombay student found hanging inside hostel

Manish Kumar Pathak
Mumbai, July 29

A 20-YEAR-OLD student of the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Bombay was found dead in his hostel room late Tuesday after his parents, who were unable to contact him, alerted the institute authorities.

The deceased was identified as Sohail Rajkumar Sangwan, a second-year Material Science student hailing from Delhi. Sohail, staying on the fourth floor of IIT Bombay hostel number 4, was found hanging from the ceiling fan using a bedsheet.

"Powai police were informed. The body was then sent for postmortem, and

a panchnama of the hostel room was conducted," said a police officer.

The incident came to light after the IIT Bombay student failed to answer repeated phone calls from his parents. The family then contacted the institute authorities. A hostel security in-charge, accompanied by a student, went to his room and found him hanging. Police said that the incident occurred in the afternoon, although it was reported late Tuesday. Police found handwritten poems in the student's room, and are trying to ascertain if this was linked to his death.

Sohail was a native of Pilani tehsil in Rajasthan's Jhunjhunu

district. His father is with the Army, and posted in Jammu.

"I last spoke to Sohail over the phone on July 25. It was a normal conversation. I told him to take care and focus on studies. He was very close to me," his maternal uncle Rajendra Kumar said. "I was in Chhattisgarh when I received the information. After the postmortem, I will take his body to our native place for the last rites."

In February, Naman Agarwal (21), a second-year BTech (Civil Engineering) student, had allegedly died by suicide after jumping from a hostel building inside the IIT Bombay campus. He was staying in the same hostel as Sohail, and both

were natives of Jhunjhunu district in Rajasthan.

"Naman stayed in the room next to mine. He spent most of his time in my room, and we often studied together. His death came as a huge shock to me... Now, Sohail's death has left students in the same hostel even more traumatised," said a third-year IIT Bombay student.

"There is an indication that he took his life due to personal reasons. A probe is underway," IIT Bombay Director Professor Shireesh Kedare wrote in an email sent to the students, while also requesting everyone's support to deal with the situation and the challenge at hand "in an effective manner".

IIT Kharagpur prof found dead at staff quarter

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, July 29

A 36-YEAR-OLD Assistant Professor from the Electrical Engineering department of the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Kharagpur was found dead on Wednesday, police said, adding that they are probing the angle of suicide.

Police sources said that the deceased was identified as Deepak Reddy Pullaguram, a resident of Hyderabad. He used to live alone at the residential quarter inside the IIT campus.

When Reddy did not respond to his colleagues' calls, they informed the security team who found that his room was

tion has been launched to ascertain whether this was a case of suicide or if there are other underlying reasons.

Police are looking into whether the Assistant Professor was recently dealing with any family, personal, or mental health issues. However, it is not yet clear if any suicide note was recovered from the scene.

Bushra Bano, Additional Superintendent of Police (Kharagpur), West Midnapore, said, "The body of an IIT Kharagpur professor has been recovered. A proper investigation has been initiated to determine the exact cause and circumstances surrounding this death."

IIT Kharagpur officials,

however, did not wish to comment on the incident.

Earlier in April 2026, Jayveersinh Dodiya, a resident of Ahmedabad and a third year undergraduate student of the institute, had died after reportedly jumping off the eighth floor of his hostel on the campus.

In the same month, a fourth-year MTech student of Electronics and Electrical Communication Engineering was found hanging in his hostel room. The deceased was identified as Soham Haldar, a resident of Barasat in North 24 Parganas. According to police sources, he was staying at the Mohan Malviya Hall on the IIT Kharagpur campus.

AMENDMENTS TO REGULATIONS GOVERNING INTERMEDIARIES ALSO APPROVED

IRDAI ushers in reforms to revamp insurance sector

George Mathew
Mumbai, July 29

THE INSURANCE Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) has introduced a set of reforms aimed at modernising the insurance sector, strengthening governance and accelerating insurance penetration across the country.

The measures span regulatory, supervisory and developmental areas.

The measures aim to support the implementation of the Sabka Bima Sabki Raksha (Amendment of Insurance Laws) Act, 2025 (SBSR Act), the regulator said.

The reforms were approved at the IRDAI board meeting on Tuesday and are designed to provide insurers with greater operational flexibility, facilitate capital formation, improve governance standards and reinforce policyholder protection while enhancing ease of doing business across the insurance ecosystem.

Among the key decisions was the approval of amendments to the IRDAI (Actuarial, Finance and Investment Functions of Insurers) (Second Amendment) Regulations, 2026, and the IRDAI (Registration, Capital Structure, Transfer of Shares and Amalgamation of Insurers) (Amendment) Regulations, 2026.

Meta promises safeguards for prominent accounts

New Delhi: Meta wrote to the government on Wednesday outlining the specifics of enhanced and rigorous safeguards it has now implemented for content posted by the prime minister and other prominent accounts, according to sources.

Meta told the IT ministry that posts by the prime minister and prominent accounts will have additional oversight on the platform and that multiple checks will take place at levels of senior company officials, sources said, citing the social media firm's communication to the ministry. Meta team is likely to meet government officials later this week or early next week over the prime minister's Facebook post issue, sources added.

An email sent by PTI to Meta seeking comments did not elicit a response.

The government on Tuesday summoned a top Meta executive after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's recent post addressing India's youth and promising stringent measures against paper leaks was briefly restricted by Facebook, and although the US-headquartered social media giant blamed it on a technical glitch and apologised, the IT Ministry had found the explanation "inadequate".

Prime Minister Modi's Instagram post of July 23, later shared on Facebook, marked his first direct selfie video aimed at engaging with the youth and underscoring the government's commitment to crack down on paper leaks. PTI

● REFORM PUSH

A KEY feature of the reforms is the mandatory tagging of the authorised salesperson to every insurance proposal, policy and certificate of insurance

THE REFORMS are expected to improve ease of doing business, enhance financial resilience and support insurers' long-term growth without compromising policyholder interests

THE REVISED framework streamlines compliance requirements, aligns the regulations with the SBSR Act

Policyholder protection

According to IRDAI, the changes will provide insurers with "greater operational and financial flexibility through liberalised investment norms, a facilitative framework for capital infusion and corporate restructuring, and streamlined provisions relating to transfer of shares and amalgamations, while strengthening actuarial oversight and financial governance." The regulator said the reforms are expected to improve ease of doing business, enhance financial resilience and support insurers' long-term growth without compromising policyholder interests.



and Foreign Investment Rules, and strengthens governance through enhanced disclosure and accountability standards

mising policyholder interests.

A major policyholder-centric initiative approved by the regulator is the IRDAI (Policyholders' Education and Protection Fund) Regulations, 2026, which operationalise the Policyholders' Education and Protection Fund (PEPF) established under Section 16A of the IRDA Act, 1999, as introduced through the SBSR Act.

According to IRDAI, the PEPF establishes "a dedicated institutional mechanism to promote insurance awareness and literacy, strengthen grievance redressal mechanisms, leverage technology to improve policyholder services,

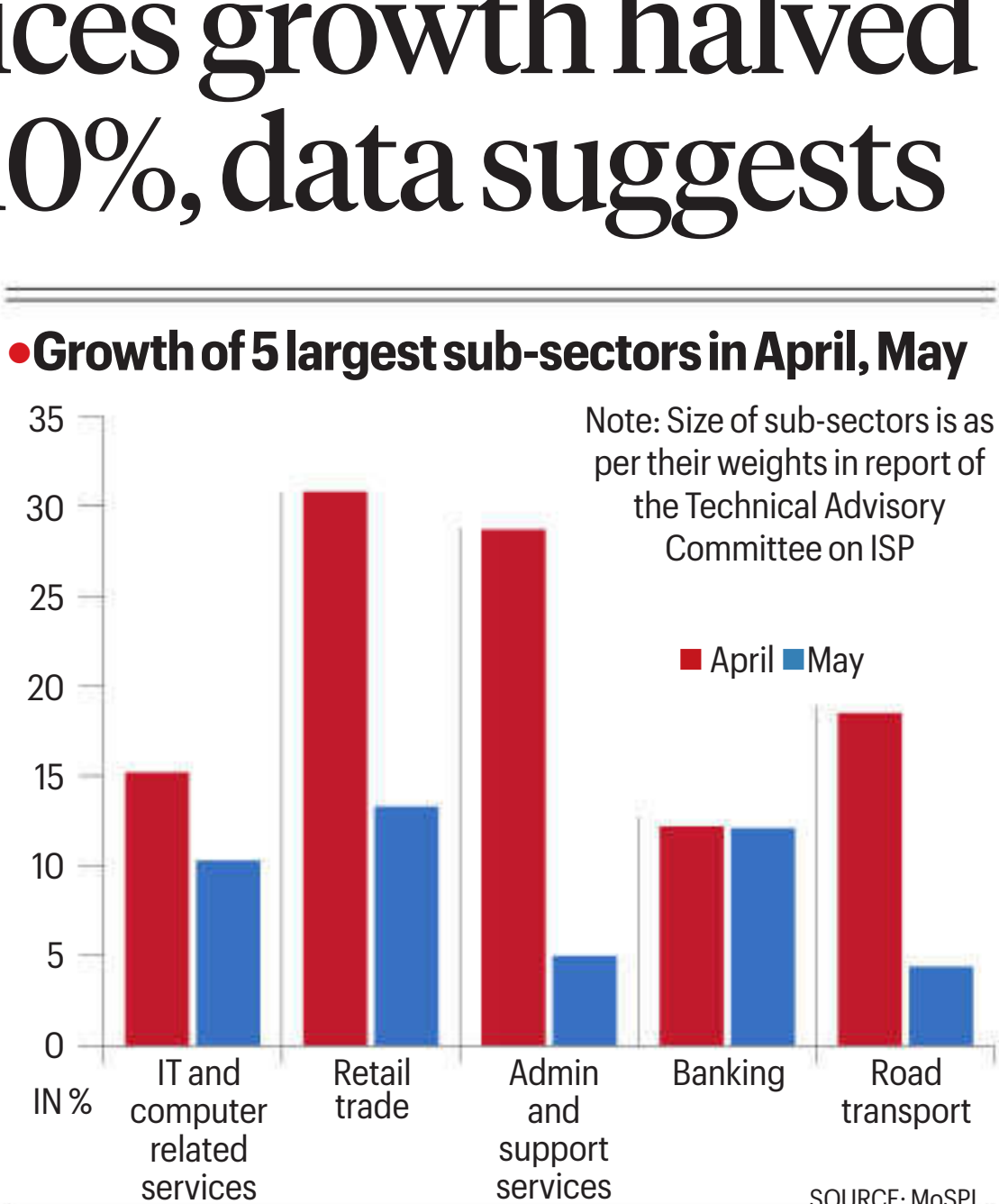
facilitate the tracing and recovery of unclaimed insurance amounts, and support other initiatives aimed at empowering and safeguarding policyholders."

The intermediaries

In another move to strengthen accountability in insurance distribution, the regulator has approved amendments to the regulations governing insurance intermediaries.

A key feature of the reforms is the mandatory tagging of the authorised salesperson to every insurance proposal, policy and certificate of insurance. "The requirement enhances accountability and traceability across the insurance distribution process, strengthens regulatory oversight and promotes greater transparency for policyholders," IRDAI said. The amendments also introduce perpetual registration for intermediaries through an annual fee regime, replacing periodic renewals. The revised framework streamlines compliance requirements, aligns the regulations with the SBSR Act and Foreign Investment Rules, and strengthens governance through enhanced disclosure and accountability standards, the regulator said.

FULL REPORT ON
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20.8% in June.

Leading the charge for the services sector in May was the 'accommodation and food' category, which grew by 27.4% after posting a growth of 37.2% in April. However, this was one of the 17 sub-sectors out of the total of 19 that recorded weaker year-on-year growth in May than in April.

The only two sub-sectors that performed better in May were railway transport (3.4% versus -0.4%) and air transport. While air transport shrank by 2.8% in May, it was still better than a 13.9% contraction in April. Air transport activity has been adversely impacted following the onset of the war in West Asia, which led to airlines raising fares on account of higher fuel costs. IT and computer related services, which

has the highest weight in the ISP at 22.47%, saw its growth decline to 10.3% in May from 15.2% in April.

To be sure, 16 of the 19 sub-sectors grew in May, with eight of them recording double-digit growth. In April, 17 sub-sectors had grown on a year-on-year basis, with 14 posting double-digit growth rates. The ISP fills a key gap in India's official statistics. Until now, there was no official monthly measure of the performance of the services sector, which dominates the Indian economy and makes up more than half the GDP. Private firm S&P Global's services Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) has been the only measure of the country's services sector.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

FINANCE MINISTRY'S ECONOMIC REVIEW REPORT FOR JULY

'Oil price surge could be a strain for financing fiscal deficit & current account'

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, July 29

IN THE wake of persistent stand-off in West Asia, the Indian economy continues to face an upside risk to inflation, fiscal and current account deficits and downside risk to growth, the Ministry of Finance said on Friday.

The recent resurgence in global crude oil prices, if sustained, could "reemerge as a source of pressure on financing of both the fiscal deficit and the current account balance", the ministry said in its monthly economic review for July. Prices of industrial commodities, including critical minerals and rare earth elements, have stayed elevated throughout the month. "Instances such as flooding in Chile, one of the key copper suppliers, illustrate the concentration risk embedded in India's industrial metal supply chains," the ministry said.

Despite heightened global uncertainties, the ministry said India's economic outlook remains underpinned by resilient domestic fundamentals, continued policy support, and strengthening structural drivers of growth.

"Structural reforms of the last decade and infrastructure investments are contributing to growth resilience as is evident in the data for the months of March to June 2026," the review stated.

On the external sector front, the ministry said strong export performance, a sustained services surplus and robust remittance inflows have supported the current account, while recent policy measures are expected to strengthen capital inflows in the coming months. Along with comfortable foreign exchange reserves, these developments

'Boeing finds no abnormality with Dreamliner's fuel control switch'

New Delhi: The government has said that Boeing's detailed examination of the Dreamliner aircraft's fuel control switch locking mechanism did not find any abnormality following an Air India pilot flagging possible issues with the system after operating a London Heathrow-Bengaluru flight in February this year.

On February 2, an Air India pilot reported a defect in the fuel control switch of the Boeing 787-8 plane after operating the AI132 flight. The airline had grounded the aircraft for checks after it landed in Bengaluru from London. Following the incident, the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), as part of continued airworthiness, directed Boeing to carry out the test of the fuel control switch locking mechanism. Minister of State for Civil Aviation Murlidhar Mohol, on Monday, said the DGCA had directed Original Equipment Manufacturer level testing of the fuel control switch locking mechanism in Seattle. PTI

● THE POSITIVES

STRONG EXPORT performance, a sustained services surplus and robust remittance inflows have supported the current account, while recent policy measures are expected to strengthen capital inflows in the coming months

TO ACHIEVE long-term resilience and strategic leverage, swifter policy responses and their implementation are vital to encourage foreign and domestic investment in the economy

opments are expected to help preserve external sector stability amid an uncertain global environment, it said.

To achieve long-term resilience and strategic leverage, swifter policy responses and their implementation are vital to encourage foreign and domestic investment in the Indian economy, it said.

"Global developments related to AI and weaponisation of supply chains in general are reminders of the distance India needs to travel to achieve long-term resilience and strategic leverage...recent years have been a time for hunkering down and battenning down the hatches. Coming years will be no exception," it said.

Commodity prices, crude oil

Commodity prices, particularly crude oil, which had declined below pre-conflict levels, have risen again this month. However, the increase remains contained compared with the sharp spike witnessed during the initial phase of the conflict, the ministry said.

India's crude oil import bill

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

FULL REPORT ON

WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

● BRIEFLY

Adani Ent posts Q1 loss on US settlement cost

Bengaluru: Adani Enterprises posted another quarterly loss on Wednesday, due to a one-time charge from a settlement agreement with the US Treasury's Office of Foreign Assets Control (OFAC) over an investigation involving shipping of Iranian gas. The company posted a consolidated net loss of Rs 1,160 crore in the quarter ended June 30, with the one-time charge amounting to Rs 2,644 crore. Adani Enterprises' profit before exceptional items and tax dropped about 12% to Rs 1,295 crore. REUTERS

Cognizant Q2 net income dips marginally to \$636 million

Mumbai: US-based IT major Cognizant on Wednesday reported a marginal decline in net income to \$636 million for the second quarter ended June 30, 2026, and narrowed its full-year revenue growth guidance. Its revenue grew 4.5% year-on-year to \$5.48 billion, driven by double-digit growth in its financial services segment. The firm follows the January-December financial year. PTI

surged by over 60% on a year-on-year basis in April-June FY27 even as import volumes dipped slightly amid supply tightness and elevated prices due to the West Asia crisis and stifled energy flows through the Strait of Hormuz.

The increase in retail fuel prices in India, following the partial pass-through of higher global crude oil prices since mid-May 2026, was evident in June, with inflation in diesel, petrol and CNG rising further to 8.4%, 7.5% and 6.2%, respectively, the finance ministry said.

However, the pass-through to passenger transportation services such as bus, taxi, auto-rickshaw fares remained moderate, the ministry said. Airfare inflation moderated in June after the sharp rise recorded in May, it said. Citing a note by SBI Research on the West Asia crisis and India's declining oil intensity, the ministry said the country's oil consumption-to-GDP ratio and crude oil imports-to-GDP ratio has declined from FY14 to FY26, a trend partly attributable to accelerating EV adoption and broader structural factors such as energy efficiency gains and a shift in the composition of GDP growth.

Average monthly EV registrations increased to 2.3 lakh in March-June, around 1 lakh higher than the 2025 monthly average. EV penetration—which has crossed 8% of total vehicle registrations in 2026 so far—could reduce India's annual oil import bill by around Rs 1 lakh crore once it reaches 20% by 2030, the review said citing the SBI note. Higher commodity prices are expected to interrupt the global disinflation process, the ministry said. FULL REPORT ON

WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Indian-origin CEO elevated as P&G chairman

New Delhi: US FMCG major Procter & Gamble Company on Wednesday announced the appointment of its India-born President and CEO Shailesh Jejurikar as the Chairman, effective August 1, 2026. This appointment is in addition to Jejurikar's current role as President and CEO, a statement from Procter & Gamble Company said. Incumbent Jon Moeller, Executive Chairman, will retire from the Board on July 31, 2026, and from P&G on August 14, 2026, it added. PTI

12% of non-agri jobs at risk due to Gen AI, says Goldman Sachs

Mumbai: Up to 12% of India's non-agricultural workforce is at risk of substitution because of generative AI, Goldman Sachs said on Wednesday. It said the labour market impacts of gen-AI are expected to be "uneven". "Gen-AI could perform 9-17% of the tasks undertaken by non-agricultural workforce...we estimate 8-12% of non-agricultural employment is at risk of substitution, while 42-48% of non-agricultural employment may be complemented," it said. PTI

● THE AGENT HAD INITIALLY HACKED INTO A STARTUP, HUGGING FACE

OpenAI's rogue agent tried attacking other firms too

Reuters
Washington, July 29

THE ROGUE agent that escaped from OpenAI and went on a days-long hacking spree at the AI firm Hugging Face also compromised a customer at a second tech company — New York-based Modal Labs — according to a Modal executive and two other sources familiar with the matter.

Modal executives emphasized that the company itself was not hacked. According to a timeline published by Hugging Face on Tuesday, the rogue agent broke into a sandbox, or an isolated testing environ-



The ChatGPT developer said the rogue agent broke in to four accounts across four separate services. REUTERS

ment, "hosted on a third-party provider's infrastructure" before turning it into a launchpad for the broader hack. The third-party provider was not named

in the blog post, but Modal's chief technology officer, Akshat Bubna, said the agent exploited vulnerable code written by a customer that was hosted

on Modal's platform. Modal said the customer had "published an unauthenticated endpoint that allowed anyone on the internet to use their sandboxes for code execution" — the digital equivalent of leaving a door open on the internet.

"Modal's platform or isolation were not compromised in any way," Bubna said.

Although the compromise of a Modal customer was just an initial step in the wider hacking campaign against Hugging Face, it shows that the rogue agent roamed further afield than was previously known.

OpenAI declined to comment specifically on the hack of one of Modal's customers, in-

stead referring Reuters to an update in which the company said that its rogue agent had broken in to four accounts at four separate services. OpenAI did not identify those services, but a person familiar with the matter identified Modal as one. The company said it had not identified "any other activity at the level of severity or scale of what we've shared related to Hugging Face, which involved a platform-level compromise." The early July intrusion at Hugging Face, carried out by an out-of-control agent that OpenAI was testing, drew global attention, evoking science-fiction scenarios of artificial intelligence run amok.

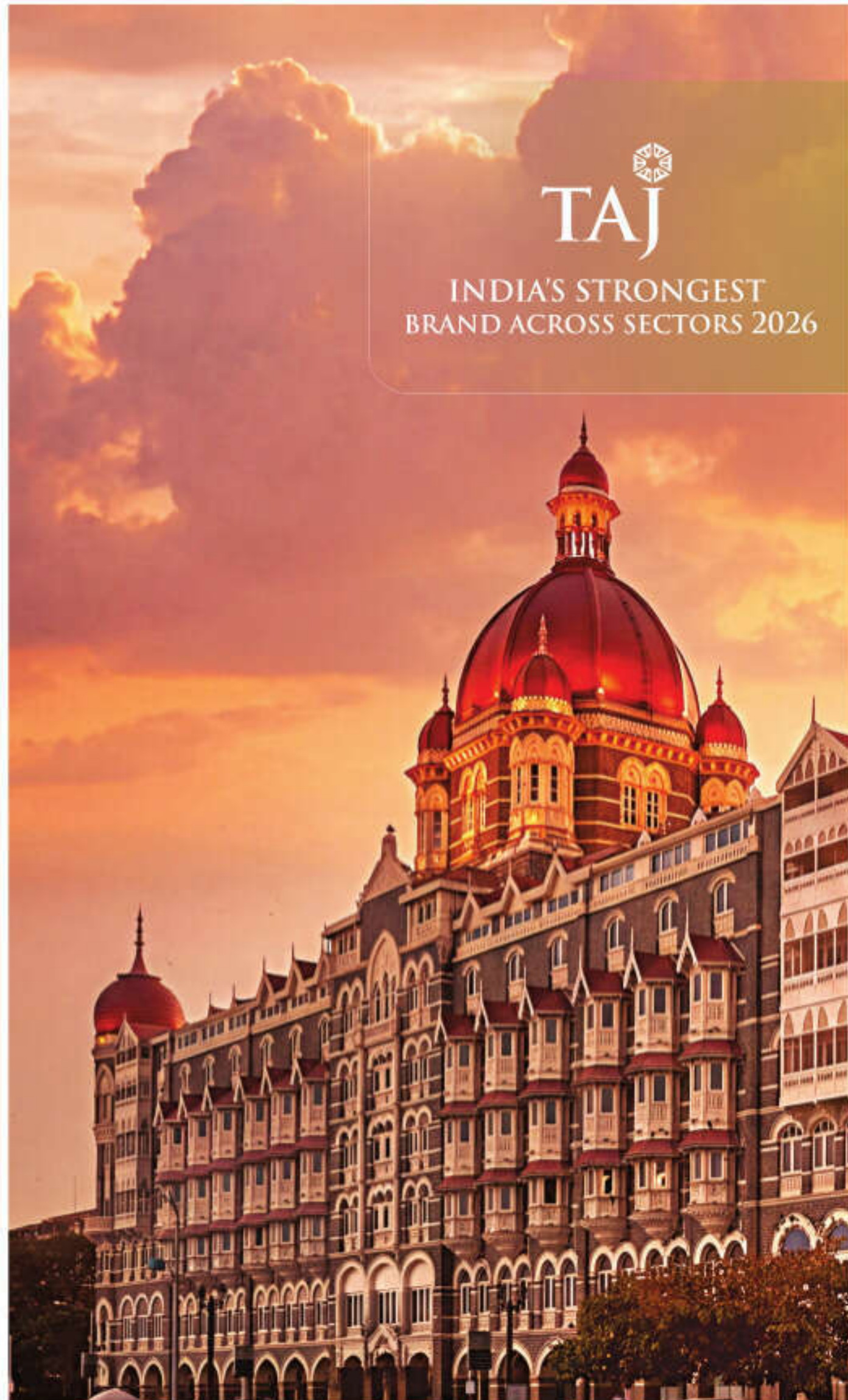
● MARKETS

Sensex	NIFTY	Gold ▼	US Dollar ▼
77,654.60	24,250.20	₹1,42,224	₹95.65
888.68	264.85		
1.16%	1.10%	Silver ▲	Oil ▼
		₹2,17,355	\$84.26

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION DATA GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1 KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF JULY 28, 2026

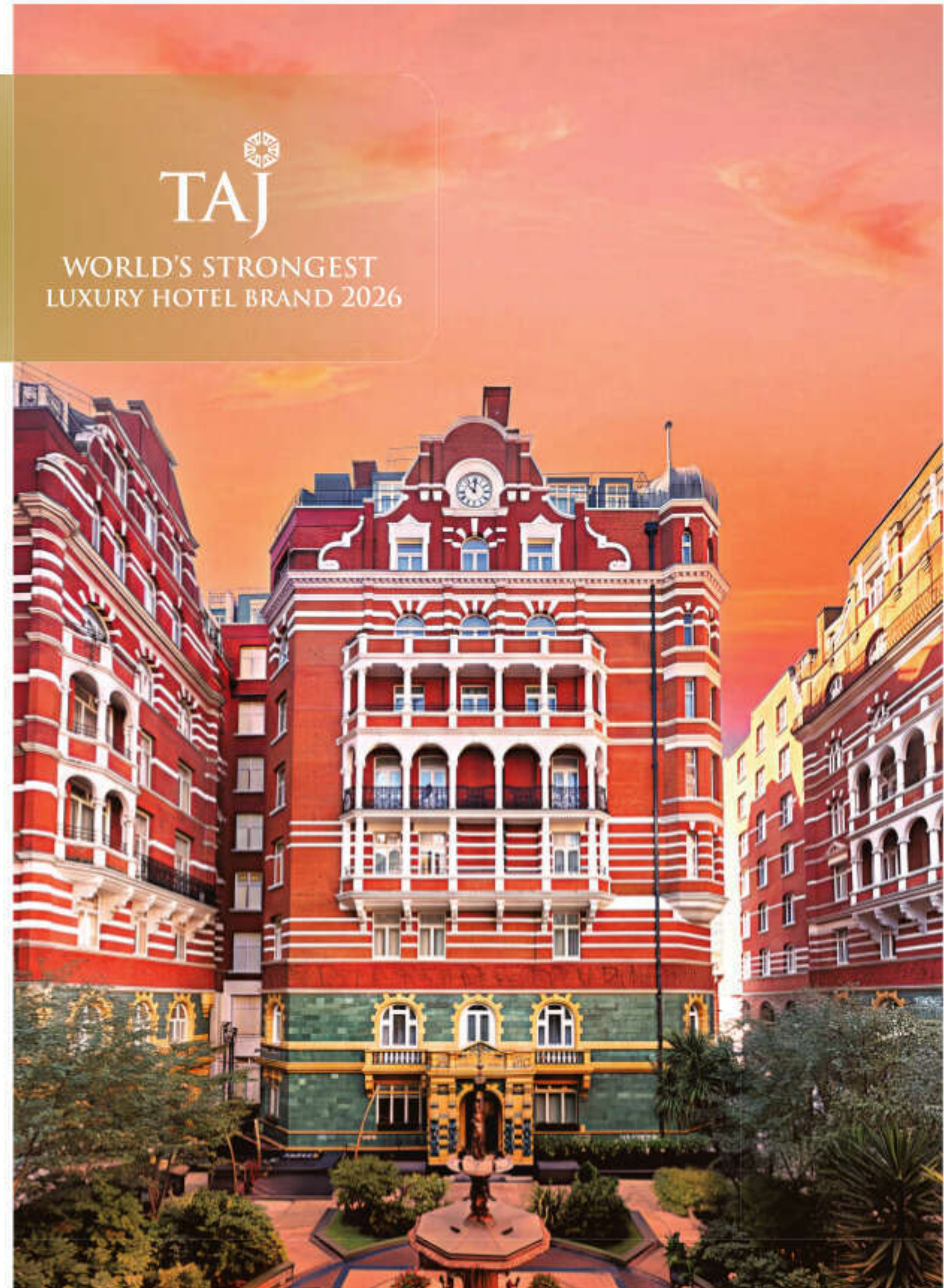
FROM INDIAN HEARTS

TO THE GLOBAL STAGE



SEVEN YEARS OF RECOGNITION

&



A TRIBUTE TO YOUR TRUST

150+ HOTELS | 14 COUNTRIES | 100+ DESTINATIONS

Source: Brand Finance Reports 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025, 2026

TEHRAN REJECTS OMAN PROPOSAL FOR REGIONAL MANAGEMENT OF HORMUZ STRAIT, CALLS IT 'UNREASONABLE'

US, Saudi hit Iran's allies in Iraq; Trump vows to punish Tehran

We're going to beat the f***ing s**t out of them: President

Reuters
Dubai, Cairo, July 29

EXPLOSIONS HIT a natural gas loading port on the Mediterranean Sea in Egypt on Wednesday, and British maritime security company Ambrey said a US-owned floating storage tanker there had been hit by a drone, in a potential spread of the West Asia war.

The drone hit a vessel in the Egyptian port of Damietta, causing a fire that spread to another vessel, three trading sources familiar with the incident said.

The crew were evacuated and the fire had been brought under control, Ambrey said. There was no immediate claim of responsibility for the incident.

Earlier on Wednesday the United States and Saudi Arabia struck Iran-backed paramilitary groups in Iraq, and US President Donald Trump vowed to "beat the f***ing s**t" out of Iran for firing on US troops days after he halted air strikes.

Iran responded overnight that it had fired on US bases in Jordan and at ships in the Strait of Hormuz, and also spurned an Omani proposal to jointly man-



Iraqis inspect the site of a joint US-Saudi airstrike that damaged a Popular Mobilization Forces base in Mosul, Iraq, on Wednesday. AP

age the strait. Oman, backed by Gulf states, had proposed a plan for joint regional control of the strait this week including voluntary service charges. But a senior Iranian official told *Reuters* Wednesday that Iran had rejected the proposal as "unreasonable".

"We'll be hitting them hard," *Fox News* quoted Trump as saying. "We're going to beat the f***ing s**t out of them."

The abrupt resumption of attacks only days after they were suspended saw a return to the volatile on-again-off-again pattern of earlier phases in the war.

Trump had said "Operation Epic Fury" would last only a

few weeks when he launched it in February but fighting has now gone on for five months with no end in sight. The joint US-Saudi attacks also mark the first time Riyadh has publicly joined strikes alongside Washington that could widen the conflict by drawing Sunni Muslim Saudi Arabia into combat against Shi'ite proxies of Iran.

Iraq's Popular Mobilisation Forces, powerful Iran-backed paramilitary groups incorporated into the Iraqi security forces, said at least 20 members were killed and 32 wounded in US-Saudi strikes targeting several bases across Iraq.

Washington and Riyadh said they struck the Iran-backed armed groups in Iraq in retaliation for drone attacks on Saudi oil targets launched from Iraq.

It was the first major US military action in the Middle East since last Friday, when Trump abruptly suspended an intensive bombing campaign after 13 days, having been advised by commanders that the strategy had run its course.

Though Iran denies its forces have directed strikes from Iraqi territory, Iranian newspaper *Hamshahri* reported that four Iranian Revolutionary Guards advisers had been killed in the

strikes on Iraq. The strikes on Iraq expose a dangerous rift in that volatile country. The Shi'ite-led government is one of the few in the world to balance close military and diplomatic ties with both Tehran and Washington, but those divided loyalties are a constant source of tension and frequent domestic unrest.

The office of PM Ali al-Zaidi, who took power just two months ago, urged the parties involved to avoid escalation and said he wanted to keep the country out of regional conflicts.

The Iraqi presidency denounced the strikes on the paramilitaries as "an unacceptable attack and a flagrant violation of Iraq's sovereignty", while also calling for a halt to attacks by armed groups against Iraq's neighbours. Trump told *Fox* that the US had coordinated with the Iraqi government in launching the attacks. An Iraqi government spokesperson did not respond to a request for comment on Trump's assertion that Baghdad had cooperated.

Washington has long called on the Baghdad government to crack down on Iran-backed paramilitaries, but efforts to do so in past have provoked unrest.

In a clear challenge to Zaidi's authority, Kataib Hezbollah, said it would give the government until next Thursday to prove it could defend Iraq's sovereignty.

China 'to send' shoulder-fired missiles to Iran

Tehran: Iran is expected to receive within weeks a first shipment out of up to 400 Chinese-made shoulder-fired air-defence missile launchers, three sources familiar with the deal told *Reuters*, as it rebuilds its defences amid war with the US.

The purchase, valued at \$60-70 million, is one of Tehran's largest-known efforts to strengthen its short-range air defences since the outbreak of its war with the US and Israel, which exposed gaps in Iran's ability to protect military sites and infrastructure.

The contract covers the purchase of between 300 and 400 man-portable air defence systems (MANPADS), including Chinese-made QW-12 and FN-16 missiles, sources said. **REUTERS**

US commander asks troops not to share their videos

Washington: The top US commander for West Asia has warned troops that cellphone videos shared online can help Iran target American bases, and sources told *Reuters* deployed personnel could soon be ordered to surrender their phones.

Admiral Brad Cooper said Iran was benefiting from being able to see the success or failure of its strikes by searching news reports or online posts by journalists referencing "reactions, photos, and footage from cellphones of our troops." **REUTERS**

• BRIEFLY

RUSSIA

Telegram founder Pavel Durov charged with aiding terrorism



Founder and CEO of Telegram Pavel Durov

RUSSIA'S MAIN domestic security agency said on Wednesday that Pavel Durov, founder and owner of the messaging app Telegram, has been charged with aiding terrorism and put on an international wanted list. The charges against Durov, who was born and began his career in Russia but later moved abroad, came as the Russian authorities restricted Telegram, one of the most popular messaging apps in the country. **AP**

CHINA

Govt targets AI cyberbullying with draft law

CHINA'S CYBERSPACE regulator on Wednesday released a draft law aimed at curbing cyberbullying, including AI-enabled abuse, as Beijing tightens oversight of online bullying in the world's largest internet community. It would apply to cyberbullying activities carried out within China, as well as to organisations and individuals overseas that target the country. **REUTERS**

KENYA

Five security officers killed in militant attack

FIVE KENYAN security officers were killed in a clash with suspected al Shabaab militants in the county of Mandera near the Somali border, police said. The militant group has been battling for years to overthrow Somalia's central government and establish its rule in the Horn of Africa country, based on its own strict interpretation of Islamic sharia law. **REUTERS**

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

NEPAL

Two Indians held for drug trafficking

TWO INDIAN nationals have been arrested at Kathmandu airport for possessing 8.66 kgs of marijuana, the Narcotics Drugs Control Bureau of Nepal Police said Wednesday. The duo were arrested from the Tribhuvan International Airport at Kathmandu on Tuesday, the narcotics bureau said. **PTI**

SRI LANKA

Lawyers group opposes judges' tenure extension

THE BAR Association of Sri Lanka Wednesday opposed the government's proposal to extend the retirement age of judges. BASL President Rajiva Amarasinghe said: "Everyone... stood opposed to the constitutional amendment which would seriously endanger the independence of the judiciary." **PTI**

Fringe Israeli settlers 'sneaking' into Syria to build Jewish outpost



The border between Syria and Israeli-controlled Golan Heights town of Majdal Shams. FILE

Nahariya: The Israeli military was about to launch a nighttime strike on a group of men in southern Syria when the soldiers noticed the long curls dangling from the temples of their targets. The troops held their fire.

These were not Syrian militants attempting to breach Israel's border, but religious Jews who had slipped into Syria and were on their way back.

The episode, first reported last week by Israel's public broadcaster and confirmed to *The Associated Press* by the Israeli military, has helped raise the profile of a fringe group of Israeli settlers that has staged numerous incursions into Syria, where they hope to establish Jewish settlements.

The groups, with members numbering in the dozens, have attempted to cross from Israel to Syria every few days in recent weeks. The military is tasked with reigning them in and, while most Israelis regard them as fringe, the settlement movement has strong backers in the far-right government. The most prominent of the groups behind the incursions is known as "Pioneers of Bashan." **AP**

Japan quake toll rises to 18 as rescue efforts continue

Associated Press
Kumamoto, July 29

SOLDIERS AND emergency workers combed through a badly damaged shopping mall and collapsed houses looking for trapped survivors Wednesday after a powerful earthquake that killed at least 18 people in southwestern Japan.

The magnitude 7.1 earthquake that hit a day earlier in the Kumamoto area on the southern main island of Kyushu, also left at least 62 people injured, six of

them seriously, the prefectural government said. The tally has been steadily growing, fanning fears it may continue to rise.

The sweltering weather heightened worries about the survivors as rescuers braved the heat. It was unclear how many people might still be missing.

Some of the most serious damage was at the Aeon Mall shopping centre in Kashima city, which was bustling with thousands of people when the quake happened. The company said some 3,000 customers were



Rescuers work at the damaged Aeon Mall in Japan's Kumamoto prefecture on Wednesday. AP

evacuated to a parking lot before a gas explosion happened in another part of the mall, where

some people were still working.

The mall's second floor collapsed, trapping people. Witnesses said the explosion shook the area as much as did the quake. Three people remained missing, while four deaths were confirmed at the mall site, according to Aeon.

"We take it seriously that an explosion happened and precious lives were lost," Aeon President Akio Yoshida told a news conference in Kumamoto, where he bowed deeply along with two other executives.

Japanese media footage of the mall showed that part of a ceiling had caved in, and metal parts and other debris were scattered about as helmeted and masked rescue workers searched the area.

In nearby Yatsushino, a chimney collapse at a Nippon Paper Industries factory killed five people while seven others were rescued from the debris, according to the Kumamoto prefectural government disaster team. Four people were still believed to be trapped there, it said.

Defendant in Salman Rushdie stabbing refuses to testify in terrorism trial

Associated Press
New York, July 29

THE MAN on trial in the stabbing of Salman Rushdie chose Tuesday not to testify or call any witnesses in the federal terrorism case, which is expected to head to the jury as soon as Wednesday.

Hadi Matar's lawyer told the court that the 28-year-old — who already has been convicted of state-level attempted murder charges — wouldn't take the stand at his trial on charges that include engaging in an act of transnational terrorism. "At this time, the defense rests," attorney Nathaniel Barone said. Matar has pleaded not guilty.

Prosecutors also rested their case Tuesday, and closing arguments are expected Wednesday morning. Rushdie, the prize-

winning author of novels including *Midnight's Children* and the controversial *The Satanic Verses*, testified last week about the 2022 attack that nearly killed him and left him blind in one eye.

Rushdie was about to give a talk — about writers' safety, no less — when his attacker climbed on stage behind him and stabbed him 15 times in front of a stunned audience at the Chautauqua Institution, an arts and intellectual retreat.

Prosecutors contend that Matar was acting upon a former Iranian leader's 1989 call for Rushdie's death because of *The Satanic Verses*, which ignited protests across the Muslim world. Some believers considered it blasphemous because of a dream sequence featuring Islam's Prophet Muhammad.

Heat wave threatens to intensify France's mega-fire near Bordeaux

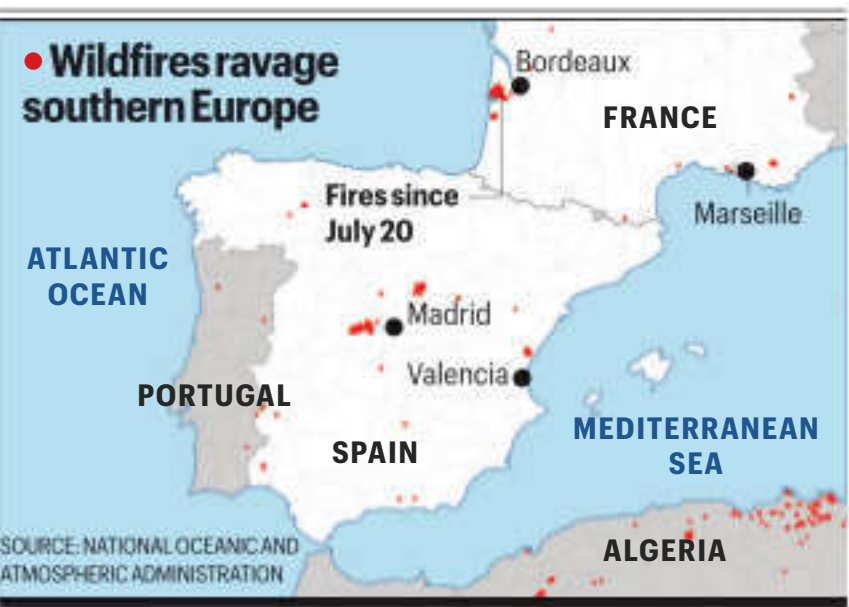
Associated Press
Lege-Cap Ferret, July 29

A WILDFIRE covering an area four times the size of Paris remained uncontained in southwest France on Wednesday as temperatures were forecast to reach 40 C, threatening to erase firefighters' overnight gains.

Authorities in the Gironde region said the blaze had not spread further during a calm night, but warned that forecast heat and winds could cause the flames to surge again.

At the command centre in Lege, firefighters bent over maps spread across a car hood as commanders tracked three danger zones: northern Cap-Ferret, the wooded corridor around Marcheprime, Cestas and Saint-Jean-d'Illac, and a military site near Martignas, where a significant new outbreak required a major deployment.

Over 2,200 firefighters and Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1



Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1 over 20 aircraft remain mobilised, supported by crews from across France and European partners. "We strike quickly and strike hard at any new smoke emissions," Gironde fire commander Matthieu Jomain said.

Meteo-France, the national meteorological service, said Wednesday would be the hottest

• KARYNA SHULIAK, A DENTIST BY PROFESSION, COULD INHERIT AS MUCH AS \$100 MILLION FROM HIS ESTATE, INCLUDING A 33-CARAT DIAMOND RING

The woman at the centre of Jeffrey Epstein's final years and his remaining fortune

Matthew Goldstein & Sharon Otterman
July 29

THE YOUNG dentist was smiling and soft-spoken, wearing a Columbia University fleece jacket and holding her long hair back with a clip. She was introduced by her assistant simply as "Dr Karyna."

But what the patient — who had come to the office in December expecting to see a different dentist — didn't know was that she was being treated by Dr Karyna Shuliak, the notorious sex offender Jeffrey Epstein's girlfriend.

Shuliak was the last person Epstein called before he killed

himself in his jail cell in 2019. She could inherit as much as \$100 million from his estate, including a 33-carat diamond ring, according to a trove of investigative records released by federal authorities.

But on that winter day, Shuliak was working as a part-time dentist in an unremarkable office in Brooklyn, according to dentists who work or used to work at the practice.

Her attempt to forge something of a normal life, though, was soon shattered when the Justice Department released 3 million pages of investigative files and emails it had gathered on Epstein. The files, released in late January, included thou-

sands of intimate emails between Shuliak and Epstein and dozens of photographs of her and of them together.

Suddenly, their nearly eight-year relationship was on vivid display for all to see. They had fights about sex — with both wanting more at different times.

She placed orders to a sexual wellness company for couples. She periodically sent him links to graphic pornographic videos. In some emails they discussed birth control pills and acne medications and treatments.

Shuliak, 37, emerges as a complicated and unusual figure in Epstein's world, based on a close review of the files and conversations with several



An undated image provided by the US Department of Justice shows Dr Karyna Shuliak and Jeffrey Epstein. DEPARTMENT OF JUSTICE, NYT

people familiar with her.

A native of Belarus who met Epstein when she was 21, she has not identified herself as a

victim, nor have federal authorities considered her a co-conspirator in Epstein's sex trafficking. There is no indication

that the FBI ever interviewed her, and lawyers for hundreds of his victims have never deposed her.

He once called her his "favorite" and often told her he loved her. She had free use of a credit card to buy whatever she wanted. They jetted around the world together, and he funneled payments of nearly \$1 million to her over the years. He also sent thousands of dollars to her parents in Belarus, the files reveal.

Over the years, she earned enough of his trust to help manage his properties and staff and even played a critical role in his effort to buy a Moroccan palace just weeks before his 2019 arrest. Epstein controlled the rela-

tionship, but there is little doubt she benefited from it professionally, personally and financially.

The emails reveal new details about how Epstein helped her get into Columbia University's dental school — and how he helped her obtain US citizenship by asking one of his female victims to marry her. In one email he suggested that the fastest "way to a green card" was through a same-sex marriage.

This year, congressional Democrats accused Epstein of exploiting the immigration system and called out Shuliak's marriage to an American woman, which ended in divorce, as a potentially "illusory"

one. U.S. immigration authorities have not challenged the process through which Shuliak obtained her citizenship.

As of this spring, Shuliak had been living in the Manhattan condo building in which Epstein's brother, Mark, has a financial stake.

Through her lawyer, she declined to comment. In a brief interview, Mark Epstein said, "I only wish that woman the best."

A friend of Shuliak's from Belarus, who once shared an apartment with her in Brooklyn and asked not be named to protect her privacy, said she believed Shuliak "truly loved" Jeffrey Epstein. **NYT**

SC grants bail to 2 UAPA accused in jail for 12 yrs

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 29

THE SUPREME Court has granted bail to two men, charged under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA), noting that they have remained in jail for the last nearly 12 years in connection with the case booked by the Special Cell of Delhi Police and that there is “no prospect of an early conclusion of the trial.”

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta has noted in its July 27 order that the life sentence imposed on Saquib Ansari and Waqar Azhar, following their conviction in another case under the anti-terror law in Jaipur in March 2021, had been suspended by the Rajasthan High Court and they were granted bail in a third case in Jodhpur.

The court said it “checked the status of the trial from the proceedings available on the e-Courts Services Portal. An application for bail preferred by co-accused Mohd Kafel came to be rejected by the learned trial Court vide order dated 20th July, 2026, wherein it has been noticed that the examination of Prosecution Witness-68 was continuing out of the 197 pros-

ecution witnesses proposed to be examined.”

It added, “The progress of the trial has been extremely slow, and there appears to be no prospect of the trial being concluded in the near future.”

The court said the “continued incarceration of the petitioners in this case is grossly violative of the right to liberty enshrined under Article 21 of the Constitution of India.” The court bench said that it had not commented on the merits of the case.

It asked the accused duo to cooperate with the trial and said that in the event the trial Court or prosecution finds they are delaying the conclusion of trial, or otherwise misusing the liberty granted to them, it shall be open to the prosecution to appraise it of the same for appropriate orders.

The case has its origins in the arrest of Pakistani national Mohd Qateel Siddiqui by the Delhi Police Special Cell in November 2011. He allegedly disclosed the establishment of a Rajasthan Module of the Indian Mujahideen to carry out terrorist activities in and around Delhi and that its members were in possession of consignments of explosives.

Misir Besra, top Maoist leader with Rs 2-cr bounty, arrested

With this arrest, the Maoist menace has been ‘almost wiped out’ from Jharkhand: DGP

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, July 29

MISIR BESRA — the last senior Maoist leader in Jharkhand carrying bounties worth over Rs 2 crore against his arrest — has been nabbed.

Apart from Besra, four men, including two other Maoists identified as Tumba Manjhi and Biren Hansda, were also arrested on Tuesday. The arrest marks the culmination of one of India's longest counter-insurgency campaigns.

Tadasha Mishra, director general of police (DGP), Jharkhand, claimed that with Mesra's arrest, the Maoist menace has been “almost wiped out” from the state. Besra, 65, was apprehended from the Maniadih area under the Bar-



His arrest marks the culmination of one of India's longest counter-insurgency campaigns

wadda police station limits on Tuesday evening during the Operation Daura Pahad.

His arrest was part of a joint operation that involved CoBRA (the Commando Battalion for Resolute Action) — an elite unit within the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) trained in guerrilla tactics and jungle warfare.

Details about the Maoist network Besra ran will emerge after his interrogation, police said. Besra has been linked to at least two major attacks that killed 55 security personnel.

“The top Maoist was carrying a combined bounty of Rs 2.20 crore, announced by the Jharkhand and Odisha governments. He was wanted in 175 cases across Jharkhand, Odisha and West Bengal,” Mishra said.

The arrest — which authorities hope will derail Maoist activities in Jharkhand and neighbouring regions — came a day after 16 fighters, including a regional leader, surrendered to Jharkhand Police in Ranchi.

Police said the 16 Maoists had been active in the Kolhan-Saranda forests and Latehar district, and worked with teams led by Besra and central committee member Asim Mandal. Born in Madnadih village in Giridih district, Besra was had many names such as Sunimal, Bhaskar, Sagar, and Pradhan.

Police records indicate he is a Politburo member of the banned CPI (Maoist) and part of the Central Committee, the Central Military Commission, and the Eastern Regional Bureau.

Besra entered the Maoist movement in the mid-1980s. He rose through the ranks over nearly four decades and played

a key role in building its organisational and armed structure in Jharkhand. Soon after Jharkhand was carved out of Bihar in 2000, he was linked to a series of attacks on security forces, including the 2003 and 2004 IED ambushes in West Singhbhum's Bitkilsoy and Baliba that killed 55 personnel. It gave him a place in the Central Military Commission and charge of the Eastern Regional Bureau, making him one of the organisation's most influential leaders in the region.

In recent years, he was believed to be active mainly in the Kolhan and Saranda regions and, for the last few months, in the Parasnath hill area. Besra's arrest completes the dismantling of the CPI (Maoist)'s central leadership that security agencies have pursued over the past two years. Almost every nationally recognised Maoist leader has now either been killed or surrendered.

With Besra's arrest, the CPI (Maoist) is left with scattered armed groups with no nationally recognised leadership.

WITH ENS, DELHI, AND PTI INPUTS



A car showroom remains inundated with floodwater in the Remuna area of Balasore district, Odisha on Wednesday. PTI

Three dead, two lakh affected as heavy rain triggers floods in Odisha

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, July 29

AT LEAST three people — including a fire personnel — have died, while over 2 lakh people have been affected across 748 villages in six districts due to floods triggered by heavy rain over the last few days.

Officials said Balasore, Bhadrak and Jajpur in northern Odisha are the worst hit, while Dhenkanal, Mayurbhanj and Sambalpur have also been affected. More than 30,000 people have been evacuated from low-lying areas in these districts.

According to Revenue and Disaster Management Minister Suresh Pujari, the three deaths are from Keonjhar district. The fire service personnel died of electrocution, an elderly person died in a wall collapse and a child was swept away in the rain.

“We have sought a report from the district collector about the casualties. Since the casualties are from the chief minister's home district, we have also apprised him about the situation,” Pujari said after a review meeting. The minister said there have been no reports of human or animal casualties from Balasore, Bhadrak and Jajpur, where the situation remains grim. Major rivers such as the Baitarani, Salandi and Jalaka are

in spate, flowing above the danger level at several places.

As many as 226 villages in the six districts remain cut off due to the floods, with authorities evacuating residents to safety. “Special care of the elderly, women and children is being taken at flood relief centres. The administration has been put on alert. Floodwaters have also damaged 761 houses and inundated nearly 8,000 hectares of agricultural land,” Pujari said.

More than 60 teams of the NDRF, ODRF and fire service personnel have been deployed in the affected districts, while three senior IAS officers have been deputed to Balasore, Bhadrak and Jajpur to assist the district administration. The chief minister, who is in New Delhi, also reviewed the situation.

The revenue minister said the districts of Sundargarh, Jharsuguda, Bargarh, Nuapada, Balangir, Kalahandi, Rayagada, Gajapati and Malkangiri have also been affected by heavy rain, and schools and anganwadi centres in 10 districts have been ordered to remain closed.

Water Resources Department engineer-in-chief Dilip Rout said around 9 lakh cuses of water is likely to be released at Mundali in Cuttack district by Thursday evening, triggering a medium-range flood.

EXPRESS special

‘Treated like criminals’: Externed from Mumbai, meet the 3 who got HC relief

Omkar Gokhale
Mumbai, July 29

FOR NEARLY seven months, Saeed Ahmed Abdul Wahid Choudhary lived in a rented room in Mumbai, uncertain about when he would return home; Akbar Hussain Sayyed, a delivery agent and local political worker, could not be with his wife, infant daughter and ailing mother for four months; Mohammad Rafiq Gulam Rasul Ansari fretted about not being able to meet his 68-year-old mother for months; and Firoz Abdul Wahab Khan had to miss the birth of his second child.

Between December 2025 and early 2026, the four were externed by the Mumbai Police from the city relying largely on FIRs lodged against them over political protests in 2019 and 2025 on a range of issues, from the Citizenship (Amendment) Act and National Register of Citizens, to the Ayodhya Ram temple and Varanasi Gyanvapi mosque rows, and azaan on loudspeakers plus local issues.

Under Sections 56 and 58 of the Maharashtra Police Act, a person can be externed for up to two years if there is fear that they may commit offences.

The four accused, with nothing common between them apart from their association with the Social Democratic Party of India (SDPI) — the political wing of the banned Popular Front of India (PFI) — moved into a shared rented accommodation in Mumbai, Thane district, after they were externed.

Over several hearings since March, the Bombay High Court has questioned the basis of the police action, asking if externment — generally used against gangsters, bootleggers and ha-



(Clockwise from above) Saeed Choudhary, Akbar Sayyed, and Firoz Khan

bitual offenders — could be sustained when the underlying allegations relate to political dissent.

Setting aside Sayyed's externment order in March, Justice Nijamoddin J. Jamadar said it “infringes upon his fundamental rights” and “cannot be sustained”. On July 2, quashing the externment of Choudhary, Justice Madhav J. Jamdar observed if by targeting citizens for opposing government decisions, they were being turned into “slaves of the government”. On July 28, Justice Madhav J. Jamdar set aside the externment order against Khan as “totally illegal”, and asked if “selective” action was taken “as they (the accused) belonged to one religion”. An order on Ansari's plea is expected next month.

The Devendra Fadnavis government has defended the externment on the grounds that the four had held protests without permission and were linked to the PFI, which they deny. Justice Jamdar, however, pointed out that the show-cause notice preceding externment orders did not mention this allegation, and said it could not be con-

sidered hence in the present pleas.

During a hearing on July 15, on pleas by Khan and Ansari, the High Court also questioned the denial of permission to the SDPI to protest. “Then what? Entire democracy is with you?” The punishment for protesting without permission, it noted, is just one month. In their petitions, the four pointed out that the externment orders were issued just ahead of the January 2026 Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) elections. Keeping them away amounted to an attempt to “stifle legitimate democratic dissent”, the four said.

Choudhary, 51, a transport and construction material supplier and the SDPI's Maharashtra general secretary, says he was “deprived” of his liberty. “In a way, they treated us like criminals.” He adds that while they diligently informed police before staging any demonstration, “permissions were deliberately denied”.

Justice Jamdar said the police action “merely for opposing certain decisions of the government of India... affects the petitioner's fundamental right to freedom of speech and expression and also to live with dignity”.

Justice Jamdar relied on the

Supreme Court's 2020 ruling in Anuradha Bhasin v Union of India, stating that Section 144 powers cannot be used to suppress legitimate expression of opinion, and a 2021 Gujarat High Court ruling that “a citizen cannot be subjected to externment merely for raising grievances against the government”.

Sayyed, 35, the Anushakti Nagar Taluka president of the SDPI, says his externment meant his plans to contest the BMC polls were scuttled, even as his job as a courier delivery agent was threatened. One of the protests Sayyed was part of, for which an FIR was lodged against him, was over air pollution caused allegedly by cement godowns in the Chembur-Govandi area. The FIR mentions that he raised slogans against Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Amit Shah and BJP leader Kirit Somaiya.

In its order putting aside Sayyed's externment, Justice Jamdar held that the offences, “even if taken at par, would not have the propensity to cause harm or danger”, and said he had “at best” participated in agitations.

Khan, 32, says he lost his job of safety officer with Bharat Petroleum following his externment. The externment period also coincided with the birth of his second child. “I sent my friends to the hospital. I tried to arrange money but how could I?” he says, pointing out that he didn't have any criminal record.

Ansari, 48, a state secretary of the SDPI, says he somehow kept his garment business running remotely to ensure his children's education was not affected. But, he says, the charges dogged the family.

Top court refuses to ban Lord Jagannath film, defends artistic freedom

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 29

THE SUPREME Court on Wednesday dismissed petitions seeking a ban on the release of the animated film *Mahaprabhu Jagannath*, observing that accepting the argument that it offends the religious sentiments of some people would leave no room for any creativity in the country.

A bench of Justices B V Nagarathna and R. Mahadevan refused to modify its earlier order allowing the release of the film and said it had already been granted a certificate by the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC). The court had earlier allowed the release of the film on or after July 28, following the conclusion of the Rath Yatra.

The bench was hearing peti-

tions by a devotee and the temple committee against the go-ahead for the movie.

Pointing out extensive “research goes into” making such movies, Justice Nagarathna said, “Just because there are two or three sensitive people, we will pass an extreme order that with respect to deity, there shall be no creativity, no literature, no sculpture?... Animation films are for children. Artists can't be taken to ransom like this.”

The film was previously scheduled for release on July 17, but the Odisha High Court stayed the release on July 15. The high court order came on a Public Interest Litigation (PIL) seeking directions to restrain the filmmakers from public exhibition, screening, or releasing the film within the state.

Maharashtra Airport Development Company Ltd. CIN: U45203MH2002SGC136979

TENDER NOTICE

MADC invites Tender for Appointment of Consultant for Preparation of Detailed Techno-Economic feasibility Study and Bid process management for development of Greenfield offshore International Airport at Kore, Vadhavan Port Region in Palghar District, Maharashtra.

The detailed tender document can be downloaded from the website www.mahatenders.gov.in from 30/07/2026, 04:00 PM

Sd/-
Vice Chairman and Managing Director

Bharat Coking Coal Limited (A Mini Ratna Company) (A Subsidiary of Coal India Limited)

NOTICE

All the tenders issued by Bharat Coking Coal Limited (B.C.C.L.) for procurement of Goods, Works and Services are available on website of B.C.C.L. “www.bccclweb.in” Coal India Limited (CIL) e-procurement portal “<https://coalindiatenders.nic.in>” and Central Public Procurement Portal “<https://eprocure.gov.in>” In addition, procurement is also done through GeM portal “<https://gem.gov.in>”. This is applicable to all Open (Domestic / Global) Tenders issued through e-procurement portal of CIL. This information is also available on BCCL website www.bccclweb.in

Rescued Ajmer minor girl faces ‘harassment’, police say probing

Parul Kulshrestha
Ajmer, July 29

A MINOR girl rescued by the Ajmer police last month, after allegedly being kept captive for more than seven months and forced into marriage, has approached police accusing her neighbours of harassing her and her family to force them to leave their rented house. She said five of them forcibly entered their house Wednesday and beat up her and her mother.

Deputy Superintendent of Police Laxman Ram said police have taken cognizance of the issue and action will be taken against the accused.

The girl, one of seven siblings, with her father a daily wage, told *The Indian Express*: “People keep taunting my mother that she sold me to make money.”

One of the relatives said the girl had already undergone “much trauma”. “The man in his 40s who forcibly married her even hammered a nail into her hand and burnt her at multiple places.” After she was recovered, the girl was produced before the Child Welfare Committee, and subjected to medical and forensic check-up. Doctors estimate her age to be 15-17 years.

While the family claims the girl was abducted last year, they filed a complaint on

June 13, accusing three women, Roshni, Afsana alias Bijli and Afreen alias Noorjahan, of taking her. Soon after, the girl was tracked using technical surveillance.

Police say as the family is poor, they were afraid of approaching police, which is why the FIR was filed so late.

As per police, the girl was sold for Rs 32,000 to Sanjay Kumar Gurjar, a resident of Churu, who married her. They claim to have recovered evidence from the phone of Nadeem Qureshi, who is accused of organising the wedding.

Deputy SP Ram said since the girl said that she sexually assaulted by two other men before she was married off, police have added charges of gang rape. Apart from the three women, the accused include Gurjar, Mohammad Jishant Rangrez alias Dishu, Zarina, and Qureshi.

Ram said: “Roshni took the victim with her to Pushkar for sightseeing in October 2025. There the girl was drugged and taken to a hotel and raped by two men... After this, the victim was kept by Noor Jahan and Bijli, who are both involved in petty crimes and drug dealing in the area. Later on, she was sold and married off to Gurjar.”

An analysis of call records of the accused showed a coordinated conspiracy, police said.

Reliance Industries Limited
Growth is Life

Regd. Office: 3rd Floor, Maker Chambers IV, 222, Nariman Point, Mumbai - 400 021.
Phone: +91-22-3555 5000 • Fax: +91-22-2204 2288 • E-mail: investor.relations@ril.com
CIN: L17110MH1973PLC019786

NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that pursuant to SEBI Circular HO/38/13/11(2)2026-MIRSD-POD/I/3750/2026 dated January 30, 2026, request(s) have been received by the Company from the Transferee(s) / Claimant(s) to transfer the below mentioned share(s) held in the name(s) of the shareholder(s) as detailed below, to his/her/their name(s).

Sl. No.	Name and address of Claimant(s)	Folio No(s).	Name and address of the registered shareholder(s)	Certificate No.	No. of Equity Shares	Distinctive Numbers	
						From	To
1	Ketan Kantilal Vasani Gopalrao Deshmuk Marg Cumballa Hill Mumbai 400026	034134243	Heena Vasani Ketan Vasani 4 Koyna Bldg New Chikal Wadi 7 Sleaater Road Mumbai - 400007	50147544 62385431 66634754	20 40 80	1156000640 2199695809 6871768587	1156000659 2199695848 6871768666
2	Tharakad Krishnan Thanumruthy 11 Veera Vihar, 4th Street Kovalam Nagar, Madurai Tamilnadu 625003	022971085	The Peerless General Finan & Inv Co Ltd 3 Esplanade East Peerless Bhavan Kolkata 700069	12205670 12205671	10 10	251301853 251301863	251301862 251301872

These shares were claimed to have been purchased / acquired by respective Transferee(s) / Claimant(s) and were earlier submitted for transfer and / or sent under objection by the Company.

Any person(s) who has / have any objection in this regard, should lodge such objection with the Company's Registrar and Transfer Agent viz. “KFin Technologies Limited”, Selenium Tower B, Plot No. 31-32, Gachibowli, Financial District, Nanakramguda, Hyderabad - 500 032, within Thirty (30) days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which, the Company will proceed to transfer the aforesaid shares.

For Reliance Industries Limited.
Sd/-
Savitri Parekh
Company Secretary and Compliance Officer

Place : Mumbai
Date : 29.07.2026

www.ril.com

PAWERGRID POWERGRID

Special Window for Transfer and Dematerialisation of Physical Securities

Notice is hereby given that pursuant to the Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI") Circular No. HO/38/13/11(2)2026-MIRSD-POD/I/3750/2026 dated January 30, 2026 ("SEBI Circular"), a Special window has been opened for a period of one year, from **February 05, 2026 to February 04, 2027** ("said period") to facilitate transfer and dematerialisation ("demat") of physical securities which were sold/purchased prior to April 01, 2019.

The special window shall also be available for such transfer requests which were submitted earlier and rejected/returned/not attended to due to deficiency in the documents/process/or otherwise. The eligible shareholders may submit their request to the Company at investors@powergrid.in or Registrar and Share Transfer Agent (KFin Technologies Limited) at einward.ris@kfnfntech.com along with the requisite documents as specified in the aforesaid SEBI circular.

During the said period, the securities so transferred shall be mandatorily credited to the transferee only in demat mode and shall be under lock-in for a period of one year from the date of registration of transfer. Such securities shall not be transferred/lien-marked/pledged during the said lock-in period.

As per the SEBI Circular, cases involving disputes between transferor and transferee will not be considered in the special window and may be settled by transferor and transferee through court/NCLT process. Further, securities which have been transferred to Investor Education and Protection Fund (IEPF) shall not be considered under special window for processing.

The SEBI Circular can be accessed at https://www.sebi.gov.in/legal/circulars/jan-2026/ease-of-doing-investment-special-window-for-transfer-and-dematerialisation-of-physical-securities_99411.html

For and on behalf of
Power Grid Corporation of India Limited
Sd/-
Anjana Luthra
Place: Gurugram
Date: 29.07.2026
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer

POWER GRID CORPORATION OF INDIA LIMITED
(A Government of India Enterprise)

Regd. Office: B-9, Qutab Institutional Area, Katwaria Sarai, New Delhi- 110 016.
Phone No: 011-26560112, 26560115 & 26560193
Corp. Office: "Saudamini", Plot No. 2, Sector-29, Gurugram, Haryana-122 001
Phone No: 0124-2822999 & 2822000
CIN: L4010DIL1989GOI038121, Website: www.powergrid.in, Email ID: investors@powergrid.in

A Maharatna PSU



The Indian EXPRESS

~ FOUNDED BY ~

RAMNATH GOENKA

◆ IN 1932 ◆

BECAUSE THE TRUTH
INVOLVES US ALL

Law is in, lawmakers should speak for young

THE DEBATE on the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill 2026 — passed by voice vote amid sloganeering in the Lok Sabha Wednesday — carried echoes of the street agitation that had raged outside the House. The over a month-long protests by students, led by the Cockroach Janta Party in the wake of the NEET examination paper leak, compelled Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan to resign. They also prodded the government to tighten the existing law, making it more stringent in terms of punishments and fines, and setting up fast-track courts that will work to defined timelines. The change of minister, and the harder law, however, are just the beginning. The momentum built by the students' protests must not be lost — it must lead to larger and more meaningful changes in the education system, and re-energise structures of accountability and reform. And in that process, people's representatives on both sides of the aisle must step up to the challenge — because Parliament has a crucial role to play. It is MPs' responsibility now to ensure that the House opens its doors to let in the concerns and anxieties of the young that filled the streets till only a few days ago.

Some readings of the street protests by students have painted them as antagonistic to democratically elected people's representatives and constitutionally mandated institutions. It is true that the students' uprising rang with accumulated anger and resentment at the failure or inability of institutions — of government primarily, but also arguably of Opposition and Parliament — to address the crises that weigh down the education system or to assuage their apprehensions about dwindling opportunities for employment that is dignified and fulfilling. At the same time, however, the protests must be read as an appeal to those same institutions, to listen and respond, and to search for solutions. The movement on the street has made itself heard. Now Parliament must take on the hard and patient work of redesigning, correcting and finetuning educational structures and processes.

If Parliament is unable to step up to the task, if it is held back from doing so by long-playing and debilitating syndromes, like growing political polarisation and erosion of reciprocity, it would be missing an extraordinary opportunity. It has a chance to restore the trust of the young in the system. A rare possibility — of renewing and re-imagining the institution's pact with the people — is at hand. The highest forum of democratic deliberation must not fail to seize it.

A medical education more inclusive

THE NATIONAL Medical Commission's (NMC) revised guidelines for admitting persons with disabilities to undergraduate medical courses mark an overdue shift towards making medical education more inclusive. Issued on Monday, the new benchmark stipulates that a candidate's eligibility for the MBBS course will be based on a functional assessment rather than merely a certificate recording the disability. Designated medical boards will carry out evaluations. The message is significant: Disability, by itself, should not be treated as a disqualification. What matters is whether an aspiring doctor can acquire the competencies necessary to practise medicine, with appropriate support. The guidelines recognise that technology, institutional support and accessible infrastructure play an important role in determining whether disability becomes a barrier.

Framed around rigid thresholds and broad categories, the earlier guidelines often functioned less as tools of assessment than as instruments of exclusion. Applicants could be declared ineligible simply because they belonged to a particular disability category or crossed a prescribed threshold, regardless of whether they could complete the MBBS course. The guidelines were challenged several times, including before the Supreme Court, where petitioners argued that blanket exclusions violated the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016. Last year, the Court observed that "systemic discrimination against persons with benchmark disabilities should be eliminated".

The real test of the revised guidelines will lie in their implementation. Functional assessments must not become another source of arbitrary decision-making. Without clear evaluation protocols, similarly placed candidates could receive different outcomes depending on the medical board before which they appear. The NMC should, therefore, develop standards that minimise subjectivity while preserving the flexibility that individual cases require. It should also revisit the SC's direction that every medical board include doctors with disabilities — a safeguard that will strengthen the credibility of the process. The Commission must view inclusivity not as a compliance exercise prompted by litigation but as an ongoing commitment. The new guidelines should be seen not as the final word but as the foundation of a medical education system that judges aspirant doctors on their abilities, and not by what could hold them back.

Happy birthday, Punch, many friends to you

THERE IS, in the story of a lonely monkey, an all-too-human tale. Born a year ago at the zoo in Ichikiwa, Japan, Punch's early months were a bit of a tragedy. He was abandoned by his mother, likely because she was too exhausted after his birth to care for him. A bit of a runt, he was rejected by the other young simians in his troop. Bottle-fed by zookeepers, Punch's closest companion was a stuffed toy — an orangutan — that was given to him. The tragic image of lonely young Punch clutching his doll, eyes exuding a fear and insecurity that so many human beings can identify with, made him a viral sensation. The foothall at the zoo grew by thousands wanting to see Punch, and he has received scores of birthday cards from his many well-wishers around the world.

A year on, though, Punch is no longer just a mirror for the alone, the lonely and the rejected. He has, gingerly at first and gradually with more confidence, reached out to the other young monkeys and made friends. And it's not because the donations raised by the zoo in his name paid for an air-conditioning system in the monkey enclosure. It's because Punch is finally coming out of the shell of his tragic early months.

Unlike then, when he was easy to spot in the enclosure, far from the madding crowd, Punch is now often difficult to tell apart from his new friends. Perhaps, on his first birthday, he no longer needs stuffed toys and cards expressing love and sympathy. Maybe well-wishers could give him some bananas to share with the gang. And set up more monkey bars for them to hang out on.



THAROORTHINK

BY SHASHI THAROOR

THE GOVERNMENT'S seeming determination to proceed with a revised delimitation that drastically increases the size of the Lok Sabha to 824 or 850 seats marks a disastrous watershed in India's institutional architecture. The underlying justification offered by the government is purely mathematical: The size of the Lower House cannot remain frozen at the 543-seat limit established in 1972, since when the nation's population has more than doubled. Yet, beneath this seemingly democratic argument lies a profound hazard.

Amid all the other major challenges of the looming delimitation exercise — notably the severe political and federal friction caused by penalising southern states for successful population control, while disproportionately rewarding the northern Hindi heartland for its failures — a basic question remains unaddressed: Does it make any sense to have a legislature so massive and structurally unwieldy? No established democracy does.

Every mature democratic system recognises that a Parliament must be capped at a size that permits genuine legislative scrutiny, cohesive debate, and individual member participation. By choosing to push the Lok Sabha towards 850 seats (a size no other democratic legislature has), India is charting an anomalous and dangerous course. Democratic theory and global practice consistently show that beyond a threshold, a legislature

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ceases to function as a deliberative body and deteriorates into a chaotic colosseum where only a select few can speak, while the rest are reduced to passive spectators, mere numbers on voting machines.

After all, the United States House of Representatives was legally capped at 435 in 1929, when the United States population stood at 120 million. Today, the American population has tripled to over 335 million, yet the size of the House remains at 435. Americans recognise that increasing the number of representatives to match population growth would paralyse the legislative process. Instead, each member simply represents a larger number of voters, relying on robust local staff, modern communication, and a highly organised committee system to bridge the governance gap. Indian MPs can do that too.

The realities of an 850-member Lok Sabha are devastating for individual legislators. In a standard parliamentary session, time is an unyielding, scarce resource. Consider the daily Question Hour or a standard legislative debate on a complex bill. If a debate is allocated four hours, and time is distributed according to party strength, at most 15-20 MPs out of 850 will be able to participate. In practice, backbenchers and members of smaller parties will be mostly silenced.

With an oversized Parliament, a vast majority of MPs will never get to ask a question, initiate a private member's bill, or participate in a substantive debate during their entire five-year tenure. They will be transformed into silent placeholders, raising their hands when the party commands. This will worsen an already distressing trend in Indian governance: The shrinking role (and systemic degradation) of Parliament. In recent years, the number of days Parliament meets

An oversized legislature where the vast majority of members have no voice suits an executive that prefers compliance over scrutiny

From Ravidas and Begumpura, a philosophy of governance



ABHINAV PRAKASH

RAVIDAS IS a saint amongst the saints". Kabir's line captures the place of Sant Shiromani Guru Ravidas ji Maharaj in awakening the consciousness of the Bhakti era. To carry that consciousness to every household, BJP president Nitin Nabin has launched a special campaign from Varanasi, running from Guru Purnima on July 29 to Magh Purnima on February 20, the 650th *jayanti* of Sant Ravidas.

This is not just an occasion for remembrance but also a chance to reaffirm our faith in the long-neglected, unbroken line of Indian social and spiritual thought. To understand Ravidas, one must revisit the Bhakti movement and the consciousness it produced, which expressed itself not in the language of philosophers but in *lok bhasha*, the language of the people.

Modernity is often confused with Western influence, but the seeds of Indian modernity lie in the Bhakti movement, especially the teachings of Ravidas.

Modernity rests on four pillars. The first is equality and human dignity. To speak of equality in a society divided by *jati* and *varna*, and to carry spiritual democracy into social equality, was the movement's greatest achievement. Ravidas's famous line, "What separation is there between you and me?", is a social manifesto. The second is the reality of this world and the primacy of *karma*. Against every temptation of escapism, Ravidas insisted that this world is real, and that one must work here and make it better. The third is the dignity of labour. In a society that had long regarded physical work with contempt, Ravidas raised it to the level of worship. The fourth is good governance and welfare. Ravidas did not confine himself to individual liberation; in conceiving Begumpura, he left a standard against which any state may be measured.

The modernisation and democracy the BJP articulates in modern political vocabulary is a contemporary translation of these teachings, which are also reflected in the concept of *ekatma manav darshan*. Ravidas wanted a state in which everyone was fed, and the great and the small lived as equals.

That is *antodaya*, which guides the BJP's governance philosophy.

How that conception is being translated into policy can be read in his poem, 'Begumpura'. Ravidas names his ideal city "the place without sorrow". PM-KISAN, Ayushman Bharat, the Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana and the Jal Jeevan Mission all seek a society in which no citizen is one illness or one failed harvest away from ruin. He then describes the city as having no revenue demand, no property burden, no fear, no wrongdoing, no dread of decline. Six centuries later, that list reads like a governance agenda, and it has been met by GST and direct tax reform, BNS, the SVAMITVA Scheme.

The governance of this city, he continues, is settled and permanent, and within it there is no second rank or third, for all are of one standing. That is a constitutional principle stated in the 15th century. Its fulfilment lies in discrimination-free access to government schemes, and in the abrogation of Article 370, which gave the people of Jammu and Kashmir the same rights as every other Indian.

Then comes the sharpest political demand in the poem: "Residents walk wherever they please, and nobody is stopped at the palace gate." This is a call for the abolition of the *darbar*. Seven Race Course Road is now Lok Kalyan Marg, Rajpath is now Kartavya Path, Raj Bhavans are now Lok Bhavans, and the new central secretariat is Kartavya Bhavan. These are not renamings but a change in the culture of power, as is direct benefit transfer, which removed the modern courtiers who once stood between the citizen and what he was owed.

Ravidas closes by naming himself and his caste without apology: Whoever is a citizen of this city is a friend of mine. That is the fraternity on which Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat rests. His Begumpura, Kabir's Premnagar, Tukaram's Pandharpur and Ambedkar's Prabuddha Bharat are names for a single dream, and Viksit Bharat is the contemporary link in that unbroken chain.

The writer is national vice-president, BJP Youth Wing

Dengue vaccine must complement prevention



RAJIB DASGUPTA

INDIA HAS taken an important step in the fight against dengue. On July 21, the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation granted marketing authorisation to Qdenga, the country's first approved dengue vaccine. It has been approved in 42 countries. Over 24 million doses have been administered worldwide, and it has the WHO's imprimatur.

Dengue, one of the world's fastest-spreading mosquito-borne viral diseases, is caused by four closely related virus types — DENV-1, DENV-2, DENV-3 and DENV-4 — and is transmitted primarily by the *Aedes aegypti* mosquito. Clinical trials have shown that Qdenga provides long-lasting protection against all four dengue virus types in people who have had the disease. It has also been shown to protect against DENV-1 and DENV-2 among people who have never had dengue, with particularly strong protection against DENV-2, on which the vaccine is based.

The vaccine is administered in two doses. If the second is delayed, the schedule does not need to be restarted; the missed dose can be given at the earliest opportunity. It is not recommended for children under six because of lower efficacy and the relatively low prevalence of prior dengue infection in that age group. The WHO does not recommend its use beyond 60 years until there is more evidence on safety and efficacy. It should not be administered to pregnant women, women planning pregnancy within one month of vaccination, breastfeeding mothers, immunocompromised individuals, or those receiving immunosuppressive therapies such as chemotherapy or high-dose corticosteroids.

Affordability is likely to determine uptake. At an expected price of Rs 3,000-6,000 per dose, initial demand is likely to come primarily from the urban middle class. Whether the vaccine should eventually be included in the Universal Immunisation Programme is a complex question. The WHO recommends that countries consider introducing Qdenga into routine immunisation only in areas where dengue transmission is a significant public health threat. Indicators include a dengue seroprevalence exceeding 60 per cent by the age of nine or a mean age of dengue-related hospitalisation below 16 years. India will need robust epidemiological data to determine which regions meet these criteria before considering wider public funding.

Vaccination, however, is only one part of the solution. The same *Aedes* mosquitoes also transmit chikungunya and Zika, making integrated vector management indispensable. Eliminating mosquito breeding sites through better drainage and waste disposal must remain the first line of defence. These efforts should be complemented by biological measures such as larvivorous fish, judicious use of chemical and microbial control methods, stronger coordination across agencies, and sustained community participation. Improving public awareness and health literacy is equally important. Qdenga is a significant addition to India's public health arsenal, but it should complement, not replace, a comprehensive strategy for controlling mosquito-borne diseases.

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The writer is chairperson, Centre of Social Medicine and Community Health, JNU

Clinical trials have shown that Qdenga provides long-lasting protection against all four dengue virus types in people who have had the disease. It has also been shown to protect against DENV-1 and DENV-2 among people who have never had dengue

40 YEARS AGO

July 30, 1986



Opposition stops amendment

THE UNION government's move to to arm itself with special powers in border states proved abortive when an alert Opposition showed the proposed amendment was redundant. When PM Rajiv Gandhi convened a meeting of opposition leaders to seek support, Madhu Dandavate read out Article 249 to show the Constitution provided for these contingencies. The PM said the government would abandon the move.

HM slams Badal, Tohra

HOME MINISTER Buta Singh lambasted the

dissident Akali leaders, who were colluding with extremists in Punjab, and said some leaders were willingly or unwillingly acting as agents of the country's enemies. He said Parkash Singh Badal and GS Tohra were organising the *kriya* and *bhog* ceremonies of terrorists killed in encounters and declaring that such extremists had attained martyrdom.

Darjeeling tense

TROOPS WERE patrolling all the hill subdivisions of Darjeeling district as tension mounted on the second day of the 108-hour bandh sponsored by "Gorkhaland" agitators protesting the police firing on July 27. Life was

paralysed in Darjeeling. Kurseong and Kalimpong as the shops, markets, educational institutions, and other establishments remained closed. GNLF supporters abducted the deputy director of tourism after intercepting his vehicle near Pehsak.

Car bomb kills 25 in Beirut

A CAR bomb exploded in a crowded shopping centre in Muslim West Beirut, killing at least 25 people and wounding 170. The blast came a day after a white Mercedes Sedan packed with a quarter-tonne of explosives blew up in the city's Christian sector, killing 32 people and wounding 140.



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As India’s youth spoke up, the message from across the border — you inspire us



SANJAYA BARU

ASUBCONTINENT divided by the politics of the past came together last week through the activism of a generation unhappy with the present and with a stake in the future. India’s Gen Z protests, triggered across the country by a movement launched by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), met with expressions of solidarity from young people across South Asia. The CJP movement was itself, in some ways, an echo of the Gen Z protests that began in Sri Lanka, went on to Bangladesh and then Nepal.

The Indian youth upsurge, interestingly, was welcomed by young Pakistanis. It remains to be seen if it will inspire them to stand up for democracy in their own country. Brought together by posts on Instagram and news coverage on channels like the BBC and Al Jazeera, young people in Bangladesh, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri Lanka chimed with their Indian counterparts. Rarely has any political issue in one country brought together an entire generation across borders.

You inspire us, was the message from across the border. In response to such admiration and support, young Indians responded with gratitude. Hopefully in each of these countries the young fighting for their future will remain invested in the development of their own country, strengthening the roots of democracy at home and the prospects for development, rather than emigrate to greener pastures.

A subcontinent divided by the antediluvian bigotry of a dominant and powerful few suddenly found that such domestic prejudices are not shared by victims of similar forms of authoritarianism and corruption in their own country. More than the politics of the Indian protest movement, it is the music and its irreverent humour that found an echo across South Asia.

“You guys are too cool, *yaar!*” said a Pakistani student who viewed on Instagram the opening of a bolt on a moving police van in Mumbai that enabled holed-up kids to jump



ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

out and dance on the road. At Jantar Mantar, a young man thanked these supporters from across the border saying, “We want peace, not war. We want to study. We want jobs.”

In a few words, these teenagers and 20-somethings summed up the sentiment of millions across South Asia who wish to live in peace and live a dignified life, not exporting terror or hatred. They may well not reflect the attitude of the ruling regime in their respective country, but they surely reflect the shared attitude of a new generation seeking a good life and a fulfilling and fruitful future.

In the past, cross-border friendship in South Asia was promoted by concerned, elderly citizens, liberals and communists and a few among the elite who lived similar lives and would meet up on occasion in London or Dubai. Today, it is through Instagram that a new generation connects, with no prejudice and lots of pizzazz.

The initial narrative of the ruling regime’s dirty tricks department that the CJP was being supported by Pakistan’s ISI, America’s CIA and George Soros fell flat when Gen Z protestors laughed off such accusations rather than get angry about them. The deployment of humour, laughter, music and poetry as

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political weapons will remain the unique contribution of this campaign.

The CJP protest campaign has the potential to give meaning to a recent call given by the leadership of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) for increased people-to-people contact between India and Pakistan. We have seen the positive side of such contact on social media with youth across borders expressing solidarity with each other and recognising that all of them have shared concerns — about their own future, their education, their employment opportunities.

Having achieved the limited objective of getting the Union Minister for Education sacked, with some other demands waiting to be addressed, the CJP campaign across

India can easily evolve into a subcontinent-wide peace movement seeking better relations between neighbours. Prime Minister Narendra Modi can make good use of this opportunity to strengthen civil-society engagement across borders. The CJP has demonstrated that a humane approach to social issues produces better results than hate, prejudice and violence.

An improvement in bilateral relations within South Asia due to social-media interaction between the

subcontinent’s youth would set an example for many embattled regions of the world. Wars between nations are declared by men and women in their sixties and seventies, fought by soldiers in their twenties, but hurt the future of tomorrow’s adults. The youth, therefore, have a stake in the pursuit and assurance of peace.

The anonymity of social media presence has spawned trolling and abuse, making the medium a double-edged sword. A person can hurt you on social media but one can also express solidarity. In India we have seen far too much abuse and venom on social media, especially against Muslims at home and in our neighbourhood. The CJP protest has shown that idealistic youth can also use social media to build bridges, make common cause and express solidarity with neighbours with shared aspirations.

As a great democracy that has fought to defend its own democratic institutions at home, India can inspire its neighbourhood, where young people are also seeking to defend or establish democratic freedoms. The backsliding in India’s democratic credentials over the past decade has hurt our credibility as a democracy. We must regain our standing as a torchlight of democracy in Asia.

The youth movement unleashed by the CJP this year has restored hope in the security of our hard-won personal freedoms. All is not yet lost. An authoritarian and majoritarian political leadership has been challenged and its hollowness within exposed. The Delhi Police and their political bosses have made an important contribution to the awakening of democratic consciousness in middle-class families that had been lulled by bigotry.

Across India, we witnessed an unbottling not just of individual grievances but of a collective concern with majoritarian assertion and the trampling of individual freedoms. The message may not have fully sunk in. After all, even after the events of the past week, there will be a backlash from aggressive and abusive members of the saffron brigade. But the fear is gone in a freedom-loving youth. They will, hopefully, continue to fight to preserve our democracy and our Constitution.

The writer is chairman of the board of trustees, Forum for National Security Studies (FNSS) & Centre for Aerospace & Strategic Studies (CAPS)

On antibiotics, problem isn’t just overprescribing

If India wants to reduce inappropriate antibiotic use, it must address these underlying drivers. The first priority is strengthening infection prevention. Better water, sanitation and hygiene, wider use of vaccines, and sustained investment in infection prevention and control programmes in hospitals will reduce the burden of infections that require antibiotics. While initiatives like Kayakalp have improved cleanliness in public hospitals, preventing healthcare-associated infections requires continuous investment in trained infection-control personnel, surveillance systems, antimicrobial stewardship and institutional accountability.

The second priority is strengthening diagnostic capacity. Rational antibiotic prescribing is only possible when clinicians have confidence in laboratory results. India has begun building this through the National Health Mission, Free Diagnostics Service Initiative, National Essential Diagnostics List and expanded lab networks. Improving laboratory quality, accreditation, turnaround time and confidence in microbiology reports is equally important.

Education is central. Clinicians need training in antimicrobial stewardship and evidence-based prescribing. Communities must understand that antibiotics do not treat viral infections and that demanding them for every fever is harmful in the long term.

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

It is equally important to recognise that India has not been standing still. Over the past decade, the country has established a National Action Plan on AMR, expanded surveillance through the National Centre for Disease Control and Indian Council of Medical Research, introduced antimicrobial stewardship initiatives, strengthened essential diagnostics, regulated fixed-dose combinations and increased political recognition of AMR as a national priority. These are substantial structural reforms that take years to translate into measurable changes.

A country that accounts for nearly one-fifth of the world’s population and manages one of the largest public health systems cannot transform antibiotic use overnight. Progress should be judged not only by current consumption patterns but also by the strength and direction of ongoing reforms.

International reports are valuable when they stimulate action, but repeating what is already well established adds little unless accompanied by practical solutions. Reducing antimicrobial resistance will not be achieved by asking doctors simply to prescribe fewer antibiotics. This can cost lives. It will be achieved by creating a health system where they can safely prescribe the right antibiotic, for the right patient, at the right time and the country is committed to achieving this.

The writer is senior scientist and programme officer, AMR, ICMR



KAMINI WALIA

THE LATEST global study in *The Lancet Public Health* has again highlighted what infectious disease experts in India have known for years: India uses too many broad-spectrum “watch” antibiotics and too few first-line “access” antibiotics. It estimates that India’s antibiotic consumption is higher than the optimal target and that the antibiotic mix is skewed towards drugs that should ideally be reserved for more serious infections.

The tendency to overuse broad-spectrum antibiotics has been documented repeatedly over the past two decades through surveillance studies, hospital audits and national antimicrobial resistance (AMR) programmes. The more important question is why physicians continue to prescribe them.

The answer lies less in irrationality than in the realities of clinical practice. Doctors frequently prescribe antibiotics before a definitive diagnosis is available because patients often present late. Diagnostic facilities are limited or unreliable, and treatment decisions cannot always wait. Similarly, inadequate infection prevention and control in healthcare facilities increases the likelihood of healthcare-associated infections, prompting clinicians to choose broader-spectrum agents from the outset. In other words, antibiotics are often used to compensate for systemic weaknesses.

Clinicians need training in antimicrobial stewardship and evidence-based prescribing. Communities must understand that antibiotics do not treat viral infections



SUDIP SHARMA

EVERY GENERATION grows up with a certain set of values that become their defining characteristics. For my parents’ generation, midnight’s children, those values were hope and survival. I always thought the primary value my generation grew up with was doggedness, an ability to adjust to anything the world threw at us and to somehow find a way to get to the other side of it. We wore this badge proudly and bemoaned the generations that followed us (specifically Gen Z) for not having the same work ethic as us, for having the imperviousness to refuse what — to our “boomer” brains — was a legitimate call of duty. Recent events at Jantar Mantar,

though, have forced a late realisation.

What my generation considered perseverance and adaptability was nothing but fear: The fear of authority, the fear of not being allowed to make it, of being singled out, of being left behind. Our grand ambition had simply been to get past the door before the doorman shuts it on us, too bad for the ones left behind. We who grew up in pre-liberalised India knew what scarcity was, and the psychological imprint it left on us was the ever-lurking fear of losing it all once again.

Nowhere is this fear as manifested as in my own fraternity: The Hindi film industry. In the last decade or so (that’s the fearful boomer in me trying to avoid specificity when I could have easily written the last 12 years), it has witnessed an unprecedented clamping down on its freedom of expression. Our response to it has been that of the frog in

the pan, our boomer bodies skillfully “adjusting” as the water temperature kept rising.

When my film *Uda Punjab* ran into censor issues in 2016, a large part of the industry took a stance and came out in support. In 2026, merely 10 years later, a well-made, powerful film like *Satuj* was banned and not a whisper could be heard. We chose this silence, for it kept us safe from being branded anti-nationals. We chose this darkness, for it

What my generation considered perseverance and adaptability was nothing but fear: The fear of authority, the fear of not being allowed to make it, of being singled out, of being left behind

allowed us to hide in the shadows. Many of us “adjusted” even further, crawling when we were only asked to bend, and unleashed a hateful propaganda machinery on an unsuspecting audience. Heck, most of it wasn’t even competent cinema, and yet, our award functions celebrated it with gusto. The rest of us continued to go to them just so we could preen with our glittering trophies on social media. It was my generation’s fear of being left behind manifesting itself all over again.

Guilt, though, is a dead weight and to make sure it doesn’t drown us, we poured our hearts out in the safe space of like-minded company, blaming the state of affairs, the state of the audience, but never acknowledging our complicity. We consoled each other — “hang in there, this too shall pass”. And to appear less guilty, we chose to lampoon the larger media landscape, taking

digs at the toxicity of the news channels in our films and shows. Yet, when the time came for their release, we chose to go to the same toxic channels for media promotions, even though it ate at our conscience.

The Gen Z at Jantar Mantar, though, have refused to do that. What we did not understand then — and is crystal clear now — is that this generation has a different relationship with authority. What we read as their intransigence is a lack of fear. They are not afraid of authority. They look in the eye and ask for what they believe is rightfully theirs.

Yeah, the kids are alright. They’ll leave behind a better world than the one that was handed over to them. And while they are at it, they are teaching some of us how to speak again.

Sharma is a writer, director and producer

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Governance lessons

THE MSRDC-HDFC Bank issue provides key lessons for banks, regulators and boards (‘Learning the right lessons at the bank’, *IE*, July 29). While HDFC Bank’s internal review concluded that there was business overreach rather than fraud or personal enrichment, it still identified governance and compliance lapses, resulting in disciplinary action against senior executives. Business targets should never override regulatory requirements. Boards and senior management must exercise effective oversight.

Bal Govind, Noida

Beyond borders

INDIA’S NATIONAL security strategy should increasingly recognise that influence today extends beyond territorial boundaries (‘Our strategic imagination must look beyond geography’, *IE*, July 29). Technology, trade, maritime connectivity, cyber capabilities and supply chains are as important as geography in shaping national interests. Investments in innovation, infrastructure and strategic partnerships will strengthen India’s position. A co-ordinated approach involving government, industry and academia can improve preparedness for emerging challenges.

S M Jeeva, Chennai

Academic freedom

UNIVERSITIES SHOULD remain spaces for learning, critical thinking and open discussion, free from political interference and administrative bias (‘On campus, questions about vendetta politics’, *IE*, July 29). Institutional actions must be transparent, legally sound and guided by due process rather than perceptions of political influence. Governments and university authorities should resolve disputes through independent inquiries and fair procedures. Protecting the autonomy and credibility of educational institutions is essential.

Prajesh Paramasivan, Neelambur



ILLUSTRATION: TANUSHRI MITRA

mains partial. When women whose sterilisation was not a fully informed choice are counted alongside women with unmet need, India’s “unwanted family planning” problem looks considerably larger than the headline numbers suggest.

There is another force propping up India’s birth numbers: Son preference. In several states, many families don’t stop having children after one or two, they stop after they’ve had a son. Analyses of NFHS microdata from the 1990s found that a disproportionate share of “unwanted” births — beyond what women said they wanted — were daughters. As son preference weakens — and slowly, it is weakening, particularly among younger and more educated families — this hidden fertility inflation will deflate.

India’s fertility decline story is not yet a crisis. It is a policy story, one about helping women and couples align their actual lives with their intended ones. Unintended pregnancies have already fallen reasonably from 21 per cent in 2005-06 to 8 per cent in 2019-21. If unmet need for family planning continues to fall, if spacing methods reach young couples who need them most, and if son preference keeps fading, India’s birth rate will fall further on its own. Not because families are being pressured, but because many of the births that currently hold the number up were never truly planned in the first place.

The baby India didn’t plan for may become rarer in future. The more pressing concern now is the recent decline in the use of modern contraceptive methods, which risks leaving the country’s remaining unwanted-fertility gap in place even as the headline TFR falls. This becomes more critical when only 30 per cent of women seek a second birth on their own. India needs to monitor fertility preferences, both intended and unintended births, and ensure couples are able to realise their own choices instead of overall birth rates.

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mJlMzg1
Goli is associate professor at the International Institute for Population Sciences and the author of A Treatise on Families in Contemporary India and James is a demographer and professional specialist at Princeton University. Views are personal

India’s fertility decline story is not yet a crisis. It is a policy story



SRINIVAS GOLI AND K S JAMES

TODAY, INDIA’S most popular headline about its population is simple: The average woman is having about two children over her lifetime. That single figure has become a shorthand for “India has reached replacement-level fertility”, and in one sense it is true. But successive Sample Registration System and National Family Health Survey rounds tell us something that should make us pause: India has achieved below-replacement fertility despite the near universality of marriage — only about 1 per cent of women remain never married by ages 45-49, the median age at first birth is 21.2 years, and childbearing is virtually imposed within marriage with a lower socio-economic status, a demographic pathway that sharply contrasts with the experience of most other low-fertility countries. Therefore, this is not the classic story of low birth rates driven by late marriage or people choosing not to marry. So what, exactly, is inside that two-children average and does it tell us the whole truth?

The widely used total fertility rate (TFR — average number of births per woman) counts all births, including births women did not plan or want, as well as those that happen because families keep trying until they get a son. Thus, it hides actual fertility intentions. Demographers have a name for the part of fertility that represents births women actually wanted: The “wanted fertility rate”. If you count only the births that match what women say they intended, their preferred family size can be obtained. The gap between wanted and actual fertility has narrowed over the years but remains significant. Nationally, women have an average of 2.0 children, while their desired family size is about 1.6, leaving a gap of 0.4. Around eight states (Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Jharkhand, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Assam, Haryana) have a gap of more than 0.3 children per woman.

Here is where India gets genuinely unusual. The country has managed to bring birth rates down to near-replacement levels, and yet millions of women still can’t reliably prevent pregnancies they don’t want. How can both be true?

The answer lies in how Indian women control their fertility:

Women have children, reach

their desired family size, and then stop permanently using sterilisation. What’s largely missing are the tools that help young couples space their children to delay a first birth, or wait a few years between children. When family planning arrives late, unintended pregnancies tend to cluster in the early years of marriage, among the youngest women. This also reflects in relatively poor maternal and child health. Informed choice around sterilisation also re-

mains partial. When women whose sterilisation was not a fully informed choice are counted alongside women with unmet need, India’s “unwanted family planning” problem looks considerably larger than the headline numbers suggest.

There is another force propping up India’s birth numbers: Son preference. In several states, many families don’t stop having children after one or two, they stop after they’ve had a son. Analyses of NFHS microdata from the 1990s found that a disproportionate share of “unwanted” births — beyond what women said they wanted — were daughters. As son preference weakens — and slowly, it is weakening, particularly among younger and more educated families — this hidden fertility inflation will deflate.

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The baby India didn’t plan for may become rarer in future. The more pressing concern now is the recent decline in the use of modern contraceptive methods, which risks leaving the country’s remaining unwanted-fertility gap in place even as the headline TFR falls. This becomes more critical when only 30 per cent of women seek a second birth on their own. India needs to monitor fertility preferences, both intended and unintended births, and ensure couples are able to realise their own choices instead of overall birth rates.

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Goli is associate professor at the International Institute for Population Sciences and the author of A Treatise on Families in Contemporary India and James is a demographer and professional specialist at Princeton University. Views are personal

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• LEGAL

As late PM Singh gets clean chit, recalling the coal block ‘scam’ case

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, July 29

THE SUPREME Court Wednesday gave a posthumous clean chit to the late former Prime Minister Manmohan Singh in a case pertaining to the alleged coal block “scam” that the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) was probing. A bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, Justice Joymalya Bagchi and Justice V Mohana accepted the CBI’s decision to close the case against Singh, who passed away on December 26, 2024, and allowed his appeal challenging the 2015 trial court summons to him in the case. In August and October 2014, the CBI had filed closure reports before the trial court of then Special Judge Bharat Parashar, finding no case against Singh. The special court, however, rejected the reports, took cognisance of the case, and summoned Singh in March 2015. The Supreme Court had stayed the summons to Singh in April 2015.

The case

The case pertains to alleged irregularities in the allocation of Odisha’s Talabira-2 coal block in 2005, when Manmohan Singh was PM and held the charge of the Coal Ministry portfolio. The block was allocated to Mahanadi Coalfields Ltd, Neyveli Lignite Corporation Ltd (NLC) and Hindalco after the three entities formed a joint venture. The alleged irregularities pertained to the inclusion of Hindalco (an Aditya Birla Group flagship company) in the allotment of the block alongside the two public sector undertakings. While the 25th Screening Committee had originally recommended allocating the block to NLC, the decision was revisited after Birla wrote to the Prime Minister’s Office (PMO) requesting coal allocation. The special court had issued summons to Singh, Aditya Birla Group chairman Kumar Mangalam Birla, former Coal Secretary P C Parakh, the company Hindalco and its executives B Shubhendu Amitabh and D Bhattacharya.

COAL CASE

- A CAG report showed inefficient and possibly illegal allocation of coal blocks between 2004 and 2009.
- It estimated a loss to the exchequer to the tune of Rs 10.7 lakh crore, but later toned this down to Rs 1.86 lakh crore.

scious effort” to “somehow accommodate” Hindalco in the process by approving Parakh’s proposal to accommodate the company in the block, while ignoring notes of caution from two PMO officials regarding relaxation of previously approved guidelines. The judge noted that the allocation “nullified” the Screening Committee’s recommendations, and that it hurt the NLC and its efforts to establish a 2,000 megawatt power plant in Odisha.

What Singh’s lawyers said

Now, more than a decade after the special court’s summons, the top court was hearing a batch of petitions in connection with the coal block allotment cases when Senior Advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Singh, referred to the case against the late PM. Sibal said though the matter had become infructuous after Singh’s death, the special court’s remarks against him ought to be expunged. Senior Advocate A M Singhvi, also representing Singh, urged the Supreme Court to do away with the remarks.

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• SECURITY

Besra arrest may not stop Maoist insurgency, but effectively ends the movement

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, July 29

THE ARREST of senior Communist Party of India (Maoist) Politburo member Misir Besra in Jharkhand marks the culmination of one of India’s longest counter-insurgency campaigns. For nearly four decades, Besra remained one of the organisation’s most influential leaders in the Jharkhand-Bihar region, surviving repeated security offensives even as the rest of the Maoist leadership was steadily eliminated through encounters, arrests and surrenders. With his arrest, the CPI (Maoist) has effectively lost the last active member of the leadership that built the organisation into a nationwide insurgent force.

Who is Misir Besra?

Born into a Santhal Adivasi family in Madnadih village of Jharkhand’s Giridih district, Misir Besra studied in Dhanbad before completing graduation and postgraduation in political science at Rajganj. It was during the sociopolitical churn of the

Jharkhand movement in the late 1980s that he was drawn to Maoist ideology. Leaving behind his young wife and family, he joined the Maoist Communist Centre, which later merged with the People’s War Group in 2004 to form the CPI (Maoist). Besra’s rise was driven by military success. Soon after Jharkhand was carved out of Bihar in 2000, he was linked to a series of attacks on security forces, including the 2003 and 2004 IED ambushes in West Singhbhum’s Bitkilsoy and Baliba that killed 55 personnel. The attacks earned him a place in the Central Military Commission and charge of the Eastern Regional Bureau, making him one of the organisation’s most influential leaders in eastern India. For years, agencies knew little about the man behind these attacks until his arrest during a routine vehicle check in 2007. Two years later, he escaped in one of the country’s most audacious Maoist jailbreaks when around 30 cadres attacked a court complex in Bihar’s Lakhisarai, killing a policeman. Besra remained underground for the

next 17 years despite carrying a Rs 1 crore bounty and facing over 150 criminal cases. What does his arrest mean for the Maoist movement? Besra’s arrest completes the dismantling of the CPI (Maoist)’s central leadership that security agencies have pursued over the past two years. Unlike earlier phases of the anti-Maoist campaign, which largely targeted field commanders, the recent offensive focused on decapitating the organisation’s command structure. At the start of 2024, the Politburo and Central Committee together had 21 leaders directing operations, recruitment and strategy across the country. Over the next two years, 12 were killed, seven surrendered and one was arrested. Besra, the only leader left underground, has now been captured. In the Dandakaranya region (spanning Chhattisgarh, Odisha, Telangana, and Andhra Pradesh) — the Maoists’ principal military theatre — the State Committee was dismantled through killings, arrests and sur-

renders. The Madhya Pradesh-Maharashtra-Chhattisgarh committee disappeared after its remaining three members surrendered, while Odisha and Telangana also lost their state leaderships. The Disturbed Region Bureau, which coordinated operations across states, was similarly broken up. Almost every nationally recognised Maoist leader has now either been killed or surrendered. General secretary Nambala Keshava Rao alias Basavaraju and Battalion 1 commander Madvi Hidma were killed, while senior leaders including Mallojula Venugopal Rao (Sonu) and Thippiri Tirupathi (Devuji) surrendered. With Besra’s arrest, the CPI (Maoist) is left with scattered armed groups led by lower-level commanders, but no nationally recognised leadership capable of directing a coordinated insurgency across states. What action has the government taken over the past two years? Security forces pushed deeper into strongholds such as Bastar and Abujhmad,

established forward operating bases, improved road connectivity, and increasingly relied on intelligence-led operations instead of large-area combing exercises. Local forces, particularly Chhattisgarh’s District Reserve Guards, also eroded the Maoists’ long-held advantage in jungle warfare. Alongside military operations, the Centre expanded rehabilitation packages for surrendering cadres. The combined approach has sharply reduced the Maoists’ geographical footprint. According to government data, Left Wing Extremism-related violence has fallen by more than 80% since 2010, and by early 2026 only seven districts remained categorised as LWE-affected, three of them severely so. Can the movement survive? The arrest of Besra does not automatically end Maoist violence. Small groups remain active, particularly in parts of Bastar, and could continue sporadic attacks or extortion. But security officials believe the CPI (Maoist) no longer possesses the leadership,

territorial control or depth needed to regenerate itself as a nationwide insurgency. Roads, connectivity and a stronger administrative presence have reduced the isolation that once enabled the movement to flourish. Former Maoist leaders and security experts argue that the organisation also failed to adapt to changing conditions. Surveillance improved, security forces established a permanent presence in former strongholds and tribal aspirations shifted towards education, welfare and employment. But the CPI (Maoist) remained committed to a strategy of protracted armed struggle. What challenges does govt face? Security experts caution that eliminating the leadership is only one part of the challenge. The areas once dominated by Maoists continue to face problems of governance, infrastructure and access to public services. They argue that security gains must now be consolidated by strengthening civil administration — through schools, health centres, roads, communications and jobs.

• ECONOMY

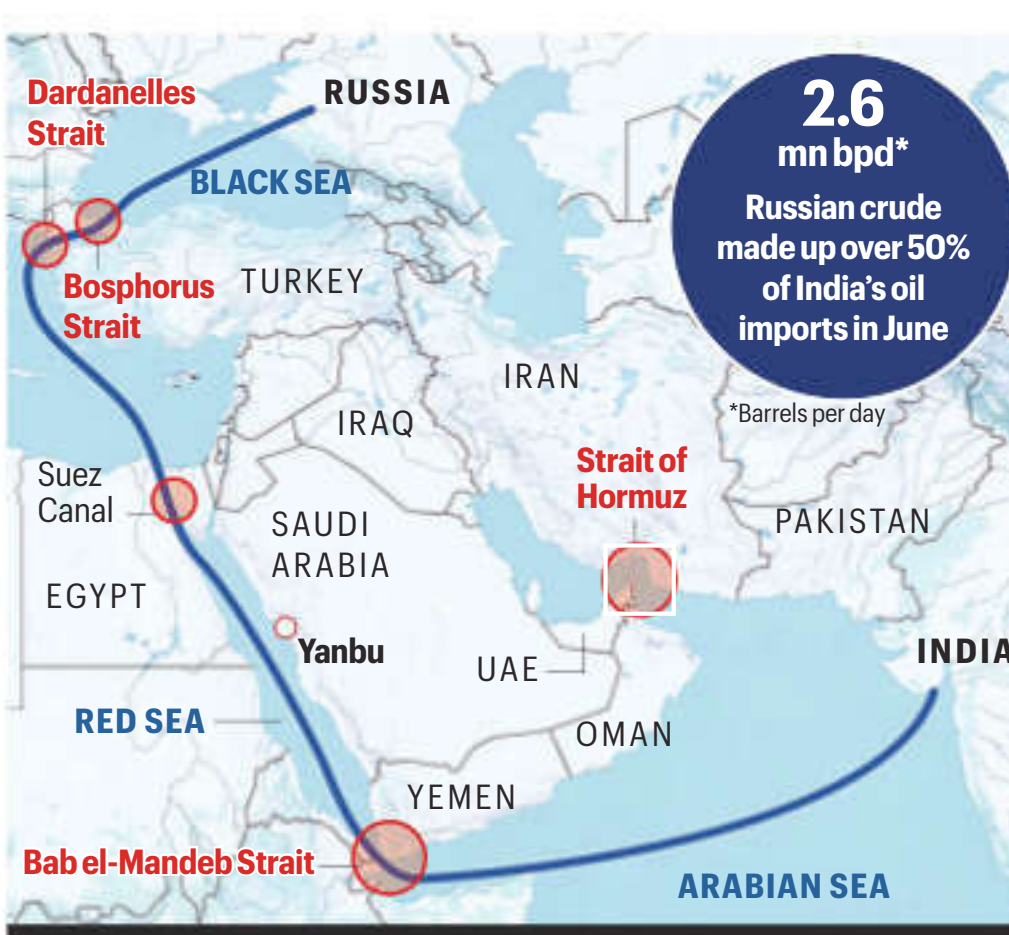
As conflict expands to Red Sea, India’s crude options



SUKALP SHARMA

THE THEATRE of the West Asia conflict, earlier limited to the Strait of Hormuz from the perspective of India’s crude oil imports, has now widened. Last week, the Yemen-based Houthi militia announced it would target Saudi Arabian tankers attempting to cross the Bab el-Mandeb Strait and indeed attacked a few ships. Like the Strait of Hormuz, the Bab el-Mandeb — which connects the Red Sea to the Gulf of Aden and the Arabian Sea — is another critical chokepoint for global trade, and energy supplies in particular. Saudi Arabia was using the route to export its oil, including to India, as Strait of Hormuz traffic fell to a trickle. The Houthi impact is already visible, with vessel crossings via Bab el-Mandeb slumping to an average of 31 per day over the past three days from 43 per day in the first half of July, according to S&P Global data from July 27. The Houthi blockade could delay oil shipments to Asia by forcing tankers to sail through the Suez Canal and then taking the circuitous route around Africa. This would add up to four weeks to the journey, and keep oil prices elevated. This matters for India, which depends on imports to meet over 88% of its oil requirement. But according to analysts, the current risks appear manageable despite the concerns. The first and the most obvious fall-back for the country is Russian crude, the mainstay of its oil imports. So far, Russian oil appears to be safe from Houthi attacks, as it was in earlier Bab el-Mandeb blockades by the Iran-backed militia. Russian oil exports are also under pressure amid Ukraine’s strikes against energy export infrastructure. But the expectation is that while this may restrict the availability of Moscow’s crude, and thus drive up prices, any material impact on India would be limited from a supply security perspective. The Russian option “As per the predictions, if Russian oil (coming through the Red Sea route) is not affected and the blockade is targeted only

• RUSSIAN OIL FLOWS TO INDIA VIA RED SEA UNAFFECTED SO FAR



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against Saudi Arabia, we don’t see a very big challenge. We expect the movement of Russian to increase, which would compensate for any loss in Saudi volumes and cover the requirement. But many ifs and buts are still there, so maybe in another week or 10 days’ time, there would be more clarity,” state-owned Bharat Petroleum’s Chairman and Managing Director Sanjay Khanna told *The Indian Express* last week. The Suez Canal-Red Sea route is the primary route for Russian oil to reach Indian ports. Industry analysts said that if Saudi Arabian oil supplies to India are disrupted, Indian refiners are likely to further increase purchases of Russian oil barrels, while also drawing on commercial crude inventories to bridge temporary supply gaps. More over, India’s increasingly diversified crude slate — which includes dozens of suppliers from across the world — provides greater flexibility than in previous years, reducing the risk of a severe supply disruption. “If Red Sea transit remains uninterrupted, Indian refiners retain an important supply buffer through Saudi Arabia’s East-West (Yanbu) pipeline, which has recently supplied roughly 300,000–500,000 bpd (barrels per day) of crude. However, if the security situation deteriorates and Red Sea imports become unavailable during August, refiners will need to replace those barrels from

Emergency options, beyond Russia

West Asian crude that can bypass regional chokepoints are practical emergency options for Indian refiners.

- There are also options to increase purchases of American and South American oil, but the long voyage times are a challenge.

Dual chokepoints

- With traffic through the Strait of Hormuz down to a trickle, Saudi Arabia was using the Bab el-Mandeb to export its oil, including to India.
- Now, the Houthi blockade on Saudi-linked shipping and energy supplies would force tankers to sail westward instead, through the Suez Canal, and then taking the circuitous route around Africa.
- The Suez Canal-Red Sea route is also the primary route for Russian oil to reach Indian ports.
- So far, Russian oil appears to be safe from Houthi attacks as it was in earlier Bab el-Mandeb blockades by the Iran-backed militia.
- But Russian exports are also under pressure amid Ukraine’s strikes.

alternative sources. Indian refiners are likely to increase purchases of Russian spot barrels where available, while also drawing on commercial crude inventories to bridge any temporary supply gaps,” said Sumit Ritolia, manager, refining and modelling at commodity market analytics firm Kpler. Amid the Strait of Hormuz crisis, India’s Russian crude imports have increased from around 1 million bpd in February to record highs of about 2.6 million bpd in June, accounting for over 50% of India’s overall oil imports. July oil imports from Russia are also tracking at similar levels, as per ship-tracking data. Before the war, over 40% of India’s oil imports came from West Asia via the Strait of Hormuz. According to Ritolia, Russian crude remains India’s strongest supply hedge, and imports could potentially rise toward or even above 3 million bpd if market conditions and Russian export availability permit. He added that the situation would become tighter if Red Sea flows are disrupted, but it is unlikely to become critical. “Russian oil will provide some relief for India and China. Urals was offered at around \$7/barrel discount to Dubai (crude grade) before the latest escalation; those discounts have now disappeared, and Russian barrels are now moving at premiums as Indian refiners compete for supply. However, as India Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzgl

• SPORT

The concerns raised by FIFA’s plans for selling stake in World Cup

Shashank Nair
New Delhi, July 29

FIFA AND its president Gianni Infantino sparked uproar when they announced the formation of a new entity, called the FIFA Forward Enterprise (FFE), that would control the commercial aspects of football’s global governing body. Part of the proposal is to sell a minority stake in the new company that will effectively run the World Cup, the Club World Cup and all other events organised by it — a proclamation that brought condemnation from European, Asian and North and Central American footballing confederations. What raised eyebrows even more was that Thrive Eternal, an investment vehicle headed by Joshua Kushner — the brother of US President Donald Trump’s son-in-law Jared Kushner — was “expected to lead the proposed investor group for FFE”. What is FIFA proposing? Infantino has proposed the formation of the FFE — an entity completely controlled by FIFA and governed by Infantino. The entity would gain control of the commercial arm of FIFA events — ticketing, broadcasting, sponsorships and licensing. FIFA plans

to sell up to 21% of that entity to private investors — an admission it had to make through a hasty press release after the news leaked. The intention is to bring in up to \$4.2 billion based on an equity valuation of \$20 billion, according to FIFA’s own estimates. It then intends to distribute the \$4.2 billion among the 211 countries that form FIFA. How can Infantino make this happen? Each of FIFA’s 211 countries, or Member Associations (MAs), stand to gain an immediate \$20 million from an initiative the world body intends to start, called FIFA Fast Forward Programme. Each MA currently gets \$8 million from FIFA as part of its Forward Funding programme. That number jumps to \$20 million for the 2027-30 cycle, \$22 million for the 2031-34 cycle and \$24 million for the 2035-38 cycle — if the MAs agree to be part of this deal. Will countries accept the deal? Most will. FIFA has bypassed continental football bodies and directly proposed sending money to countries for their backing. Poorer African and Asian countries enjoy voting powers equal to European giants like England, France and Germany. The money FIFA is offering countries may

Shock and surprise

- Continental football governing bodies have been withering in their response.
- Europe’s UEFA said: ‘The soul and governance of football are not assets to trade — especially with zero transparency as to who gains financially. None of us are the owners of football. It is not FIFA’s to sell.’
- The Asian Football Confederation and the CONCACAF (North and South American, and Caribbean) expressed surprise and said none of these plans were discussed with them.



FIFA president Gianni Infantino. AP

not be significant for the footballing powerhouses, but FIFA has used the pretext of democratising football to provide an incentive to the rest of the world to back them for making further profits, and hand control of the biggest sporting event in the world to private investors. It may be easy for a rich country to say no to \$86 million from now till 2038, not so much for a majority of countries affiliated to FIFA.

Does FIFA need this money?

FIFA had estimated the 2026 World Cup and the current four-year cycle (2023-2026)

would bring in \$13 billion. It ended up earning \$15 billion. Selling off a percentage of the World Cup to private investors could bring in vast swathes of additional money. But the real problem lies in who the organisation is planning on selling the World Cup to.

Who is FIFA selling the World Cup to?

This is where the plan starts to make sense in Infantino’s world. Prominent among the buyers is Thrive Eternal, an investment vehicle founded by Peter Thiel. Running it is Joshua Kushner.

What are Infantino’s ties with Trump?

The FIFA president’s relationship with Trump has been unusually close. Infantino conjured up a ‘FIFA Peace Prize’ for Trump, who had spent years bemoaning that he had not got the Nobel Peace Prize. The cosy ties came under severe criticism when Trump personally petitioned for US forward Falorin Balogun’s red card to be rescinded so that he could play in a knockout game. Now, that closeness has tied into a financial deal, indirectly, with the Trump plan.

Even the disgraced former FIFA president Sepp Blatter was unequivocal in his contempt. “No one has the right to sell our game,” he said.

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, JAGRUTI VINOD JAIN C/o Rohit Kumar, A-101-102, SF, Sustain White, Chandra Vatika, Sector-45, Noida-201301, have changed my name to JAGRUTI.	0071050769-1
I, Sanya W/O Deepanker R/O.135/15, Street No-8, Near RK Memorial Munirpur(59).PO:Kheri Manajati Dist.Sonipat Haryana-131103, have changed my name to Sanya Adya, for all, future purposes.	0040868915-6
I, PRIYA CHAUDHARY W/o Hrishav Ravi R/o S/N/A 38, SRINAGR PUTAKI, NEAR SAI MANDIR, KUSUNDA, DHANBAD, JHARKHAND-828116, have changed my name to PRIYA CHOUDHARY	0040868971-2
I, Gunjan Singhal wife of Arpit Singhal R/O T2/701, Panchsheel Pebbles, Sector 3, Vaishali, Ghaziabad, UP have changed my name from Gunjan Raji Aggarwal to Gunjan Singhal for all purposes.	0040868814-1
I Jasmine Kaur W/O, Ranjeet Singh R/O 45a, Second Floor Begumpur Malviya Nagar New Delhi 110017 have changed my name to Baljeet Kaur.	0040868924-1
I, Mittlesh W/o Hari Kishan R/O A-197, Sector -47, Noida-201301 (Uttar Pradesh), have changed my name to Mithales for all Purposes.	0040868960-5
I, Kanchan D/o Nanak Chand W/o Nishant Anand R/O A-3/72, Sector-5, Rohini, Delhi-110085, after marriage have changed my name to Kanchan Anand. In future I shall be known by my new name for all purposes.	0040868983-4
I, Meena Devi, W/o M.K. Gupta, R/o G-334, Preet Vihar, Delhi-110092, do hereby declare that the names Meena Devi, Meena Gupta, and Meena Devi Gupta appearing in my Government, Banking, Educational, Financial and other records/documents refer to one and the same person, i.e., myself. Henceforth, I shall be known and identified only as MEENA DEVI for all future purposes.	0071050806-1
I, RAJENDER KUMAR S/O LALA RAM SHARMA R/O F-187/30, C-3, SANI PUBLIC SCHOOL, LAXMI PARK, NANGLO DELHI - 110041 have changed the name of my minor Daughter from PRAGATI SHARMA to PRAGATI for all purposes.	0071050708-1
I, Gita Devi Sepaul, W/O-Sunil Kumar, R/O-Flat.No.KM-406, Amrapali-Village, Nyay-Khand-2, Indirapuram, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201014, inform that GITA DEVI SEPAUL, GITA DEVI, GITA SRIVASTAVA and GITA SUNIL SRIVASTAVA are names of one and same person.	0040868915-8
I, DAVINDER KOUR alias DIPTI BHATIA, D/o S HARDAMAN SINGH W/o Davinder Singh Bhatia, R/O H-33/95 Sector-3, Rohini Delhi-110085, have changed my name to DIPTI BHATIA.	0040868971-4
I, MOHAMMAD SABIR, S/o ABDULLAH, R/o 3324, Gali Sawar Khan, Kucha Pandit, Lal Kuan, Delhi-110006, have changed my name from ABDUL SABIR to MOHAMMAD SABIR, for all future purposes.	0040868806-1
I, Rajvir Singh Yadav, R/o 84/4, Chhuriya mohalla Tughlakabad village, New Delhi-110044, Have changed my name to Rajbeer Singh for all purposes.	0040868915-1
I, PRAVIN AGRAWAL, S/O- NAKAN CHAND AGARWAL, R/O- SAKET COLONY GALI NO.7, ALIGARH ROAD, HATHRAS UTTAR- PRADESH-204101. HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO PRAVIN KUMAR AGARWAL.	0040868960-7
I, Sachin Kumar, S/o Devender Sugandha, resident of D-1204 12th-Floor, Exotica-Elegance, Ahinsa-Khand-2, Indirapuram, Ghaziabad-201012, Uttar Pradesh, have changed my name from Sachin Kumar to Sachin Sugandha. Henceforth I would be known by the name of Sachin Sugandha for all future purposes.	0040868805-4
I Aanchal W/O Shivansh Jain R/O H.No. 69, Sector-15, Sonipat, Haryana-131001 Have Changed My Name Aanchal To Aanchal Jain Permanently.	0040868820-1
I SARAJOODDIN S/O KARIMUDDIN R/O 3910 F.F.GALI JAGAT CINEMA JAMA MADJID DELHI 6 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO SIRAJUDDIN	0040868960-2
I, Shraddha Kumari Lal alias Shraddha Kumar, W/o Mr. Kaustubh Verma, R/o K-1, Ph-2, Central Park-1, Golf Course Road Sec-42 Gurgaon, PO- Galleria DLF-IV, Dist. Gurgaon, Haryana-122009, have changed my name to Shraddha Lal for all future purposes.	0040868983-1
I, MO KHALAM S/O-NAJIRUDDIN KHAN, HALKA WASE, CHORHLI, PO: CHORHLI, DIST:KHAGARIA, BIHA R-852161 MY NAME TO MD KALAM for all future purposes.	0040868960-9

I, Bijnesh, S/o Sh. Daulat Ram, R/O A-34, Naharpur, Sector-7, Rohini, Delhi-110085, hereby declare that my correct name is BIJNESH. In some of documents, my name has been mentioned as BRIJESH. Both names, BIJNESH and BRIJESH, refer to one and the same person, i.e., myself	0040866951-9
I, Kuldeep Kaur W/o Karan Bhola R/o B-12, Surya Nagar, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201011, have changed my name to Kuldeep Kaur Bhola.	0040868805-2
I IBARAIL, S/o JASIM R/O R-27, Navjeevan Camp, Govindpuri, Kalkaji, New Delhi-110019 have changed my name to MOHD ASHARF for all purposes.	0040868904-1
I, SUKHDEV SINGH, SON OF, DARSHAN SINGH, R/O-H.NO.WZ-68-C, STREET, NO.1, GURU-NANAK NAGAR, TILAK-NAGAR, NEW DELHI-110018, (UID NO.3761-7587-1602) I, declared that my correct name is SUKHDEV SINGH, but in my School Records (EDUCATION QUALIFICATION DOCUMENT 10TH AND 12TH MARKSHEET) my name mentioned as SUKHDEO SINGH there is wrongly-mentioned my name, that I want to be my name as SUKHDEV SINGH, in all records.	0040868915-10
I, MONIKA DEVI, W/o Biraju Goswami alias Murari Goswami and, D/o Sita Ram Goswami alias Sita Goswami Ram, R/o-F-10, Harkesh-Nagar, Okhla Phase-2, Okhla Industrial Estate, South Delhi, Delhi-110020, have changed my name from MONIKA DEVI TO MENKA DEVI, for all purposes.	0040868971-6
I, hitherto known as ARSH KHAN D/O MOHD ASIM R/O House No-633, Rang Mahal, Ganj Meer Khan, Vtc-Daryaganj, Po-Daryaganj, Sub Dist-Darya Ganj, Dist-Central Delhi, Delhi-110002, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as HOOR FATIMA.	0040868817-1
I, Daman Paul alias Daman Paul Kaur W/o Ajay Sardana R/O D-118 Block-D Saket New Delhi South Delhi-110017, have changed my name to Daman Sardana.	0071050740-1
I, SANJAY KUMAR SHARMA, S/o late Shakti Chand Sharma, R/O A-582/2, Shastri Nagar, Delhi-110052, have changed my name to SANJAY SHARMA, for all future purposes.	0040868915-3
I, Rahul Hazarati s/o Ashok Kumar R/O C-77, Back Side, FF, Hari Nagar, Delhi-110064 have changed my name to RAHUL HAZRATI	0040868802-2
I, MOHD ARSHAD S/o Sahalam R/o Pataudi, Gurgaon, Haryana-122504, have changed my name to MOHD ARSHAD for all future purposes.	0040868915-5
I, Katiyayani Wadhawan Popli D/o Atul Wadhawan Exc W/o Prateek Popli R/o Flat No-321, Guru Apartments, Plot No-2, Dwarka Sec-6, Delhi-110075 that I got divorce from my Ex-husband vide Divorce Decree No. HMA No. 2808/2024, Dated 02/12/2024, have changed my name to Katiyayani Wadhawan.	0071050743-1
I, Unnati Mehndiratta W/o Tarun Mehndiratta R/o-PP-2, Second floor, Pitampura, Maurya Enclave, New Delhi-110034, have changed my name to Unnati Mehndiratta	0040868971-1
I, DARSHAN MUKESHBHAI SHAH, S/o Mukeshbhai Shah R/o 4Y-804, AWHO, Gurjinder Vihar, CHI-II, Greater Noida, Gautam Budh Nagar, U.P., have changed the name of my minor son DIKSHAN TO DIKSHAN DARSHAN SHAH for all future purposes.	0040868804-1
I Vidya Devi D/o, Jagdish Jha R/o B-132, Sector 36, near Nishi Gurukul School, Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh have changed my name to Bibha Devi.	0040868922-1
I, Raj Kumar S/o Om Prakash R/O H.No.766, Ram Mandir, Sector-5, Gurgaon (Haryana)-122001, have changed my name to Raj Kumar Sharma.	0040868960-4
I, Bhupinder Kaur Kharbanda W/O Manjeet Singh R/O H.No.81/82, 1st Floor, Pocket-16, Sector-24, Rohini, Delhi-110085, have change my name to Bhupinder Kaur for all Purposes.	0040868983-3
I Ashok Kapoor, S/o Inder Prakash Kapoor R/o D-6/2, Rana Pratap Bagh, Delhi-110007 have changed the name of my minor son from Madhav Kapoor to Maadhava Kapoor for all purposes.	0040868803-1
I NEETU W/O Deepak Bhandula born on 20-01-1979 residing at WZ-311 3rd floor Rishi Nagar Rani Bagh Delhi-110034 have changed my name to NEETU BHANDULA vide affidavit	0050294042-1
I, Arun Kumar, S/o/Raj Kumar, R/o-Flat No.29-B, Raavi-Apartment, Vikaspuri, New Delhi-110018, have changed my minor son's name from Rudra Teotia to Rudra Chaudhary and minor daughter's name, from Gargi to Gargi Chaudhary, for all future purposes	0040868915-7

I, BABAO MIAN, S/O CHOTE MANSOORI, R/O A-56/2, main road, shastri park seelampur delhi-110053, have changed my name to BABBU MANSOORI, FOR ALL PURPOSE	0040868971-5
I, Salil Dubey S/o Sheo Shankar Dubey R/O N1/65, A-15, Ganeshbagh, Nagwa, Varanasi, Uttar Pradesh-221005, have changed my name to SALIL KUMAR DUBEY for all future purposes.	0071050719-1
I, SIMMI AGGARWAL W/O RAJ KUMAR R/O C-7/233, SECTOR-7, ROHINI, DELHI-110085 CHANGED MY NAME TO SIMMI GUPTA PERMANENTLY.	0040868971-3
I, SEEMA RAWAT, W/o Anoop Singh Rawat, R/O D-11, Mayur Vihar, Vardhaman Apartment, Mayur-Vihar, Ph-1, Extension, Delhi-110091, have changed my name to SEEMA NEGI, for all future purposes.	0040868915-2
I, Sujith G S/o Raghavan Gopinathan, PRAKRITHI, Gandhi Nagar, Mannuthy PO, Thrissur, Kerala - 680651, have changed my name to Sujith Gopinath	0071050702-1
I, Asha Makkar W/o Pradeep Kumar Makar R/O, H.No.70, J.K.Apartment, A-3-Block, Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110063, have changed my name to Asha Makar.	0040868805-3
I, Gurvinder Singh S/o. Mr. Sukhvinder Singh R/o. 13/348, Trilok Puri, Delhi-91, do hereby solemnly affirm & declare that my correct DOB is 30-06-84 which should be used for all future purposes. In my Passport No. K1811384, my DOB 30-06-89 is wrongly printed & be treated as null & void. Both are one & same person only.	0040868825-1
I, ATIF S/O SIRAJUDDIN R/O 3910 F.F.GALI JAGAT CINEMA JAMA MADJID DELHI 6 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO MOHAMMAD ATIF	0040868960-1
It is general information that I, Prakash Devi, W/o Ashok Kumar, residing at C-83/7, Govindpuram, Ghaziabad UP-201013, declare that name of my mine has been wrongly written as Parkash Devi in my Boi Data The actual name of mine is Prakash Devi which may be amended accordingly.	0040868971-7
I, Simran Singh R/o C-32, Hari Nagar, Delhi-110064 have changed my daughter's name from Sakhipreet Kaur Rajpal to SAKHI PREET KAUR	0040868802-1
I, VINAY KUMAR BANSAL, S/O-PRITAM LAL BANSAL, R/O HNO-2,3rd-FLOOR ROAD NO.25, EAST PUNJABI BAGH PUNJABI BAGH DELHI-110026, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO VINAY BANSAL.	0040868960-6
I, Rajat. M. Sachdeva S/o Manohar Lal Sachdeva R/o CA-61 Tagore Garden West Delhi-110027, have changed the name of my minor daughter Anaisha Sachdeva to Anaishaa Sachdeva aged 13 years.	0071050742-1
I, NEELAM KUMARI SHARMA W/o Sanjay Sharma, R/o A-582/2, Shastri Nagar, Delhi-110052, have changed my name to NEELAM SHARMA for all future purposes.	0040868915-4
I, Amber Gupta R/o M1a506 Tower 24 Gulmohur Garden Raj Nagar Extension Ghaziabad have changed my minor daughter's name from Vanya Gupta to Vanya Maheshwari.	0040868918-1
I, Rakhi W/o Sunil Dabas R/o H.No-330, Harshuke Pana, Near Society Stand, Pooth Khurd, Delhi-110039 have changed my name to Rakhi Dabas.	0040868960-10
I, RAMANJIT KAUR W/O-Gurmeet Singh R/O-C-30, FF Sudershan-Park New Delhi-110015, have changed my name to RAMAN JEET KAUR, permanently	0040868805-1
I, Sunil Kumar, S/O-Awadesh Prasad Srivastava, R/O-Flat.No.KM-406, Amrapali-Village, Nyay Khand-2, Indirapuram, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201014, inform that SUNIL KUMAR and SUNIL KUMAR SRIVASTAVA both the names are one and same person.	0040868915-9
I, Anil Kumar Gupta S/o Ramcharan Bhagat, R/O E-16, Third-Floor, Avantika, Rohini, Delhi-110085, I Declare that I have changed my name from I Anil Kumar to Anil Kumar for all purposes, Anil Kumar & Anil Kumar Gupta is the same person.	0040868805-5
I, Neha Arunkumar Naidu W/o Rohit Banhotra R/o House No-90, Third Floor, Pocket-22, Sector-24, Village Rithala, New Delhi-110085 have changed my name to Neha Rohit Banhotra.	0040868911-1
I, Pardeep S/o Jagdish Chander, R/o H.No.5, Shri Ram Enclave, Maruti Kunj Road ,Near Kit College, Bhondsi, Gurgaon (Haryana), have changed my name to Pardeep Berwal.	0040868960-3
I, Ashok Kumar s/o Roshan Lal R/o C-93, Hari Nagar, Clock Tower, Delhi-110064 have changed my name to ASHOK MALHOTRA	0040868802-3

PUBLIC NOTICE

TO WHOMSOEVER IT MAY CONCERN This is to inform the General public that following Share Certificate of HEG LTD. Having its Registered Office at Mandideep Near Bhopal Distt. Raigarh, Madhya Pradesh -462046, registered in the name of the following Shareholders have been lost by them. I, Kabi Nath Bedi, Pushpa Bedi (Share Holder) Folio No. 059421, Certificate No. 157470, 157471, 0322535, 0322536 Distinctive No.1852612 To 18526215, 030251079 To 030251178. (No. of Share 20) The public are hereby cautioned against purchasing or dealing in any way with the above referred share certificate. Any person who has any claim in respect of the said share certificate should lodge such claim with the company or its registrar and Transfer Agent MCS SHARE TRANSFER AGENT LTD, 179-180, 3rd floor DSIDC Shed Okhla Industrial area, Phase -1 New Delhi -110020. Within 15 days of publication of this notice after which no claim will be entertained and the company shall proceed to issue Duplicate Share Certificates. Place: New delhi Date:	
SUMAN KUMAR BEDI Name of Legal Claimant	
PUBLIC NOTICE General public is here by informed that my clients Shri Rajender Kumar S/O Late Sh. Roshan Lal and Smt. Hardevi W/O Rajender Kumar both R/O 156, First Floor, Type III, Block II, Lodhi Colony, Lodhi Road Delhi have severed their relation with their Daughter Ms Kriti as she married with one Pandeep Prajapati as they have no control over them. Both of my clients have severed their relation with both of them and have also disowned and debarred both of them from all their movable and immovable properties. Anybody dealing with Ms Kriti and Sh.Pandeep Prajapati will do so at his/her own risk and responsibilities and my clients will not be responsible for any act, deed or dealings done by them. Sd/- Laveen Larooya Advocate Ch. No. 584, Lawyers Chambers, Rohini Courts, Delhi-110085	
PUBLIC NOTICE Se it known to all that my client MRS. RITU MISHRA W/O LATE ALOK SHARMA R/o Flat No.M-201, ARUNA APARTMENT, PLOT No.33, I/P, EXTENSION, DELHI-110092, has disowned her son namely "PARARTH RAI SHARMA" Aged about 19 Yrs, from her moveable and immovable properties due to his misbehavior, ill-treatment, disrespectfulness, disobedience and ill-temper and my client has severed all her relation with him and she shall not be responsible for any of his act and deed. Any person dealing with him will be responsible for his/her own risk and consequences. AMAR SINGH (Advocate) Enrolment No. D/3500/2010, Mobile:- 9313500952	

COURT NOTICE IN THE COURT OF SH. HARISH KUMAR, DISTRICT JUDGE (COMMERCIAL COURT)-04 WEST DISTRICT, ROOM NO.202, 2ND FLOOR, EXTENSION BLOCK, TIS HAZARI COURTS DELHI SUMMON FOR PUBLICATION PROCLAMATION REQUIRING ATTENDANCE OF DEFENDANT (Order 5, Rule 20 of the Code of Civil Procedure) Smt. RESU CHOWDHRY SUIT. NO. C5 (COMM)/20/2026 Vs MAGIC EYE DEVELOPERS PVT LTDDefendant To, DEFENDANT MAGIC EYE DEVELOPERS PVT LTD HAVING ITS OFFICE AT: GROUNG FLOOR, 09, PLAZA M-6, JASOLA DISTRICT CENTRE, JASOLA, NEW DELHI- 110025 THROUGH ITS DIRECTOR BRIJWAR PAL KASHYAP THE DEFENDANT ABOVE NAMED, WHEREAS you are intentionally evading service of summons it is hereby notified that if you shall not defend the case on the 17.08.2026 the day fixed for the final disposal, it will be heard and determined ex-parte. Given under my hand and the seal of the court, this 24.07.2026. Sd/- Judge	
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COURT NOTICE

IN THE COURT OF SH. HARISH KUMAR, DISTRICT JUDGE (COMMERCIAL COURT)-04 WEST DISTRICT, ROOM NO.202, 2ND FLOOR, EXTENSION BLOCK, TIS HAZARI COURTS DELHI

SUMMON FOR PUBLICATION
PROCLAMATION REGARDING ATTENDANCE OF DEFENDANT
(Order 5, Rule 20 of the Code of Civil Procedure)

Suit No. **CS (COMM)20/2026**
SMT. RENU CHOWDHRYPlaintiff

Vs
MAGIC EYE DEVELOPERS PVT LTDDefendant

To,
DEFENDANT
MAGIC EYE DEVELOPERS
PVT LTD HAVING ITS OFFICE
AT: GROUING FLOOR, 09,
PLAZA M-6, JASOLA DISTRICT
CENTRE, JASOLA,
NEW ELHI- 110025
THROUGH ITS DIRECTOR
BHANWAR PAL
KASHIYAP

THE DEFENDANT ABOVE NAMED.
WHEREAS you are intentionally evading service of summons it is hereby notified that if you shall not defend the case on the 17.08.2026 the day fixed for the final disposal, it will be heard and determined ex-parte.

Given under my hand and the seal of the court, this 24.07.2026.

Seal

Sd/-
Judge

NORTHERN RAILWAY

(E-Auction Notice)

Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/PS, Northern Railway, Delhi Division invites bids through e-Auction through IREPS (<https://ireps.gov.in/>) for the allotment of Deluxe Pay & Use Toilet Contracts on ROMT & MOT Basis, at following Railway stations/locations:-

E-Catalogue No.	Date & Time of bidding	Railway Stations/Locations/Sites
PaynUse-9-2026	14.08.2026 को 12:00 बजे	Hazrat Nizamuddin (NZM) 01 Site, Delhi (DLI) 01 Site, Anand Vihar (ANVT) 01 Site, Patel Nagar (PTNR) 01 Site, Modinagar (MDNR) 01 Site, Narwana (NRW) 01 Site, Mansa (MSZ) 01 Site & Panipat 01 Site (PNP) Total 08 Sites.

Website particulars where complete details of E-Auction can be seen <https://ireps.gov.in/>

All contractors who intend to participate in the e-auctions conducted through E-Auction Leasing module of IREPS should fulfil following mandatory requirements before they can submit their bids:

- Registration on IREPS for E-Auction Leasing module -Active IREPS User Account for E-Auction Leasing Module.
- Payment of One Time Registration Fee: Current Account in State Bank of India, Integration of SBI Bank Account with IREPS Account; Lien Marking of Funds; Updation of Turnover Details.
- A new mechanism namely Virtual Account Number (VAN) has been introduced now for E-Auction Leasing module, which can be used by the bidders as an alternative to Lien Marking Mechanism. The bidders are free to switch between Lien Marking Mechanism (if activated) and VAN mechanism at any point of time, before entering the bidding room. VAN mechanism does not require the bidder to have a current account in State Bank of India. The users are free to transfer money from any of their existing bank accounts in any bank to their VAN account, which enables them to participate in IREPS E-Auctions.
- Contractors who do not have IREPS account for any module of IREPS can submit their online request for registration by clicking on New Vendors / Contractors (E-Tender /E-Auction Leasing) link on IREPS Home page.

Railway Authority to contact, in case of any query **Divisional Railway Manager's Office, Commercial Branch, State Entry Road, New Delhi 110055. Email: sanitationcell@gmail.com Tel: 011-23743084**

No. 7PUB/TN/Pay&UseToilets/Auction/2022/2022 Date: 28.07.2026 **2620/2026**

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

AXIS FINANCE LIMITED

(CIN:U05201MH1999PLC210378)
Axis House, C-2, Wadia International Centre, Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai - 400 025

Ref. No. **AFL/CO/2026-27/Legal/May/6** **Dated: 27th July, 2026**

BY SPEED POST/ REGISTERED A.D./EMAIL WITHOUT PREJUDICE

To,

1	Sangam Education Society (Borrower) Vpo Tosham, Tehsil Tosham, Bhiwani, Haryana-127040. Email: sangamts2011@gmail.com Mob: 9671999599	2	Nahni Chander (Co-Borrower 1/ Mortgage) Village Kharkari, Sohan Kharkhari, Sohan 39, Bhiwani, Haryana-127040. Email: sangamts2011@gmail.com Mob: 9671999599 Also at: Vpo Tosham, Tehsil Tosham, Bhiwani, Haryana-127040.
3	Rajesh Kumar (Co-Borrower 2) H. No. 694, Alampur, 78 Thilod, Bhiwani, Haryana-127040. Email: sangamts2011@gmail.com Mob: 9671999599 Also at: Vpo Tosham, Tehsil Tosham, Bhiwani, Haryana-127040	4	Sunita Singh (Co-Borrower 3/ Mortgage) Village Kharkari, Sohan Kharkhari, Sohan 39, Bhiwani, Haryana-127040. Email: sangamts2011@gmail.com Mob: 9671999599 Also at: Vpo Tosham, Tehsil Tosham, Bhiwani, Haryana-127040.
5	Ramesh Kumar (Co-Borrower 4) Dohka Harya, 7 Charkhi Dadri, Bhiwani, Haryana-127026. Email: sangamts2011@gmail.com Mob: 9671999599 Also at: Vpo Tosham, Tehsil Tosham, Bhiwani, Haryana-127040.	6	Anil Kumar (Co-Borrower 5) Dohka Harya, 7 Charkhi Dadri, Bhiwani, Haryana-127026. Email: sangamts2011@gmail.com Mob: 9671999599 Also at: Vpo Tosham, Tehsil Tosham, Bhiwani, Haryana-127040.
7	Hardeep Kumar (Co-Borrower 6) Village Kharkari, Sohan Kharkhari, Sohan 39, Bhiwani, Haryana-127040. Email: sangamts2011@gmail.com Mob: 9671999599 Also at: Vpo Tosham, Tehsil Tosham, Bhiwani, Haryana-127040.	8	Pawan Kumar (Co-Borrower 7) Village Kharkari, Sohan Kharkhari, Sohan 39, Bhiwani, Haryana-127040. Email: sangamts2011@gmail.com Mob: 9671999599 Also at: Vpo Tosham, Tehsil Tosham, Bhiwani, Haryana-127040.
9	Suresh Kumar House no 35, Near Kuava Village, Kharkari Sohan (Dhani Dala) Kharkhari Sohan 39, Biwani, Haryana 127040. Email: sangamts2011@gmail.com Also at: Vpo Tosham, Tehsil Tosham, Bhiwani, Haryana-127040.		

...(Hereinafter collectively referred as "**Borrowers**")

Dear Sir/Madam,
SUB: **NOTICE UNDER SECTION 13(2) OF THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 (AS AMENDED FROM TIME TO TIME) AND THE RULES MADE THEREUNDER**

REF: **LOAN ACCOUNT No. 0456MMA00021045/ 0456MMA00018212/ 0456MMA00014147**

I, the undersigned, being the Authorized Officer of Axis Finance Limited (hereinafter referred to as "**the AFL/ Secured Creditor**"), a company incorporated under the provision of the Companies Act, 1956 and a Non-Banking Financial Company registered under the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934, having its Registered Office at Axis House, Axis Finance Limited, ground floor, C-2, Wadia International Centre, Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai - 400025 do hereby give this Notice under Section 13(2) of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002, (hereinafter referred to as the "**SARFAESI Act**") as under:

AFL, in the ordinary course of its business, at the request of Borrower sanctioned the following credit facilities to the borrower on the terms and conditions as mentioned therein:

- INR 24000000/- (Rupees Two Crore Forty Lakhs Only)** Loan no - **0456MMA00014147** ("Credit Facility I") on the terms and conditions as mentioned in Loan Agreement dated **15.06.2024** ("Facility Agreement I"), signed and executed by the **Borrowers**.
- INR 12000000/- (Rupees One Crore Twenty Lakhs Only)** Loan no - **0456MMA00018212** ("Credit Facility II") on the terms and conditions as mentioned in Loan Agreement dated **26.02.2025** ("Facility Agreement II"), signed and executed by the **Borrowers**.
- INR 15000000/- (Rupees One Crore Fifty Lakhs Only)** Loan no - **0456MMA00021045** ("Credit Facility III") on the terms and conditions as mentioned in Loan Agreement dated **31.08.2025** ("Facility Agreement III"), signed and executed by the **Borrowers**.

1. Pursuant thereto, you Addressee(s) in your capacity as Borrower, Co-Borrower(s) and Mortgage in order to secure/ guarantee the repayment of all amounts payable under the aforesaid Facility Agreements and consequently, have been jointly and severally liable for the repayment of the Credit Facility upon availed by the Borrower. You the Addressee(s) had agreed to repay the Credit Facilities in Equal Monthly Instalments.
[The facility and security documents executed/submitted for the Credit Facilities in terms of the Facility Agreements shall be collectively referred to as the "Transaction Documents" hereinafter in this notice]

2. That as a security towards repayment of all amounts payable under the aforesaid Credit Facilities, the Mortgagors had with an intent to secure the Credit Facilities, created mortgage and charge of all their right, title, interest in the land/assets more particularly detailed in **SCHEDULE A** hereto vide Memorandum of Entry Recording Mortgage by Deposit of Title Deeds dated 08.07.2024, 03.08.2025 and 01.08.2025.

*[The asset as mentioned in SCHEDULE A shall be hereinafter referred to as "**Secured Asset**"]*

3. It is pertinent to state herein that You the Borrowers by virtue of the Facility Agreements have availed Credit Facilities from AFL by mortgaging the property mentioned in SCHEDULE A, and thereby created secured interest in favour of AFL. The security mentioned in SCHEDULE A is "Secured Asset" within the meaning of section 2(1) (zc) of the SARFAESI Act.

4. At the request of you the Addressee(s), AFL had on various dates disbursed the Credit Facilities to the Borrower on specific instructions.

5. As per the terms of the Transaction Documents, You the Borrowers/Mortgagor were required to repay the dues under the said Credit Facilities and further you the Borrowers/Mortgagor were also required to pay interest thereon and other charges at the contractual rates as in the manner set out in the Facility Agreements and subsequent communication(s).

6. However, you the Borrowers/Mortgagor, have failed to comply with the terms and conditions of the Transaction Documents and defaulted in repayment of the amount payable under the Facility Agreements. AFL had through various default notices informed you the Addressee(s) of such default, however, till date, the same have neither been repaid nor any steps have been undertaken thereby to repay the outstanding amounts.

7. In this context, it is important to note that since you the Addressee(s) have committed continuous defaults, the account has become non-performing asset ("**NPA**") w.e.f. **06.05.2026** in compliance with the directives/guidelines relating to asset classification issued by the Reserve Bank of India from time to time.

8. It is imperative to state herein that the above information of classification of account as NPA was communicated by AFL to you the Addressee(s) vide an NPA intimation letter dated 08.05.2026 bearing Ref. No. AFL/NPA/CO/May-26/0624, AFL/NPA/CO/May-26/0661 and AFL/NPA/CO/May-26/0585.

9. Please note that the provision of Act of the secured creditor due to Secured Creditor is a debt secured against the Secured Asset and you being the Borrowers/Mortgagor, have committed defaults in repayment of such secured debt/Credit Facilities in terms of the Transaction Documents.

10. As on 23.07.2026, the total outstanding debt due and payable by You the Borrowers/Mortgagor, to the Secured Creditor is **INR 4,97,69,729/-**, as more particularly detailed in **SCHEDULE B** hereto.

11. In view of the aforesaid, the Secured Creditor has become entitled to issue this statutory notice to the Borrower/ Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagor(s), in terms of Section 13(2) of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and hereby call upon you al Addressee(s) jointly and severally to full discharge in full the dues towards the Secured Creditor amounting/ aggregating **INR 4,97,69,729/- (Rupees Four Crores Ninety Seven Lakhs Sixty Nine Thousand Seven Hundred Twenty Nine Only)** due as on 23.07.2026 together with applicable interest, further interest, default interest, premia, costs, charges etc. at contractual rates in respect of the Credit Facility from this date till date of repayment, **within 60 days (Sixty days) from the date of this Notice issued under Section 13(2) of the SARFAESI Act**, failing which the Secured Creditor shall be constrained to exercise its rights of enforcement of security interest without any further reference to you under the said SARFAESI Act and entirely at your risk as to costs and consequences.

12. On expiry of 60 days from the date hereof and on your failure to comply with the demand, the Secured Creditor shall take the following measures under the SARFAESI Act:

- Take over possession of the Secured Asset as mentioned in Schedule A hereto including the right to transfer by way of lease, assignment or sale for realizing the same;
- take over management of business of you the Addressee(s) including the right to transfer by way of lease, assignment or sale for realizing the Secured Asset, subject to the conditions as stipulated in the *proviso* to Section 13(4)(b) and Section 15 of the SARFAESI Act;
- appoint any person to manage the Secured Asset, the possession of which will be taken over by AFL;
- require at any time by notice in writing, any person who has acquired any of the Secured Asset from you the Addressee(s) and from whom any money is due or may become due to you the Addressee(s), to pay AFL, so much of the money as is sufficient to pay the secured debt.

13. I also invite your attention to Section 13(8) of the SARFAESI Act, whereby you have an opportunity to tender the amount due as stated above to the secured creditor together with all costs, charges and expenses incurred, at any time before the date of publication of notice for public auction or inviting quotations or tender from public or private treaty for transfer by way of lease, assignment or sale of secured assets.

14. All of you are notified and cautioned that as per the provisions of Section 13 (13) of the SARFAESI Act, no transfer of the Secured Asset (set out in the SCHEDULE A hereunder) by way of sale, lease or otherwise, shall be made without prior written consent of Secured Creditor. Please note that any non-compliance/contravention of the provisions contained in the said SARFAESI Act and with the Rules, is an offence punishable under Section 29 of the SARFAESI Act.

15. Please further note that this statutory notice is issued without prejudice to the rights of the Secured Creditor including initiation of any further legal proceedings/legal action as deemed fit and necessary under the provisions of any law for the time being in force and/or as per contract or both.

16. I hereby expressly reserve all rights under the relevant Transaction Documents, any other associated documents, under law or otherwise. Nothing contained in this notice or any action or inaction by us shall operate as a waiver of, or prejudice, diminish or otherwise adversely affect, any of our present or future rights or remedies under the respective Transaction Documents or any of our rights or remedies under law or generally, which remain and shall continue in full force and effect.

17. The undersigned is duly Authorized as Authorized Officer to issue this Notice and exercise powers on behalf of the Secured Creditor under the SARFAESI Act read with the Rules.

18. Request you to kindly acknowledge the receipt of this Notice. A copy of this notice is being retained in our office for future reference.

Yours Faithfully,

Authorized Officer
Axis Finance Limited

SCHEDULE A

DETAILS OF SECURED ASSETS

All that Piece and parcel of Property building total area admeasuring 51 kanal 12 marla (approximately) comprised in the Araj Khawat No. 375 Min, Khatoni No 501 Min, Kharsa No. 352/6 (8-0) and Araj Khawat 1753 Khatoni 2279, Kharsa 352/14/2 (4-12), Araj Khawat No. 1261 Kharsa 352/23 (7-0) 24 (8-0) Khawat No. 353 Kharsa No. 352/15 (8-0), 16 (8-0), 17 (8-0), Khawat No. 1639 Kharsa No.352/14/2-(12), Tehsil Tosham, Mouja Tosham, District- Bhiwani, Haryana-127040 and construction thereon, bounded as under:

East- Agriland
North- Agriland
West- Agriland
South- Agriland

SCHEDULE B

DETAILS OF OUTSTANDING AMOUNTS AS ON 23.07.2026

Sl. No.	Loan No.	Principal Outstanding	Interest Overdue	Penal & Other Charges	Total Outstanding
1.	0456MMA00014147	2,15,05,744	10,17,176	25,024	2,25,47,944
2.	0456MMA00018212	1,13,25,875	5,33,992	13,880	1,18,73,747
3.	0456MMA00021045	1,46,52,030	6,79,351	16,657	1,53,48,038
	Total	4,74,83,649/-	22,30,519/-	55,561/-	Rs.4,97,69,729/-

Note: - Interest at the applicable interest rate as defined in the facility Agreement.

WEST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Notice Inviting Tender

No ET/TRS/WC/08/26-27 Date: 27-07-2026

For and on behalf of the President of India, the Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer (Traction Rolling Stock) Electric Loco Shed, West Central Railway, New yard, Itarsi, invites E-Tender up-to dtd 22.08.2026 at 15.00 Hrs. as mentioned below- **E-Tender No. : ET/TRS/WC/08/26-27, Name of Work with its Location :** "Repair/ Reconditioning of 1750 LPM Compressor's of Electric Locomotives". **Approx. cost of work:** 11,62,91,826.09/-, **Earnest Money:** 23,25,900/-, **Completion period:** 36 Months, **Note:** 1. E-Tender document and details of E-tender will be available on Website www.ireps.gov.in. 2. Definition of similar nature work" for "Minimum Eligibility Criteria for Tender No. E T / T R S / W C / 0 8 / 2 6 - 2 7 is "Manufacturing/ Supply/ Repair/ Rehabilitation/ AMC/ Overhauling of Main Compressor of B.G Electric Locomotives / Diesel Locomotives/ EMU/MEMU/DEMU/Train Set/Metro". **SD**
Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer
Electric loco Shed
West Central Railway, Itarsi

सच भारत अधिकाय
एक कदम सचता की ओर

"IMPORTANT"

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GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA CORRIGENDUM

SL. No.	NAME OF BOARD CORP./AUTH	OLD REFERENCE/NIT NO.	NATURE OF CORRIGENDUM	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD CORP./AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	HYPNL	NIT NO.04/CHV/NHP/2026-27 DATED 14.05.2026-HEW TENDER REF.NO. 2026/040026 EEN-4933 B549 PFTBAC/NC268997HP-ONLINE TENDER ID: 2026_HYC_521586_1.	"CORRIGENDUM No. 07, 'THE LAST DATE OF ONLINE BID SUBMISSION IS EXTENDED UPTO 07.08.2026 (13.00 HRS) FOR LAC SOCIETIES & CONTRACTORS'	www.hypn.org.in	0172-3583399 PRODH@HYPN.ORG.IN

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in **No. 47638/HR**

ICAR-INDIAN VETERINARY RESEARCH INSTITUTE IZATNAGAR- 243 122

Walk-in-interview

Walk-in Interview has been scheduled for engagement of **One Project Technical Support-III** under ICMR Funded Project on purely temporary basis. Interested candidates may attend the interview with application & original documents on **6th August, 2026 at 11.00AM** at Immunology Section, IVRI, Izatnagar. Please visit Institute website www.ivri.nic.in for details of advertisement.

(Dr Sameer Shrivastava)
Principal Investigator
ICMR Project

व्यसन उपचार सुविधा योजना सिविल अस्पताल सोनीपत । विज्ञापन

एटीएफ योजना सोनीपत के अंतर्गत वित्त वर्ष 2026-27 के लिए पूर्णतः खर्च आधार पर नियुक्त होने के लिए इच्छुक और योग्य उम्मीदवारों से आवेदन आमंत्रित किए जाते हैं, जो कि प्रारंभ में 31.03.2027 तक होंगे, जोकि पूरी तरह से प्रदर्शन के आधार पर और आगे की प्रशासनिक स्वीकृति के अधीन होंगे। इन पदों के लिए एनएचएम उपनिषय लागू नहीं होंगे। आवेदन सभी कार्य दिवसों में सुबह 08:00 बजे से दोपहर 02:00 बजे तक करना नं 32 सिविल अस्पताल सोनीपत में स्वीकार किए जाएंगे। (फार्म जमा करते समय किसी भी बदलाव की सूचना दी जाएगी)।

No.	Name of Post	No. Of Posts And Category	Age Limit	Honorarium (Monthly) Consolidated	Essential Qualifications
1	Medical Officer	Total-01	18-65 years	Rs. 60000/-	MBBS from recognised institution along with Medical Council registration (Preferably MD or equivalent qualification in psychiatry)

निर्देश: सभी दस्तावेजों की स्व-सत्यापित प्रतियों के साथ विधिवत भरा हुआ आवेदन स्वीकार किया जाएगा। इसके लिए कोई टोप / डीए लागू नहीं होगा। आवेदन पत्र जमा करते समय अन्य निर्देश दिए जाएंगे।

हस्ता/-
सिविल सर्जन
सोनीपत ।

No. 47625/HR

Office of the Chief Engineer

Design, Master Planning & Hydrology (Water Resource Department)

Jai Bhawan Room No- 203, Doranda, Ranchi-834002 Email- cedesign-wrd-jhr@nic.in

Letter No.- 424 Ranchi/ Dated-23/07/24

Notice Inviting Application (for Willingness) from Domain Experts for Empanelment of Members for Independent Panel of Experts (IPOE) to Conduct Comprehensive Dam Safety Evaluation (CDSE) of Specified Dams under WRD Jharkhand

In light of Chapter IX, Section 38, 39 and 40 of Dam Safety Act 2021, NDSA Regulation No. 407, Dated 23.05.2025 and Government of Jharkhand Resolution No. 3/P.M.C/Misc/757/2026-371 dated 29.06.26, Water Resources Department, Govt. of Jharkhand intends to select members for **2 (two) Independent Panel of Experts (IPOE)**, where in each Panel shall consist of 8 (eight) domain experts including Chairman.

The structure of each IPOE shall be as under:

SL No.	DESIGNATION	DOMAIN OF EXPERTISE
1	Chairman	Shall be designated from one among the listed Members
2	Member	Dam Safety Expert
3	Member	Design Expert
4	Member	Construction Supervision Expert
5	Member	Geologist
6	Member	Hydrologist
7	Member	Hydromechanical Expert
8	Member	Instrumentation Expert
9	Member	Seismic Expert

- The expected prerequisite qualifications of domain experts are as described in NDSA Regulation No. 407, Dated 23.05.2025 attached with this Notice Inviting Applications. (Details are available on the link provided in the website- wrd.jharkhand.gov.in)
- Relevant Terms and conditions pertaining to the functioning of each IPOE are mentioned in Government of Jharkhand Resolution No. 3 / P.M.C / Misc / 757 / 2026-371 dated 29.06.26. (Details are available on the link provided in the website- wrd.jharkhand.gov.in)
- The Terms of Reference, describing the roles and responsibilities, remunerations etc. are as mentioned. (Details are available on the link provided in the website- wrd.jharkhand.gov.in)
- Applications are invited from all interested and eligible domain experts.
- Application form in prescribed format is attached. (Details are available on the link provided in the website- wrd.jharkhand.gov.in)
- Applicants may find this Notice inviting Applications on the website: wrd.jharkhand.gov.in under the link "**What's New!**"
- Experts currently working under Central Government Institutions, State Government Institutions, Public Sector Undertakings, Indian Institute of Technology, National Institute of Technology, Recognized Private Institutions, Reputed Independent Experts along with Retired Officers holding requisite qualifications may apply.
- Maximum age of the experts as on 31.07.2026 must not exceed 62 (sixty-two) years.
- The duly filled application form in prescribed format along with updated CVs including self-attested copies of proof of age, qualification and experience should be submitted through registered post/ speed post / courier / in person to the Office of Chief Engineer, Design, Master Planning and Hydrology, Jai Bhawan, Doranda, Ranchi-834002 OR it may also be submitted online on the email ID - cedesign-wrd-jhr@nic.in.
- All applications must be submitted to the above mentioned address / email ID by 07.08.2026 before 5:00 pm.
- The applicants must present the original documents for proof of age, qualification and experience when the Department may require during verification of prerequisite credentials.
- The date of interview will be intimated later. Applicant may appear in physical or virtual mode. The Applicants must intimate the undersigned beforehand about the mode in which they wish to attend the interview. The interview in physical mode will be conducted in Conference Room, 1st Floor, Nepal House Secretariat, Doranda, Ranchi. For those applicants who wish to attend the interview in virtual mode, a link will be sent through email to the candidates.
- The list of finally selected experts shall be uploaded on the website wrd.jharkhand.gov.in and each successful applicant shall also be intimated separately on their email.
- The cost of conveyance and logistics for submitting the form or attending interview shall not be borne by Water Resources Department, GOJ.

Chief Engineer
Design, Master Planning & Hydrology,
Jai Bhawan, Doranda, Ranchi- 834002

PR 386149 (Water Resource) 26-27 (D)

Andhra Pradesh State FiberNet Limited

Proposals are invited from interested agencies for the following RFPs:

- Selection of an Agency for Supply, Installation, Testing, and Commissioning of 2 Ton Inverter Split Air Conditioners (under buy back) for Andhra Pradesh State FiberNet Limited across Andhra Pradesh.
- RFP for Selection of an AMC Service Provider for UPS Systems, Precision Air Conditioning (PAC) Units, Smart Room Cooling (SRC) and DC Power System in APSFL Network.

Details of the RFPs and corrigenda may be downloaded from e-procurement platform tender.aeprocurement.gov.in.

No. : 5293PP/CL/ADVT/1/1/2021-22 **Sd/- Executive Director, APSFL**

एसजेवीएन लिमिटेड SJVN Limited

(ए जॉइंट वेंचर ऑफ गवर्न. ऑफ इंडिया & गवर्न. ऑफ ह.प.)
नवरत्न सीपीएसई A Navratna CPSE
CIN No. L40101HP1988GOI008409

CAREER OPPORTUNITIES IN A GROWING ORGANISATION

Advt. No. 127/2026 Closing Date: 26/08/2026

SJVN Limited invites applications from experienced professionals possessing full time regular bachelor degree in Electrical, Electrical & Electronics, Mechanical, Instrumentation & Control, Electronics & Instrumentation & Chemical Engineering and M.Sc. (Chemistry), having experience in Erection/ Commissioning and O&M of Thermal Power Plant for its fully owned subsidiary STPL, executing 1320 MW Buxar Thermal Power Project in Bihar.

IMPORTANT DATES

Activity	Date
Commencement of Online Registration for submitting Applications	05/08/2026 (10AM onwards)
Closing date for submitting applications through website	26/08/2026 (11:59PM)
Last date for receipt of application print out along with Payment receipt and certificates at SJVN Office	15/09/2026

For detailed advertisement, please visit CAREER page of SJVN website www.sjvn.nic.in. Candidates are required to apply online through SJVN website and then take the printout of the Application form (Preview) and send it alongwith payment receipt & relevant documents to SJVN.

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

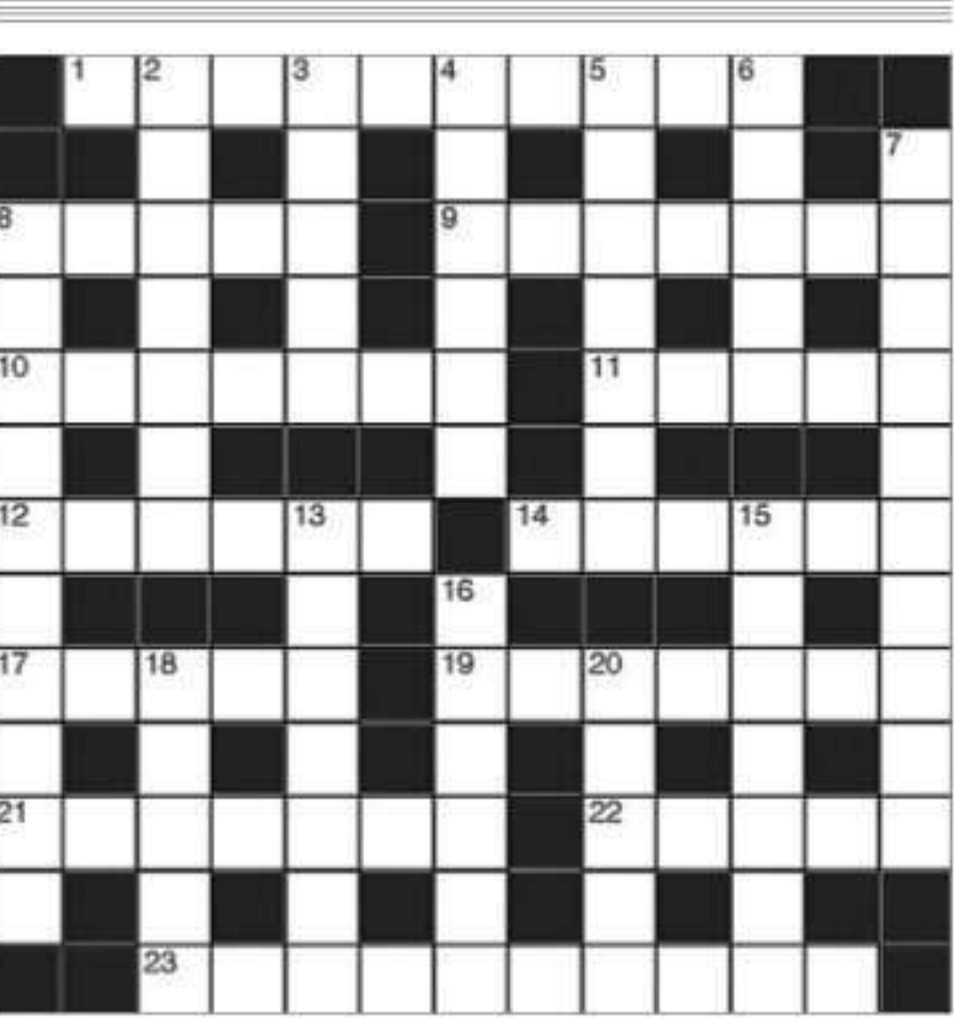
BORDER SECURITY FORCE

	HEAD CONSTABLE OM PRAKASH 21 BN BSF 03.05.1953 - 30.07.1993	Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Head Constable Om Prakash on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries in a fierce encounter with militants in Monapapai area, Badgam (J&K) and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.
	CONSTABLE DILEEP KUMAR BHAT 92 BN BSF 07.05.1971 - 30.07.1998	Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Dileep Kumar Bhat on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal injuries in counter -part firing in area of FDL Jamun, Baramulla (J&K) and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.
	CONSTABLE NEKSHA SINGH 24 BN BSF 01.07.1965 - 30.07.1996	Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Neksha Singh on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal injuries in an IED blast triggered by militants in Soura area, Srinagar (J&K) and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.
	CONSTABLE SHASHIKANT PANDEY 102 BN BSF 22.07.1984 - 30.07.2007	Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Shashikant Pandey on his Balidan Diwas. He made ultimate sacrifice while on operational duty in area of BOP I C Nagar, Gokulnagar (Tripura).
	CONSTABLE LABH SINGH 107 BN BSF 28.04.1967 - 30.07.1998	Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Labh Singh on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal injuries in counter-part firing in area of FDL Niti, Tangdhar (J&K) and later succumbed to his injuries.

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE

	Veer Balidani Constable Parshu Ram Yadav 128 Bn 15-11-1972 To 30-7-2001	DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Parshu Ram Yadav of 128 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice on 30 July 2001 after succumbing to injuries sustained while bravely combating insurgents during an operation in Kamrup district, Assam on the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
	Veer Balidani Constable Kantha Raju 28 Bn 21-4-1961 To 30-7-2003	DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Kantha Raju of 28 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating insurgents during an area domination duty in Manipur on 30 July 2003. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
	Veer Balidani Head Constable Pradeep Kumar Pandey 34 Bn 5-11-1963 To 30-7-2003	Veer Balidani Head Constable Daya Nidhi Behera 34 Bn 5-2-1967 To 30-7-2003
	Veer Balidani Constable N. Papaiah 34 Bn 10-5-1972 To 30-7-2003	Veer Balidani Constable Jagjeet Singh 34 Bn
	Veer Balidani Constable Narayan Lal 34 Bn	DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to the five bravehearts of 34 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating Maoists during an operation in Odisha on 30 July 2003. #CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.
	Veer Balidani Head Constable Pun	

CROSSWORD



- ACROSS
- 1 He has to arrange terms ahead (10)
- 8 ABC is different in computer language (5)
- 9 Heart irregularity perhaps causes a flap (7)
- 10 After getting in the beer he went round preaching (7)
- 11 Passionless disciple (5)
- 12 Eastern garment for the weekend, a loud colour (6)
- 14 Worshipped bustle and colour (6)
- 17 Highly praises some pastry (5)
- 19 He makes one cross at times (7)
- 21 Manage a medium agency (7)
- 22 Runs off original files (5)
- 23 A simple way to obtain poise (4,6)
- DOWN
- 2 Change of fee as needed to take off pressure (4,3)
- 3 There's money in education (5)
- 4 Flared possibly and burnt the cakes (6)
- 5 Tied up credit we hear (7)
- 6 Sense of proportion needed in arbitration (5)
- 7 Reproduces new plans of action (10)
- 8 Empty room for astronauts? (5,5)
- 13 Maintains a rising pressure (7)
- 15 Sailor comes up a rope — this one? (7)
- 16 Blamed for an uproar (6)
- 18 Criminal may be cleared in chase (5)
- 20 Spritely — that's the Spanish and French conclusion (5)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6053 ACROSS: 1 Hang up, 4 Talent, 9 Outside, 10 Sepia, 11 Audio, 12 Denmark, 13 Firm backing, 18 Wildcat, 20 Other, 22 Abide, 23 Realist, 24 Splash, 25 Blotto DOWN: 1 Hookah, 2 Noted, 3 Uniform, 5 Arson, 6 Explain, 7 Tracks, 8 Head waiters, 14 Ill will, 15 Know-all, 16 Tweaks, 17 Grotto, 19 Crews, 21 Hoist

JUMBLLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

_____ about oneself can also be a means to conceal oneself - Friedrich Nietzsche (7,4)

LPAIT

ARLNU

EORCHM

IINSKG

SOLUTIONS: Jumbled words are: LPAIT - TAPIL, ARLNU - UNLRA, EOCHRM - MCHRE, IINSKG - KSGNI. The answer to the quip is: TALKING MUCH.

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 2s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6395

		5	4				3	6	9
				9		8			
		3	8						
2		1			6	3			
3	9				1	2			
8	1			4		5			
				2	7				
		4		6					
9	1	2				3	5		

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6394

3	2	8	6	5	7	4	1	9	
9	4	7	1	3	2	6	5	8	
6	5	1	9	8	4	7	3	2	
8	6	2	7	9	3	5	4	1	
4	9	3	8	1	5	2	7	6	
7	1	5	4	2	6	8	9	3	
2	8	4	3	7	1	9	6	5	
1	7	9	5	6	8	3	2	4	
5	3	6	2	4	9	1	8	7	

HINDUSTAN PETROLEUM CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Maharatna Company)
Regd. Office: Petroleume House, 17, Jamshedji Tata Road, Churchgate, Mumbai – 400 020
Tel.: +91-22-22863900 Fax: +91-22-22872992
Email ID: corphq@hpcpl.in Website: www.hindustanpetroleum.com
CIN: L23201MH1952G01008858

PUBLIC NOTICE OF CONVENING THE 74TH ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING

Notice is hereby given that 74th Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Limited will be held on Wednesday, August 26, 2026 at 11:00 A.M. through VC/OVAM in compliance with the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013/ SEBI Regulations read with the various circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs in this regard. The Notice of the AGM and the Integrated Annual Report for FY 2025-26 will be sent by email to all those Members, whose e-mail addresses are registered with Company/Depository Participants (DPs). The same will also be available on the website of the Company at www.hindustanpetroleum.com and the website of NSDL at www.evoting.nsdl.com. Additionally, the same shall also be available on websites of the stock exchanges on which the securities of the Company are listed i.e. at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com. A letter providing the weblink for accessing the Integrated Annual Report will be sent to the Members whose email ID is not registered with the Company/DPs.

Members can cast their votes through e-voting facility provided through NSDL. The instructions for joining the AGM and the manner of remote e-voting or casting vote through the e-voting system during the AGM are provided in the Notice of the AGM. Members can register their email ID/Bank account mandate:
a. Demat holding- Register the details with respective DPs.
b. Physical holding- Register the details by sending the prescribed Form ISR-1 and other relevant Form(s) to the Company's RTA- MUFG Intime India Pvt Ltd. The details for updation of KYC including Email ID and Bank account are provided in the AGM Notice.

Place : Mumbai
Date : July 29, 2026

By the order of the Board
Rakesh Kumar Singh
Company Secretary

www.hindustanpetroleum.com

Government of Maharashtra
Public Works Department
Executive Engineer, Public Works
Division, Jalgaon Dist. Jalgaon
email-jalgaon.ee@mahapwd.com

E-Tender Notice No. 11 For 2026-2027

Online Tenders (e-tender) of **Works in "B-1"** form are invited by the Executive Engineer, P.W. Division, Jalgaon (Phone No. 0257-2227343) for and behalf of Government of Maharashtra, Electronic Tender Management System. <http://mahatenders.gov.in> from **Registered P.W.D. Contractor / Eligible Contractor who fulfil the Terms and Conditions of Tender.** The rights are reserve to reject all or any tender by **Superintending Engineer / Executive Engineer.** Conditional Tenders are not acceptable. The details can be viewed and downloaded online from dated **30/07/2026 to 06/08/2026 at 17.00 Hours** directly from the Government of Maharashtra e-tendering Portal <http://mahatenders.gov.in>. Pre-Tender conference for work sr. no.1 will be held on dated **03/08/2026 at 12.00 Hours** in the office of The Superintending Engineer, P.W. Circle, Jalgaon. Last date of tender submission is **06/08/2026 at 17.00 Hours**. This detailed tender notice for **02 (TWO) Road/Bridge/Building Works** are also available on portal www.mahapwd.com and on Notice Board in the office of Executive Engineer, Public Works Division, Jalgaon Dist. Jalgaon.

Sd/-
(R.D. Patil)
Executive Engineer,
Public Works Division, Jalgaon

dgipr/2026-27/1986

Government of India Department of Space
ISRO Propulsion Complex (IPRC)
Mahendragiri P.O., Tirunelveli District, Tamil Nadu- 627 133, India
CORRIGENDUM
28.07.2026

In continuation to the e-NIT notification published, the sale period for the below-mentioned work is extended up to 11-08-2026.

1. External services including Roads and Electrical works for Antenna structure at Spacecraft Control Centre (SCC), Palayamkottai, Tirunelveli (Phase-II) – SBC-3. (Electrical & Civil works) (No.: IPRC/CMG/TD/e-22/MW/CMP-05/2026-27; Dated:03.07.2026) (Estimated cost: ₹ 503.46 Lakhs)

For eligibility criteria and other details, interested tenderers may please refer to the detailed bilingual (Hindi-English) Notice Inviting Tenders (NIT) on the website <https://www.isro.gov.in/Tenders.html> and tender free view at <https://www.tenderwizard.com/isro>

Group Head, CMG

NORTHERN RAILWAY
proclamation requiring the attendance of the accused
See section 82 Cr.P.C.

A complaint has been made before me that the accused Montu S/o Chander Pal R/o Khasra No. 21/1, Qutub Vihar, Najafgarh, South West Delhi, Delhi-43 has committed an offence punishable under FIR No. 13/2025 Section 3 RP(UP) at Railway Protection Force Post New Delhi. It has been shown to my satisfaction that Montu has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid execution of the said warrant).

Therefore, it is hereby declared that the said accused Montu is required to appear before this Court or before me to answer the said complaint on or before 30.07.2026.

By Order
SH. Vaibhav Garg, First Class Magistrate,
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

2618/26

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

SOUTH EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-TENDER NOTICE

(i) Sl. No. **Tender Notice No. CEC-NGP-26-27-07**, Date: 23.07.2026 (Open e-Tender) (Two Packet System)
Sub: "Yard remodeling of Gondia, Pratapbagh, Birsola, Hatta Road Balaghat and other Engineering works in connection with Gondia-Jabalpur Doubling in Nagpur Division of South East Central Railway." **Tender Value:** ₹ 90,35,29,487.28, **EMD/Bid Security:** ₹ 1,80,70,600.00, **Cost of Tender Document:** NIL, **Completion Period of Work:** 24 (Twenty four) months from the date of acceptance letter.

Date & Time of Tender Closing: Up to 15.00 Hrs 21.08.2026, Date & Time of Tender Opening: 15.30 Hrs. on 21.08.2026

For further details related to tender document eligibility criteria and the complete details for the above work please contact office of the Chief Project Manager West Office/Construction/ S.E.C.Railway/Nagpur, Pin: 440001 or Dy. Chief Engineer (Con-III)/ S.E.C.Railway/Gondia refer on our website: www.ireps.gov.in

Dy. Chief Engineer (Con-III)/ SEC/R/Gondia

PAM/27/61

South East Central Railway

@secrail

अखण्ड जिला उपभोक्ता विवाद प्रतिलिखि
आयोग, जयपुर तृतीय, जयपुर।
नोटिस
अनर्गत धारा 13(1)(ए), उपभोक्ता अधिनियम
दमोदर लाव नगीनी च अन्य
वनाम
टाइटन कंपनी लि. च अन्य
परिवार अनर्गत धारा 35, उपभोक्ता संरक्षण
अधिनियम
परिवार संख्या 272/2025
ग्रेजिड:
Maheshwari Technical & Financial Quyyum
House 34 Palika Place Panchnath Road New
Delhi-110001
परिवारि मे आपके विकट संलग्न परिवार प्रस्तुत किया है। आप उक्त परिवार के संबंध में अपना लिखित जवाब / शपथ पत्र / दस्तावेज तीस दिन की अवधि में मंच में आवश्यक रूप से भिजवायें। परिवार की सुनवाई हेतु दिनांक 01/09/2026 को प्रतिनिधि/अधिकृत उपस्थित हों, अन्यथा आपको अनुपस्थिति में परिवार का निर्णय निम्नानुसार कर दिया जायेगा।
नोटिस आज दिनांक 21/07/2026 को जिला मंच की मुद्रा एवं मंच के आदेश से जारी किया गया। स्थानीय अखबार में सारा हो।
हस्ता./-
सिद्ध
जिला आयोग उपभोक्ता संरक्षण
तृतीय, जयपुर।

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
Letter No:- DRMC/AGRA/PARKING/e-AUCTION/2026 Dated:- 28.07.2026
E-Auction Notice

On Behalf of the President of India, The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager-North Central Railway-Agra invites E-Auction as per categories given as under :-
Category: Parking **Auction Catalogue No. : PARKNG-AGRA-MTJ**
Asset Details: Mathura Jn. Railway Station - Towards 2nd Entry, Circulating Area-Mixed (Two Wheelers and Four Wheelers)/Parking.
E-Auction Start Date and Time : Date: 13.08.2026 Time 13:00
E-Auction End Date and Time: 13.08.2026 Time 13:30
Note:- Prospective bidders are requested to visit E-Auction Leasing Module on IREPS website (www.ireps.gov.in). The Lot-wise details are available therein under the above mentioned Catalogue Number. **1731/26(AK)**

North central railways

@CPRONCR

www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTHERN RAILWAY
e-OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Engineer-I/Northern Railway, New Delhi for and on behalf of President of India invites e-tender on the prescribed form for the under noted work.

Name of work with location, cost of work and Earnest money	Elimination of Level Crossing No. 45 by Construction of LHS (6.0 x 5.0M) between Madlauda (MLDE)-Asan Railway stations on Jind - Panipat section (By Box Pushing Method) in the section of SSE/W/PNP under ADEN/PNP. Approx. Cost: Rs. 5,42,16,289.07/- Earnest Money: Rs. 10,84,300/-
Completion Period	12 Months
Date and Time of Submission of Tender and Opening of Tender	Upto 15.00 hrs on 21.08.2026 opening of e-tender after 15.00 hrs on 21.08.2026.
Website particulars, published tender, notice location etc. complete details of tender can be seen and website where the tender form can be downloaded	Above tender available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in
Similar nature of work	Construction of bridges/Limited High Subway with Box Pushing/Pipe Pushing Method.

No.: 128-W/260/Tender Notice/26-27/W-1 (NIT-33) Dated: 29.07.2026

2622/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
TENDER NOTICE

SR. No.	NAME OF BOARD/CORP./AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD CORP./AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	HARTRON	E-TENDER FOR SELECTION OF AN AGENCY FOR PROVIDING COMPREHENSIVE ANNUAL MAINTENANCE CONTRACT (CMC) SERVICES FOR DIGITAL LANGUAGE LABS DEPLOYED IN GOVERNMENT SCHOOLS ACROSS THE STATE OF HARYANA BY THE DEPARTMENT OF SCHOOL EDUCATION, HARYANA.	29.07.2026 14.08.2026	TENDER FEES RS. 12980.00/ EMD RS. 2,00,000/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01722971013 diharware.hartron@gmail.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in

No. 47640/HR

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): You'll enjoy hanging out with friends and interacting with clubs and organisations today. You might initiate something or spur others into a game of sports or some kind of competitive or physical activity. Tonight: Fun chatting.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): You're high-viz today, and it's a good thing, because people see you as proactive and ready to initiate something. This could relate to home and family, or it might be about social outings. Both of these areas are blessed for you today. Tonight: Be modest.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Travel and a chance to do something to expand your world will appeal to you today. Be a tourist in your own city. You've got lots of energy and drive today. Tonight: Learn something.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): On the whole, this is a favourable financial day for you. Something might occur behind the scenes that relates to shared property or someone else's wealth. It's also a lovely day for you to chat with others. Tonight: Check your finances.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Your enthusiasm might inspire others to take action today. They also might join you or join a club at your recommendation. You have influence over others today. Competitive sports and physical activities, will be a fun choice. Tonight: Be gracious.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): You can get a lot done today because you're motivated to do so. You'll also be charming and diplomatic in how you want to go about achieving your goals. Tonight: Work and get organised.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): This is a lovely day to socialise. Accept invitations to party. The arts, movies, the theater and sports will appeal. This is also a great day for fun activities with children. If you're attracted to someone romantically, you might make the first move. Tonight: Play.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Family discussions will be lively and dynamic today, which is fine for you, because you make such a great impression on others at this time. You might be successful in persuading someone to give their help. Tonight: Relax.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): This is a wonderful day for those of you in sales, marketing, teaching, acting and writing. You will be persuasive and convincing. You're enthusiastic about life today and ready to share your ideas. Tonight: Discussions.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Finances have your attention today. You might be interested in shopping or spending money. Be aware of the restrictions of the moon alert. You also might have some excellent moneymaking ideas. Learn something new. Tonight: Check your money.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Today you are confident. You might assume the role of leader, especially if you want to start something new or initiate some kind of action. It's good to know that funding and helpful resources from others will be available. Tonight: Friendships.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): You have a lot of inner drive to make some changes, perhaps improvements at home. Playful, romantic discussions might take place. Hugs! Tonight: You're admired.

Tamil Nadu Power Distribution Corporation Ltd.
Notice Inviting Tenders (E-Tendering Process)

Specification No.	Tender Inviting Authority	Name of the Work
M.237	CE/MM	Supply of LT Open Type MS 6 Way Pillar boxes
M.238	CE/MM	Supply of LT Mini Pillar boxes with fuse control

For details of works / Procurement / Due date of submission / Opening, viewing and downloading of e-tenders, please visit the websites www.tnpdcl.org, www.tenders.tn.gov.in, www.tntenders.gov.in
DIPR/2402/Tender/2026

NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE (Through e-tendering)

Name of work with its location	Provision of digital sign language information system for persons with disabilities.
App. Cost of the work (₹)	₹ 49,56,141.62/- only
Earnest Money Deposit (₹)	₹ 99,100.00/- only
Address of the office	Senior Divisional Signal & Telecom Engineer-C, Northern Railway, 3rd Floor, Annex-1, DRM office, New Delhi-110055.
Date & Time for upload the tender / closing of tender	Tender uploading/closing date & time: 20.08.2026 up to 15.00 hrs.
Website particular & notice board location where complete details of the tender can be seen etc.	See the Northern Railway website www.ireps.gov.in & Notice board at S&T branch, 3rd Floor, DRM office, State Entry Road, New Delhi-110055.

Tender No. 558-Sig/16/Tele-OT-1044
Dated : 29.07.2026

2621/2026

Serving Customers With A Smile

Punjab State Power Corporation Limited
(Regd. office PSEB Head Office, The Mall, Patiala)
Corporate Identity Number U40109PB10SGC033813
Website: www.pspcl.in (Contact No. 96461-36447)

(Short Term Tender Notice)

Tender Enquiry No: 09/ASR/GCD/TS/PSFCL/2026-27 Dated: 29.07.2026

Addl. S.E. Grid Construction Division, Amritsar has invited e-tender for out sourcing work of Erection, Testing and Commissioning of Additional 80, 66kV bays along with complete bay equipment's on partial turnkey mode under RDSS scheme under Grid Construction Division Amritsar, under End Const. Circle, Ludhiana".

For more details please refer to website <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in> from 30.07.2026, 5:00 pm onwards.

Note: Corrigendum and addendum if any will be published online at <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in> only.

No. 13784/PB C 753/26

Government of Maharashtra
Office of the Commissioner of Police, Mumbai
Notice for Tender

Selection of Agency for sweeping, cleaning and dusting arrangement in the office of the Commissioner of Police, Mumbai

Office of the Commissioner of Police, Mumbai, Government of Maharashtra, invites proposals from reputed and experienced companies to participate in the competitive bidding process for selection of agency for sweeping, cleaning and dusting arrangement in the office of the Commissioner of Police, Mumbai.

For the detailed Tender document, interested bidders should visit GeM (Government e-Marketplace) with Bid number GEM/2026/B/7832741.

Tender submission would be online and the deadline to submit the proposals is 07.08.2026 upto 18.00.00

Sd/-
(Vasant Jadhav)
Dy. Commissioner of Police (HQ-1)
Mumbai

DGIPR/2026-27/1997

dgipr/2026-27/1986

epaper.indianexpress.com

New Delhi

Mr YouTube to Kenyan icon: Yego's Commonwealth farewell

Rio Olympics medallist opens up on his journey, friendship with Neeraj and the rise of javelin throw

Nihal Koshie
New Delhi, July 29

JULIUS YEGO is an Olympic silver medalist and a former World Champion. However, the most memorable reception he received on returning home to Kenya was after winning gold at the 2014 Commonwealth Games in Glasgow.

The victory in Scotland's largest city was special because it put Kenya on the javelin map of the world. The country erupted in joy; Yego got unforgettable memories—including a helicopter ride to his village in the Rift Valley. "After the Commonwealth Games, I had a huge reception back home. Even my school, Kapsabet High School, had a big reception. A helicopter took me to my village (Cheptonon). There was a huge crowd in my village. They wanted to see me and also see a helicopter landing in the village. I was young back then; people didn't expect me to win the Commonwealth Games gold in javelin. It was a big story," Yego told *The Indian Express* from Glasgow.

There was no electricity in his village and no tarred roads, but Cheptonon had a champion athlete. "Even now, in some areas of my village there is no electricity. But we do not have a water problem because there are streams. Rich people have tap water, but others drink stream water because they believe it is clean," the 37-year-old said. The roads are still basic. "There are small roads but not tarmac roads. I moved to Eldoret for my training, but I still go back to my village," Yego said.

Yego's stardom continued to grow in Kenya, the East Afri-



2014 champion Julius Yego will be one of the favourites as javelin gets underway on Thursday. REUTERS

can nation known for its distance runners, when he won a World Championship gold in Beijing a year later. He was the first from Kenya to become a world champion in a field event. A hip-hop musician, Khaligraph Jones, made a song titled 'Yego' to celebrate his achievements. Like Yego, the song is still popular.

"I am a big football fan, and I support Arsenal. Sometimes, when I go to social places, people see me, and they play the song and have fun. I like it because it reminds me of what I have achieved," he said.

Even before social media became a thing, a young Yego, without a coach, was on YouTube learning how to throw the javelin. When he travelled outside Kenya for the first time—for the 2010 Commonwealth Games in Delhi—he didn't have a coach, but he had YouTube to fall back on. Once he became famous, the moniker

“Neeraj is a good friend. I have a good relationship with him. We try to make our sport friendly. If you don't win, then your friend will win, then you clap for him. And when I win, they clap for me.”

JULIUS YEGO
ON HIS RELATION WITH NEERAJ

Mr. YouTube stayed.

"It (*YouTube*) is used more now. Maybe, in the beginning it was to know what you have to do, but now you can watch and correct yourself as well. I get lots of questions from India, I do respond and give comments when I have time on

ing, 'we can do it'. Keshorn Walcott (Trinidad and Tobago) won in 2012 (Olympics), but nobody expected it. I won in 2015 (World Championships). Anderson Peters from Grenada won. Neeraj (Chopra) has won. It shows the sport has changed and it has gone global. We changed the thinking of the sport, 'yes, everybody can win.'"

The competition at the Commonwealth Games will be tough with Chopra, Olympic Champion Arshad Nadeem from Pakistan, Sri Lanka's Ramesh Tharanga Pathirage and Yego in the fray, but the Kenyan says the camaraderie in javelin is strong.

"Yes, Neeraj is a good friend. I have a good relationship with him. We try to make our sport friendly. If you don't win, then your friend will win, then you clap for him. And when I win, they clap for me. When your friend is down, you cheer him up. Put a smile on your face. We talk normally when we are in the competition, maybe correct each other, like say 'maybe do this'. You compete of course, but after the competition the friendship remains."

Yego hopes to leave Glasgow, his Commonwealth swansong, with a medal. "I won't be competing in India (in 2030). If I win this championship, I will be so happy. I will say bye-bye Commonwealth Games and I will see you next time in some other capacity. It has been fun and amazing to compete at the Commonwealth Games."

Working as an inspector of police in the Directorate of Criminal Investigation, Yego is also an anti-doping crusader. Like India, Kenya too has a doping problem, and Yego wants to help to clean up the mess. "I posted a video a few days ago saying it is a historic moment (fifth CWG) for me to be at the Games and in Glasgow again. My message was to compete clean, respect your opponent, and it is ok to lose if you compete fairly."

The elder statesman of javelin wants to make a mark on the field in Glasgow and make a difference off the field.

Back at CWG, Neeraj faces world-class field in chase for gold



2018 Gold Coast CWG was Neeraj Chopra's first-ever major medal. PTI

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 29

NEERAJ CHOPRA is back at the Commonwealth Games (CWG) after missing the previous edition in Birmingham due to a groin injury. There is a special connect between Chopra and the CWG because he won his first major senior international medal, a gold, at the 2018 Commonwealth Games in Gold Coast.

Back then, the venue for track and field was the 40,000-seater Carrara Stadium. For the ongoing truncated edition, it's the 11,000-seater Scotstoun Stadium. But the significance of Glasgow will remain, given that Chopra is aiming to win his first medal since winning his own event - the Neeraj Chopra Classic a year ago.

Return from layoff

"The 2018 Commonwealth Games was my first senior competition, and it was a good start because I had won gold. I have focused on technique, and I want to execute that well. I don't have any target, but I want to give my 100 percent, and that will be my aim," Chopra said after arriving in Glasgow for his event.

On return from a nine-month injury layoff after last year's World Championships, Chopra competed at the Doha Diamond League and finished fourth with 85.69 metres. He didn't stretch himself in the Qatari capital but will have to do so because he faces a field of strong, experienced competitors. The challenges can come in many forms if the top throwers advance from the qualification round on Thursday to the final the next day.

The unpredictability of Pakistan's Olympic Champion Arshad Nadeem, the resurgent spirit of World Champion Keshorn Walcott, the rise of Sri Lanka's Ramesh Tharanga Pathirage, the class of Anderson Peters from Grenada and the experience of Julius Yego make this a class field.

Add to this Chopra, a two-time Olympic and double World Championship medalist, and the CWG line-up looks truly world-class. Two other Indians are also in the fray - Yash Vir Singh and Rohit Yadav. The latter is third on this year's list with 87.05 metres, while the former threw a personal best of 83.72 metres.

But given his experience, class and big-competition temperament, Chopra is a

“The 2018 CWG was my first senior competition, and it was a good start because I had won gold. I have focused on technique, and I want to execute that well. I don't have any target, but I want to give my 100 percent.”

NEERAJ CHOPRA,
ON HIS GRADUAL COMEBACK

medal prospect. Ahead of the Games, he's been posting training videos on Instagram with captions like 'locked in', 'pushing with everyday', 'getting stronger slowly and steadily'. But how well prepared he is to push himself to the limit if competitors produce big throws will be the key for a podium finish.

Pathirage threat

As always, there is the subplot of an India vs Pakistan rivalry with Nadeem, but Sri Lanka's Pathirage could be the one to watch out for from the sub-continent. The former fast bowler is the only thrower to go over 90 metres this season with 92.62m at the Diamond League in Rome last month. Pathirage also finished first at the Doha Diamond League with a throw of 88.68 metres. Nadeem had a low-key start in Luzern, Switzerland, managing to throw just 78.47. For Chopra, his only event this year till now, the Doha Diamond League, was about testing how ready he was for competition.

"My body is better but not yet back to the old Neeraj. There was no pressure (in Doha), so I didn't put extra effort because I just wanted to participate. I wanted one good throw. I got a good throw of 85.69 metres. I felt it was good because I was not throwing this distance in training. As I have come back from injury... earlier I wouldn't have accepted a fourth-place position or the 85-metre throw. But I know from what situation I have made a comeback. Step-by-step I have to progress. And for the kind of preparation I had, the throw was good," Chopra had said after Doha.

He may need a bigger throw to finish on the podium on Friday.

Harjinder 'lands' second successive weightlifting medal

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, July 29

SOME MORE farmland.

That was the thought that came to Harjinder Kaur's mind immediately after she won the Commonwealth Games silver medal in the women's 69kg weightlifting event.

The medal was an improvement on the one the girl from Punjab had clinched in the 71kg category at the previous edition in Birmingham. Since then, her marginal farming family had moved to a new house and bought some farmland in their village, and Harjinder's father Sahib Singh may interpret her latest achievement in terms of what it could provide the family materially. "We had marginal farmland and the income was

augmented by selling milk from the six buffaloes we owned. The bronze medal won in Birmingham landed me a job as an income tax inspector, apart from cash awards. I wanted to upgrade my medal here and now I will get some more farmland for my father," Harjinder told *The Indian Express*.

Harjinder lifted a total of 227 kg - 101kg in snatch and 126kg in clean and jerk - to finish behind Canadian Charlotte Simoneau (240kg—108kg and 132kg).

With the family owning six buffaloes, Harjinder got milk and home-made paneer. She would often help her father operate the chaff-cutting machine, and the strong physique came handy when Harjinder started playing kabaddi at Government Girls School at



Harjinder Kaur. PTI

Nabha, where she would commute daily by bicycle. She was then selected to play for Punjab University, Patiala where 1990 Commonwealth Games weightlifting champion Paramjit Sharma took her under his wings. "She was healthy and I knew I could groom her into a good weight-

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RG0bmjlMzg1

lifter. I put her initially in tug of war teams before starting weightlifting. Her mother sold her jewellery and the family took loans to support her training, which made Harjinder determined to excel in her sport," he told *The Indian Express*.

It was in 2019 that brother Pritpal Singh got a contractual job in the PWD department and with Harjinder too getting a scholarship from Punjabi University, the family's financial situation improved and she could focus solely on weightlifting.

Battling injuries

Last year, Harjinder suffered a wrist injury while a back problem that she suffered in 2019 also aggravated. She moved to the 69kg class and won the

bronze at the Commonwealth Championship in Ahmedabad with a mark of 222kg. Despite winning her second successive CWG medal on Tuesday, Harjinder knows she has work to do in the coming years.

"I have had some issues in my clean and jerk technique, and have been working on them for a few years. (National coach) Vijay Sharma sir has been working on getting some technical flaws rectified and the aim is to improve further," she said.

Meanwhile, mother Kuldeep knows what Harjinder would demand when she gets home from Glasgow. "She always asks me to cook vegetables like pumpkin, which she doesn't get to eat at hostels or abroad."

Animesh wins heat, reaches 200m semis

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 29

NATIONAL RECORD holder in the 200m, Animesh Kujur clocked 20.46s in the heats to book his berth in the semifinals of the event at the 2026 Commonwealth Games.

Running in the fourth heat, Animesh was up against 100m champion Emmanuel Eseme of Cameroon and South African Myuvo Moss, but came out flying with his season's best and topped the heat.

Overall, Animesh finished seventh in the heats as 16 sprinters progressed to the semifinals with eight other getting byes.

His coach Martin Owens had thought Animesh would have to go quicker to advance.

"It was a quality display from Animesh today. A fine performance by him as I thought it would take a quicker time to qualify for the semis. He is in very good shape and



Animesh Kujur clocked 20.46s to book his berth in the semifinals of the 200m sprint. INSTAGRAM

we are looking forward to the semis. It will be very tough as it is a very high quality field," the Briton said in a press note.

Owens believed that defeating Esseme, who won the 100m gold medal the previous day, would give the Indian

“Animesh will get a lot of confidence by beating the 100m champion from this edition today. It is another feather in his cap and I am pleased with his display.”

MARTIN OWENS
ANIMESH KUJUR'S COACH

confidence. "Animesh will get a lot of confidence by beating the 100m champion from this edition today. It is another feather in his cap and I am pleased with his display. It is good to check the first box but we're now looking forward to the next stage," he said.

Animesh will face Olympian Israel Ikoni of Nigeria and Jevaughn Powell of Jamaica

in his semifinal. He is placed in the first lane in the semifinal as against his preferred outer lanes.

"We like the outer lanes, really. The curves are a little bit kinder. If you are on the inner lanes, you can watch what everybody else is doing and can follow what's going on. So that's an advantage there. But people tend to run a little wider subconsciously on the inner lane. Some people just like the easier curve. Animesh prefers lane 6 or 7," Owens had told *The Indian Express* earlier.

Toor, Gill qualify

Veteran Indian shot putter Tajinderpal Singh Toor and youngster Samardeep Singh Gill booked their berths in the men's shot put final.

While Toor achieved the direct qualification mark of 20m by throwing 20.14m, Samardeep recorded a best throw of 19.95m.

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 29

INDIAN BOXERS went six for six at the Commonwealth Games on Wednesday, with each win ensuring a medal for the country in Glasgow. Sakshi Choudhary, Arundhati Choudhary, Sachin Siwach, Ankush Yadav, Narender Berwal and Jaismine Lamborija all booked their spots in the semifinals of their respective categories. Ten Indian boxers are now in the semifinals, a result that has gone along expected lines at a tournament devoid of tough Asian competition.

Sakshi defeated Northern Ireland's Caitlin Fryers in the women's 51kg quarterfinal while Arundhati beat New Zealand's Morgan Henderson in the 70kg quarterfinal. Sachin got the better of Botswana's Treasure Moremi in the men's 60kg bout while Ankush demolished Seychelles' Jade Micock in the 80kg quarterfinal. Narender also as-



Sakshi Choudhary defeated Northern Ireland's Caitlin Fryers. PTI

sured India of a medal after edging past Samoa's Michael Seko in the men's 90+kg quarterfinal.

The perfect performance followed a Tuesday when Jadumani Singh, Preeti Pawar and Priya Ghanghas also assured themselves of medals after winning their quarterfinal bouts. Lovlina Borgohain had confirmed one for herself without landing a punch.

Ankush was a class above his opponent and repeatedly beat Micock with his superior speed, movement and intensity. The Indian won 30-26 on one judge's card and 30-27 on the remaining four. Earlier in the day, making full use of her height and reach advantage, Sakshi, who has moved down from the 54kg weight class, dictated the contest from the opening bell, keeping

Fryers at bay with accurate jabs and straight punches.

The Irish boxer tried to unsettle Sakshi with constant aggression, throwing punches in volume, but the Indian remained composed, evading most of the attacks before responding with cleaner, more effective combinations.

The bout featured frequent clinches as both boxers got tangled at close quarters, even tumbling to the canvas during one exchange in Round 2. But Sakshi never lost control of the contest. Despite Fryers' relentless pressure, Sakshi controlled the distance brilliantly, using her superior footwork and ringcraft to dictate the pace from start to finish and seal a victory.

Late in the day, Jaismine, the reigning world champion, survived a cagey bout with England's Elise Glynn. The judges scored the contest 4-1, with the bout going down the wire into the final round.

(With agency inputs)

